Hero

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/26898565.

Rating:
Teen And Up Audiences

Archive Warning:
No Archive Warnings Apply

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F/F

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

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Adora/Catra (She-Ra), Bow/Glimmer (She-Ra), Perfuma/Scorpia (She-Ra), Mermista/Sea Hawk (She-Ra)

Characters:
Catra (She-Ra), Adora (She-Ra), Glimmer (She-Ra), Bow (She-Ra), Bow's Fathers (She-Ra), Frosta (She-Ra), Entrapta (She-Ra), Scorpia (She-Ra), Perfuma (She-Ra)

Additional Tags:
Shadow Weaver | Light Spinner (She-Ra)'s A+ Parenting, Fluff and Angst, Emotional Hurt/Comfort, The Fright Zone (She-Ra), Post-Canon, Catradora is CANON, Peace Accords, Life in the Horde (She-Ra), Reunions, Weddings, Post-War, Adora is in Love with Catra (She-Ra), Catra is in Love with Adora (She-Ra), Everyone Needs Therapy, The Horde as a Sovereign Nation, War is Hell but Peace is Hard, no beta we die like my faith in humanity, Implied/Referenced Rape/Non-con, Implied/Referenced Child Abuse

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Part 2 of Unchained Heart, Part 4 of Tell Me Everything

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by Paganaidd

Summary

Prime is gone. The War is over. This is how the Peace begins.

But, how are the citizens of the Fright Zone coping?
Where do they fit into the New Etheria?
Spoilers for S5

A Prequel to Casting Out Shadows.

The End

Chapter Summary

The day of victory over Horde Prime.

Fright Zone

The Day of Victory on Etheria

In the cool hollow under two collapsed beams, Felina crouched, hiding in the darkness from the madness outside. She'd been here since before dawn, and it was late afternoon now. She could see people's feet as they passed; there were more people in the street than she'd seen in months. Since Horde Prime had taken over the Fright Zone, the only people in the street were the chipped and the clones. They were always quiet and orderly.

What was happening right now was anything but orderly. People shouted and screamed. Some of the feet walked by, but just as many ran.

After so long playing hide and seek with the invaders, something had changed last night. Agatha had shaken Felina and the other cadets in her cadre awake. "There's a fight starting," Agatha spoke softly as she pulled on her armor. "It looks like someone's figured out how to get the chips off of people."

"Are we going to join them?" Mike whispered. He was the biggest of them and always the first to run into combat, whether simulated or real.

The old veteran shook her head. "No, not right now. I want to do some reconnaissance. We don't know what's happening. But we have to be ready." She grinned at them reassuringly. "If this turns out to be THE fight, we'll be in it."

The massive step of a bot in the corridor outside their hiding place signaled all of them to silence. Tensely they waited to see if it

would move on or try to open the locked door.

Boom!

Something impacted the door, and all the cadets jumped to their feet. “Go! Stay out of sight. I’ll find you later!” Agatha hissed, powering up her weapon and pointing at the door. The youngsters grabbed shoes, jackets, backpacks, and the few weapons they had (mostly rocks and sticks at this point) and fled through the tunnel that led to the back door. They scattered when they reached the outside of the building.

People were running in every direction. Formerly chipped soldiers were turning on clones, firing on bots.

Felina grabbed her metal bar and her jacket; she didn’t need shoes. She wasn’t very big, but she was fast and agile; she’d discovered over the past few weeks that the clones wouldn’t see her if she snuck up behind them. Her bare feet were soundless. She took out four clones and reached one of their spider-holes when fire, as green as a laser shot, exploded from the ground.

The booming voice of Horde Prime spoke through the spire, but Felina didn’t catch what he said. She fell to the ground covering her ears and closing her eyes. She ducked into the hollow in the madness of fear, knowing only that she needed to get away from whatever was about to happen.

And then, just as quickly as the green light erupted from the ground, it went out.

Silence fell over the Fright Zone, a terrible breath-holding pause. Felina wished that she wasn’t alone at what she was sure was the end of all things.

But, the world hadn’t ended. The silence gave way to shouts and shrieks. Since then, the sound of weapons fire stopped, and the yelling sounded less angry. The light outside seemed brighter than usual. Unfamiliar scents tantalized her. Felina could not bring herself to leave her safe hole to find out what happened. It was

what Agatha had ordered (it had nothing to do with being scared). They'd drilled this for weeks, scoping out designated hiding and rendezvous points. The trouble was, she'd been here for many hours already, and she was hungry, thirsty, and tired.

This particular hiding spot wasn't great for figuring out what was going on; she could only see the feet of passers-by.

The cadets in Felina's cadre were a fortunate few; everyone else in the Fright Zone was chipped. The twenty-four cadets had escaped so far by following Agatha's orders precisely. The first order was: never move during the day.

If Agatha hadn't found her by nightfall, Felina knew she would follow the order to make her way to the primary rendezvous. Agatha would be there (or left some sign of where to look for her), or she was dead. At that point, it would be up to Felina, Lee, and Mike to round up the surviving cadets, find some rations, and scope out new hiding places.

Doing her best to ignore her hunger and thirst, the cadet curled up with her tail wrapped tightly around her, settling down to continue her long wait.

Dust motes danced in the afternoon light. Hot. Far too bright. It made her eyes gritty. It was so much more comfortable if she let her eyes fall shut. Cool, calm drowsiness beckoned and she followed willingly.

Sometime in her exhausted sleep, deep purrs insinuated themselves into her dreaming. The sound of some presence that wanted to meet her, to help her. A tingly, tickly scent wafted past. Not anything she'd ever scented before but it sang of *safety* and *love.* Warm fur and muscular bulk pressed into her side.

For a moment, her sleeping self soaked in the rare comfort of being a child, protected by a loving adult.

Coming more awake, Felina realized the scent, fur, and muscles were real, not just a comforting dream.

Opening her eyes, the girl registered a huge blue and white creature large enough to swallow her in one gulp. She let out an involuntary shriek, lashing out. Hot flesh parted beneath her claws. The thing gave way as she dashed out towards the light. Two legs blocked the low, narrow opening but Felina just slammed right into them, knocking whoever it was over.

Felina meant to keep right on going, but the owner of the legs was faster than anyone the cadet had ever fought. A hand grabbed Felina's tail and pulled her back. The cadet hadn't picked up the metal bar when she fled the cave. Instead, she used her claws, aiming for the assailant's face.

The stranger wasn't much larger than Felina, but they were incredibly fast. They caught Felina's wrists and held them. "Stand down!" a woman's voice ordered.

The girl struggled to rip herself away, twisting in that iron grip, using the claws on her feet to scratch at the woman and biting anything she could reach.

The attacker growled and threw herself on top of the girl, pinning her arms and body. "That's enough!" she barked, "Stand down! Do not make me hurt you! Melog! A little help?"

A warm, heavy, weight pressed Felina's legs and lower body to the ground. The woman held onto her wrists and stayed well away from her teeth.

"Are you going to chip me, now?" Felina gasped out, closing her eyes tight against the horror of the idea. That thought and the sensation of being trapped sent her mind into a panicked spin. Her breath came in short sobbing gasps, and she felt sick even as she continued her useless struggle.

"Hey! Calm down! It's okay! I'm not here to chip you. I swear!" The woman sounded horrified. "Listen. Just...calm down. I'm on your side."

Felina went limp and opened her eyes. She stared into two mismatched cat's eyes, one blue and one yellow. The woman wore what could have been a modified Horde uniform. Her short hair was brown, as were her cat's ears.

"I'm going to let you go now. I just want to talk. Okay?"

Felina nodded.

Slowly the woman moved off of Felina and let go of her wrists. The weight on Felina's legs moved off too.

Gingerly the cadet sat up. To her shame, tears still leaked from her eyes. She shut them tight, appalled by her weakness.

"Oh, hey." The woman moved to sit next to her and put her arm around her shoulder. It seemed the large presence from her dream pressed into her from the other side.

Inexplicably, that seemed to make the pressure in Felina's chest worse, and sobs erupted from her throat.

"Shh. It's okay now." The woman said softly. "Are you hurt?"

"N-no." Felina gasped out, trying to get a hold of herself. Obviously, the woman would assume she was injured. The only reason for these sorts of waterworks would be a broken arm, at least.

Finally, getting a grip, Felina opened her eyes. She saw that the warm presence was the colossal animal that had frightened her from her hole in the first place. She squeaked in alarm and shrank towards the woman. "What is that?"

"That's Melog. They're my friend," the woman replied. "They won't hurt you. Have you been in there all day?"

The creature regarded her with eyes that gleamed with an eerie blue light. It mewled and purred. As in her dream, the deep rumble spoke of peace and safety.

“Yes, ma’am.” Felina nodded, tearing her eyes away from the giant catlike creature with an effort. “My orders were to stay out of sight. I was waiting until dark to move,” she managed to say.

”Good job, cadet.” The woman shifted, and Felina tensed, ready to move away so the woman could reclaim her personal space. “It’s all right,” the woman said, not withdrawing her arm. “I just want to grab my bag. Here. You have this. Drink the whole bottle--you look like you need it.”

Two whole ration bars and a bottle of water came out of the leather bag.

“Thank you!” Felina grabbed both the bars and the water--it was more food than she’d eaten in days. She drank half the bottle and scarfed down the first ration bar in about thirty seconds. She tucked the other one into her jacket pocket for later. She started to put the half bottle of water into her other pocket when the woman stopped her.

“I told you to drink the whole thing, cadet.” The woman raised her eyebrow. “I’m not having you pass out on me. The best place to carry water is in your gut.”

“Yes, ma’am. Sorry, ma’am.” Felina dutifully drank the whole thing and handed back the empty bottle. Unfortunately, she wouldn’t have any water to take back to her cadre.

“You been on short rations for a while, cadet?”

“Yes, ma’am.” With food and water in her stomach Felina felt solid again, able to pull herself together. She took a look around.

A riot of green vegetation punctuated with flowers had grown all over the road and buildings. The sky was blue and clear. Along the street, people gathered in boisterous crowds. They laughed, danced, wept, and hugged each other.

“What...what happened?” she asked the woman, astonished.

The woman smiled broadly. “We got rid of Horde Prime and...well...it’s a whole new world.”

“Hey, Catra?” A tinny voice said and Felina realized that the woman wore a Horde communicator badge.

The woman tapped it to reply. “Catra here. What’s up?”

Catra?

“Just wondering where you went. I thought you’d be back by now.”

“Sorry. I got sidetracked. Melog found a stray cadet that’s been hiding all day. I’ll get her where she needs to go and meet you at camp?”

“Sounds good. And Catra? I really...um...” The person on the other end hesitated, then said, “can’t wait to see you.”

The Catra?

“Me too.” The woman turned away as if to block Felina from hearing and said very quietly into the communicator something that sounded almost exactly like, “love you.”

Felina must have heard wrong.

The person on the other end giggled. “Love you too.”

There was only one Catra that Felina had ever heard of, but this couldn’t be THE Catra, could it?

But... how many cat people with mismatched eyes were there in the Horde? (Felina knew exactly how many, from her government class).

“Force Captain!" The girl scrambled to her feet. "I’m sorry." She snapped off the best salute she had in her. "We...we thought you were dead!”

“Yeah. Me too.” Force Captain Catra smirked lopsidedly up at her, showing one fang, “I got better though.”

The animal chirped and mewled while Felina stood rigidly until Hordak's second rose to her feet and returned the salute.

“At ease, cadet,” Catra said, more gently than Felina would have her capable of. Felina had o “Now, where were you supposed to rendezvous with your squad?”

“We were supposed to meet at warehouse number four near the munitions plant.”

“That’s a little bit of a hike, but it’s on my way. You want a ride, cadet?”

“Force Captain?” No vehicle was in sight

“Come on.” The Force Captain mounted the animal and offered her hand to Felina, “Melog can take us both.”

Somehow the creature became bigger; big enough so that Felina could clumsily scramble onto its back behind the woman.

“Hold on.”

“Th-thank you, Force Captain.” Felina stuttered, not sure what she was supposed to hold on to.

Catra solved this when she took both the cadet’s hands and drew them around her waist. “That way, Melog,” she said to the animal as if it understood her.

Catra directed Melog towards the munitions plant, grateful that the big cat moved so quickly and that this was their last errand. If the cadet’s commander wasn’t at the munitions plant, Catra would just take the girl back to camp with her and figure it out tomorrow. She wanted to get back to Adora.

After their spectacular victory at dawn, and a hurried brainstorming session with the Rebel leaders, Glimmer, Scorpia, and Hordak had used Prime's communication net to announce the *joint* victory of the Etherian Horde and the Princess Alliance over Horde Prime's forces. Catra had suggested this (she was shocked when Bow and King Micah backed her up) so that the Horde forces wouldn't feel honor-bound to resume hostilities towards the Princesses.

On the day of Horde Prime's invasion, Hordak and Catra's forces had been scattered out of the Fright Zone on their disastrous final push to conquer the Princesses. Fortunately, when it became clear that Horde Prime's forces had been unbiasedly destructive to every Etherian, no matter what uniform they wore, many Horde and Rebel Commanders had joined forces in an uneasy alliance. Attributing the victory to both armies solved a lot of problems(for now, at least).

It was decided that Catra would be the one to scout out what was happening in the Fright Zone, so her day had been spent speaking to every officer she could find, spreading the word for all fighters to stand down.

Fewer people were left than she hoped, and every single one of them had been chipped. They were mostly support staff who were left behind when Hordak's main forces were deployed. But everyone in the Fright Zone was trained in combat and the freed Etherian Horde made short work of the clones and bots once Entrapta's signal had disrupted the hive mind. Now with the fighting over, every person Catra spoke to sported the same glassy, shocked, thousand-yard stare.

The first officer she'd found was a grizzled old lizard who challenged her as she and Melog paced the familiar streets, calling out for survivors.

"Who's there?" He demanded in the language of the Lizard-folk, holding nothing but a great metal club as a weapon.

Giddy from the events of the morning, she almost laughed, then she pulled herself together enough to snap, “Force Captain Catra.”

He stepped closer, looked down into her eyes. “Force Captain Catra?” he breathed as though he saw a ghost, “Force Captain Catra?” Slowly and stiffly he saluted her. She could almost hear his joints creak. “It’s true, then? Did we...win?”

Catra returned the salute. “We won,” she said, not bothering to keep the smile from her face.

“Horde Prime?”

“He can’t come back. He’s dead. We killed him.” And then the laughter bubbled up again, but Catra didn’t bother to try to push it down. “He’s dead and he can never use us again.”

The soldier gaped and then he started to laugh too. After a moment, tears rolled down his face and he slowly sat on the nearest grass-covered rock. “Wait...I saw you...You were chipped?” he asked in the barest whisper.

Catra covered her mouth with her hand. She had not meant to let that slip. She wished the old officer wasn’t so quick on the uptake.

Melog nudged her with his nose. “*It would help your people to know you suffered alongside them*,” they mewled.

“Yes.” Catra leaned on the rock next to the man and crossed her arms, shrinking into herself. The points of her claws sunk into her upper arms, the pain steadying her so that her voice barely shook when she admitted it. “He captured and chipped Hordak and me.” She took in a long slow breath. “It’s really rough the first few days after you get unchipped. But it will get better.” Slowly she opened her eyes to meet the soldier’s gaze. “I promise.”

The soldier covered his face with his hands and moaned. Sitting, he was almost the same height as she was standing. Cautiously, Catra patted his shoulder at Melog’s urging. After a moment he

took his hands away from his face to look at her. Whatever he saw made him reach out.

Before she could evade him, he wrapped his arms around her and hugged her hard. “I saw you.” He repeated. “Over and over in *his* mind. Saw you kneeling at his feet.”

Catra felt all the blood drain out of her face and she swayed in the soldier’s embrace. “You saw that?” She gasped. It made sense, but she hadn’t thought of it. Inwardly she cringed. Everyone would know...everything. She tensed, wondering how bad she looked through Prime’s eyes. She could *never* show her face again if everyone who had been chipped had seen her humiliation and terror.

“You were so frightened.” Catra shrank back, cursing to herself, but the man wouldn’t let go and kept talking into her hair. “He was so angry at you. He wanted you to be afraid and you were. I could see through him. I could hear your heartbeat and smell your terror,” the lizard man growled and backed off to look her in the face with an expression akin to awe. “And yet...you *laughed* at him. And that one memory was like a stone in his boot. Such a small thing...not even a real threat but he could *not* stop thinking about it. And then, you escaped. He kept going over and over in his mind, how it could have happened.” His rough voice deepened with emotion. “It...gave me...us...hope.”

For a moment, he closed his eyes and stood silently, his hands still gripping Catra’s shoulders. A full-body shudder passed through him before he took a deep breath and opened his eyes. He took his claws away, cleared his throat, and went on in a much more businesslike voice. “Have you and Hordak returned then?”

“Hordak is not coming back,” Catra said firmly. “Force Captain Scorpia is going to run the Fright Zone. I've just come back to spread the news. We’ve made peace with the Princesses and the War is Over.”

“Over?”

"There will be official written copies of the order tomorrow morning, but for now you'll just have to take my word for it. "

The lizard man laughed again and signaled 'all clear' with his claw and a small crowd crept out of hiding places in the surrounding buildings. Catra repeated what she had told the old veteran to the crowd. Soon though, others began to repeat it to each other until victory shouts echoed off the vegetation-covered machinery.

It was natural for Catra to take command since everyone she spoke to in the Fright Zone recognized her authority, and she'd gotten pretty good at logistics in the last two years. She sent people to survey the wreckage of the city, to inventory the warehouses, to find out how much food and supplies the population had to work with over the next few days. The reports were more optimistic than she'd imagined they would be as she relayed them back to Scorpia. Horde Prime hadn't fed the denizens of the Fright Zone any better than he'd fed Catra when she'd been chipped and the warehouses were almost completely full.

By noon, one of the central halls had been cleared for serving meals and Catra ordered that double rations be issued until Scorpia said otherwise. This was met with cheers and a full-fledged party was starting to take shape. People laughed, cried, and hugged each other with an abandon unprecedented in the Fright Zone.

Not until late afternoon were Catra and Melog able to wrap up and head back to the Princesses' camp.

The magical cat pulled up short, suddenly. " *There is a kitten down there."* It turned to the partially collapsed building and gently dumped Catra onto the ground. *"She is in need of aid."*

"A kitten? Seriously?" muttered Catra, following her friend on foot. "Okay, go see what you can do. But then can we just go back?" Adora was waiting for her and the thought made Catra want to laugh out loud again.

Melog shrunk themself down so they could get into the hollow. Catra had absolutely no interest in squeezing in there so she stood waiting outside the hole until something rocketed right into her, knocking her off her feet.

Instinctively she'd grabbed at the attacker, only to realize she grabbed the tail of a frightened cadet. One of the few cat people in the Horde, like Catra herself. *She* was the "kitten" Melog had been talking about. Alone, dressed in rags, far too thin and scared out of her mind, if her still-bushy tail and flattened ears were anything to go by.

"Are you doing okay?" She could feel the girl trembling but wasn't sure what scared her more: riding a giant beast or being in close proximity to "Force Captain Catra"

"I-I-I'm fine," the girl lied. Clearly, the girl was not and had not been fine for a while.

The warehouse came into sight. In the late afternoon sunlight, two youngsters stood on the loading dock, keeping watch. Seeing Melog galloping towards them, they both took a fighting stance.

"Agatha! Someone's coming!" one of them yelled, while still keeping their eyes fixed on the intruders.

A powerfully built, battle-scarred old woman in armor hurried out of the door, holding a powered-up weapon scavenged from one of Prime's bots. The trigger mechanism looked redesigned and it was jury-rigged to run off of an Etherian power source. One of Scorpia's people, she easily hefted the huge laser to point it at the three of them. "Show me your necks," she growled.

The cadet and Catra tumbled from Melog's back. Obediently, the cadet moved her hair aside to bare the back of her neck and Catra turned and flipped down the high collar of her shirt. It came to her then that perhaps Entrapta had designed the collar to be extra high to protect the still healing spot.

“They’re clear.” The old woman announced harshly and she moved the weapon to aim solely at Melog and Catra. Other cadets had emerged from the building, all of them almost adult-sized. They closed their formation, penning them in. “Report, Felina!” Agatha barked. “Who is this and why are you bringing her here, against orders?”

The girl snapped to attention and saluted, “Yes, ma’am! Force Captain Catra found me hiding in the rubble, ma’am.”

The old woman’s eyes narrowed, and her penetrating gaze shifted from Felina to Catra and back. She advanced on the girl while keeping her laser focused on Catra. “Your orders were, ‘do not be found,’ and ‘do not bring strangers to the cadre’,” she gritted, “I assume you have some good reason for disobeying?” Her voice dropped into a silky undertone that raised the hackles on the back of Catra’s neck. Melog’s mane and tail shifted to a dark purple and he growled softly.

Felina didn’t blanch, “Yes, ma’am! Force Captain Catra countermanded that order, ma’am!” Here, the cadet looked at Catra and back to her commander.

“How do you know this is the real Catra? The last we heard, she was probably dead.”

“Oh…” Felina hesitated for the first time. She seemed to be going over different responses in her head.

“I’m waiting, cadet” Again, that gentle Shadow Weaver-worthy murmur that made Catra want to bite something. If this went on much longer Catra was probably going to eat this woman alive.

Before Catra could open her mouth to put an end to this nonsense, Felina blurted, “Ma’am! Force Captain Catra has heterochromia! It occurs in less than .01 percent of Fright Zone Citizens and Force Captain Catra is the only feli-form person who has been documented to have it listed as an official distinguishing mark.” She straightened up to smile at her commander, “Ma’am.”

The forbidding face broke into a fond smile. “Good job cadet. You were paying attention that day.”

Catra blinked. That was more than she knew.

Agatha turned to peer at Catra. “Force Captain?” Her tone was respectful, but wary, “My apologies, but we are out of the loop here.” She still hadn’t lowered the weapon, “I need some proof.”

Catra sighed and scratched her ear. “I don’t know what to tell you.” She couldn’t blame the old woman for being cautious. “The war is over. We drove out Prime and made peace with the princesses. It’s been a long day.” After a second, she opened the bag she’d filled with ration bars from one of the warehouses. She’d put a few boxes in this morning. “How many cadets do you have? I’ve got a whole stack of food.”

At the mention of food, a little murmur that sounded like longing went around the circle of teenagers who surrounded them.

An expression that looked like hopelessness flashed across the old woman’s face and she closed her eyes. Seeming to come to a decision, she opened them and took two strides forward. Melog moved as if to intervene, but Catra signaled them to stop with a sharp gesture. The woman stared straight into Catra’s eyes. After a beat, she lowered her weapon. Saluting, she , “Force Captain Catra! Cadet Commander Agatha reporting in.”

Breathing a sigh of relief, Catra handed the bag of rations to Felina. “Cadet. Distribute these.” She turned back to the old woman. “Agatha. Report. How many cadets do you have and what is your objective?”

“Force Captain, I have a cadre of twenty-four cadets and we have been continuing our guerilla campaign of sabotage against Prime’s forces.”

“Twenty-four?” Catra stared, “You have twenty-four cadets that you’ve kept alive and unchipped? For all this time?”

“Yes, Force Captain.” Hopelessness warred with pride in the woman’s face.

The teenagers were encouraging smaller kids to come out of the building and accept the ration bars which were met with squeals of delight. Catra called out, “That was a hundred bar box. Make sure everyone gets two! One for now, one for later. Don’t eat yourself sick. Return the rest to Agatha. And remember, we can all count.”

Felina came back over, “Ma’am? Mike and Lee are distributing the rest of the rations. Here’s yours.” She handed over the two bars. Eyeing Catra cautiously, she said, “Force Captain? Can I find you somewhere to sit?” Then she moved her eyes to look significantly at Agatha.

“She wants you to sit down for the old one,” Melog purred.

Yeah, but if I do that, I’ll be stuck here longer, Catra thought to herself. She preferred to have her meetings on her feet because it cut down on people talking just to listen to themselves talk. However, Agatha like the cadets, looked far too thin, with sunken cheeks and grey shadows under her eyes. Catra sat cross-legged on the grassy ground. “Sit with me, Agatha,” she said, giving the cadet a wink. One of the other cadets pushed a bench over that had obviously been scavenged for Agatha’s use.

“Thank you, Force Captain.” Her disciplined demeanor finally cracked. She sagged, putting the barrel of the laser across her lap. “And, gods, I hope you are who you say you are.” Felina came up beside Agatha and took the giant weapon, staggering a bit under the weight as she handed it to one of the bigger cadets. She came back to stand beside Agatha.

“So, what are our new orders?” Agatha asked, seemingly recovered from her momentary weakness.

“For tonight? Stand down. Get some rest. In the morning, head to the central dining hall. I’ll make sure they know you’re coming.”

Catra grinned again. “It really is over.”

“Over…” that seemed to be more than the old woman could take in. She brushed her grey hair back with her pincer and stared at Catra, momentarily transfixed, then in a move reminiscent of Scorpia she lunged forward, sweeping Catra into a hug.

“Whoa!” Catra gasped. Since when was everyone in the Fright Zone so damned touchy-feely? She let it go for a minute before starting to wiggle out. She’d never known any Scorpion-folk other than Scorpia, but this rampant hugginess was apparently genetic.

The cadet commander released Catra, turned to Filena and hugged her too. “I was so worried when you didn’t report in. I was going to sweep all the holes tonight.”

Catra let out a breath she didn’t know she was holding as Filena hugged the woman back. An uncomfortable lump formed in her throat. Melog, sensing her sudden change of mood came over and butted their head against her.

Just then, the commbadge beeped. “Scorpia to Catra?”

Catra cleared her throat before she answered. “What’s up, Scorpia?”

“Hey, Wildcat? You coming in yet? There’s a party getting started here.” Scorpia paused, “Adora’s looking for you.” Another pause and Catra thought she heard Perfuma and Glimmer giggle in the background, “Oh, I’m not supposed to tell you this, but Adora is sulking and threatening to send Glimmer for you.”

A tempting offer, but it was hardly romantic to throw up on her girlfriend’s (!) shoes. “I’m headed in now. Tell Adora I won’t be long. I’m just wrapping up.”

“That’s what you said an hour ago!” Adora whined from the background.

Catra rolled her eyes and grinned. “Okay, okay.”

“Felina, go pass on the Force Captain’s orders. And tell everyone we’re having recreation until lights out!” Agatha told the girl, whose eyes went wide with delight.

“Yes, ma’am!”

“Where are you camped, Force Captain?” asked Agatha seriously as Felina scampered off.

“Edge of the Fright Zone. Near the Whispering Wood.”

“That will take you hours without a vehicle. You could spend the night here.”

“Nah, Melog moves fast.” Now that the cadet was safely back where she belonged, Catra was even more desperate to get back to Adora. She stood up. “Agatha, I’m recommending you for a medal.” Keeping all of these cadets alive and unchipped was a feat Catra wasn’t sure she could have pulled off.

Agatha rose to her feet and snapped a sharp salute. “Thank you, Force Captain.” She stopped and opened her mouth as if to add something, but then she shut it again. It reminded Catra a lot of Scorpia.

“What?”

The woman hesitated, then blurted, “Do you remember me? At all?”

Catra wracked her brain. “No. Sorry,” she finally said.

“No, you were such a little thing.” The woman smiled, but crookedly as if she were trying to convince herself that it was okay that Catra didn’t remember her. “The last time I saw you, you were playing in a cardboard box; the day Shadow Weaver chose you. She only took the most promising children from the creche. I always knew you’d do well. I’ve been so proud of all of the good

you've done as Hordak's second. And now you tell me you won the war? I'm just...so proud."

Awakening

Chapter Summary

Catra on trial

Day 2 after Victory on Etheria

Spire Encampment

Sun heating up the sidewall of the tent woke Catra up. Her face was buried in thick golden hair. Her arms, legs, and tail were wrapped around Adora, and she couldn't remember the last time she had the opportunity to sleep so long. Or the last time her insomnia let her sleep so deeply. It was at least midmorning. She wondered why Adora was still in bed in her half-sleep, but it didn't feel important. She had some sense that they'd been given the day off.

Suddenly the warmth and the light seemed a little *too* good.

She opened her eyes, looking around the neat little cabin-style tent. Adora snored quietly as Catra studied her. Was this real? Could what she remembered happening yesterday actually happen? Or was it one of Prime's tricks?

"Any sign of either of them yet?" Glimmer's voice cut through Catra's sleepy confusion. The Queen was just outside their tent flap.

Bow replied, "No. I'm guessing they both need the sleep. What's the council decided?"

"Nothing yet. I gave my testimony, and then they threw me out. Dad said I had too much of a conflict of interest to render judgment."

A little silence then, "I guess that makes sense. I mean, everyone else only knows her as Hordak's Second."

“Adora’s going lose her mind when she finds out about this.” Glimmer sighed. “I don’t blame her. But Mermista’s right. We have to show people that their leaders are negotiating in good faith. The best way to do that is to have a proper trial. And given what we’ve been hearing about Catra... well, the Horde citizens deserve to have their say as well.”

“Yeah.” Arrow Boy was silent for a minute, then, “Do you think we should wake them up?”

“No. They’ll only stress about it. They deserve some peace while they can get it. The council will probably want Catra to make a statement when they render judgment, but Dad said he didn’t think there was any reason for either of them to be there for testimony.”

Perhaps another time, Catra would have been outraged to hear she was being tried for unknown crimes *in absentia.* Right this second, she found herself limp with relief. *None* of Prime’s false scenarios included trials. Let the Alliance get on with their show trial, she didn’t much care. What she cared about was what yesterday *happened*. The old officer, the cadet commander, the brave little cadet; they were *real.* Prime was *gone.* They were *free.* No one could take that away.

And what was the worst the Alliance could do? Same shit, different day. Catra sighed and closed her eyes again, feeling too exhausted to do anything about anything. For now, the reality that Prime was gone and the scent of Adora’s hair was everything Catra needed to purr herself back to sleep.

Sometime later, Adora disentangled herself from Catra. “I’ll be back,” she whispered. “I’m hungry.”

Catra opened one eye, “Bring me back something,” she muttered. By the light, it was lunchtime.

“Okay.”

“Hey, Adora.” Bow said as Adora exited the tent.

"Oh, hey. Were you waiting for me?"

"Yeah," Arrow Boy paused. "Sort of."

"Well, I'm going to go find some lunch. Where is everybody?"

"They're...um…" Bow lowered his voice to a whisper.

"A TRIAL!" Adora shrieked. "WHY IS CATRA ON TRIAL?"

Catra sighed and sat up. Melog lay on the floor, their mane dark with Catra's irritation. Now she was going to have to get dressed. Honestly, Adora did not think things through. *Of course*, there was a trial.

"*Why is your mate distressed, granddaughter?"* Melog asked.

Her mate? Is that what Adora was now? That made Catra grin, even as she answered, "I think the Rebellion has me up on war crimes or something. You know, the usual." Bow and Adora's voices were gone now, so Catra really hoped that they'd gone to find food.

"*Have you committed war crimes?"*

Catra stopped to think. "Well, yeah. I mean, I spent a shit ton of time trying to conquer them. They're probably pretty mad."

"By itself, war is not a crime. Did you purposely target civilians? Torture captives?"

Thinking of Entrapta and of Thaymore, Catra shrugged. "Yes." She feigned unconcern even as Melog gave her a side-eye. "I also opened a portal that nearly destroyed reality and it killed Sparkles' mom, I broke the Salineas Seagate. Opened the way for Prime to find Etheria. I never really expected to get out of this mess alive, honestly."

She finished dressing. "Maybe I can get them to give me another night with Adora before they cart me off to Beast Island or

whatever.” She smiled faintly, “We were too tired to actually get anywhere last night.”

“*I will not allow that.”* Melog pronounced. “*They will not take you anywhere.”*

That made Catra tear up. She sat down beside them and rested her head on theirs. “No,” she said. “It’s okay. Whatever happens, I need you to stay safe and keep Adora safe. You’ve seen what she’s like. She’ll go and do something stupid and get herself hurt. She needs these people and I don’t want her to alienate them because of me. Okay? If they want to take whatever happened out of my hide...well, I knew it wasn’t going to end any other way.”

“You will accept their judgment? ”

Catra sighed and scratched the magical cat’s ears. “Yeah. I guess.” She hoped Melog didn’t get the wrong idea. “Don’t think I’m being *noble* or anything. I’m just so tired.”

"*I will not allow them to harm or imprison you. There are other solutions that are more healing."*

Adora’s voice came back into earshot. “Who’s advocating for her?”

Bow spoke much more quietly, so Catra didn’t hear his answer.

“What? Seriously? And Glimmer is okay with this?” Adora’s voice was closer now and she sounded near tears.

“Yes. Look, everyone needs to have some closure about this if the peace treaty is to go forward.”

“But after everything we’ve gone through...Everything she’s gone through...I thought we could have some, I don’t know, just some time to be together.”

“Look, it’ll be okay. King Micah is conducting the trial to be as fair as possible and with everyone going, they’ll get all the facts out in

the open. Hell, half the Etherian Horde is already functioning as part of the Princess Alliance so we need to drive home the idea that Horde soldiers are subject to common Etherian Law."

"What will they do to her?" Adora choked out.

A long pause. "I don't know what they have in mind, actually. King Micah will do the actual sentencing if she's found guilty."

Catra gave Melog a final scratch and stood up to face the day.

"Hey, Catra." Bow flashed her a strained smile as she came outside. "Did you sleep okay?" He sat on a log next to Adora, who stared at her with guilty eyes.

"Yeah." For a second Catra considered pretending she hadn't overheard them, then she decided she was too tired for games. "So, did I hear I was on trial?"

Bow and Adora looked at each other sheepishly. "Um...yeah," Bow admitted.

Catra stared down at them with her arms crossed. "Let me guess, you're supposed to guard the tent so I don't wander off while they decide if I'm a prisoner or not."

Bow dropped his gaze to his lap. "Yeah."

"All right, I'm headed to the latrine, if you want to follow me. Otherwise, I'll be back." Catra turned to walk away, half expecting him to jump up to follow. She was oddly touched by his trust when he didn't.

When she got back Glimmer had returned again. "They recessed for lunch," Glimmer was saying, "Then they want Catra to come to hear their judgment."

"Will Catra be able to make a statement?" demanded Adora.

Glimmer nodded.

“I’m not much for public speaking.” Catra folded her legs to sit at Adora’s feet. "So, I don't think that will matter."

Adora put her hand possessively on Catra’s shoulder. “I'll speak up for you then. If they want She Ra, they have to take you.”

Catra patted Adora’s hand. “No, you won't.”

“What? Catra! I won’t let them take you away from me.” The wheels in Adora’s head were clearly spinning, planning some daring rescue attempt or other grand gesture.

“Just...just stop,” Catra said, quietly. “Can we just...sit here? For a little while?” She was so tired. She leaned her head on Adora’s thigh and closed her eyes.

“Is she okay?” Bow asked, sounding perplexed.

“I think she’s still out of it from yesterday,” Adora replied, petting Catra's ears. “It was pretty intense. I’m shocked anyone’s ready to have trials and things. I mean we only got rid of Prime yesterday.”

“My dad and Mermista wanted it held today before people started heading home,” Glimmer said. “He said the symbolism would help people realize that the peace was real. That’s a lot of what we were doing yesterday when you guys were running around telling people we’d won. Trying to make sure the treaties would stick.”

“I know, but I just never thought…”

“I know.”

Catra opened her eyes to meet her girlfriend’s worried gaze. “Come on, Adora. What’s the worst thing they’ll do to me? Banish me? It’ll be a vacation.”

Glimmer smiled, looking relieved. “Yeah, see? That, or she’ll just end up in the spare room. It’ll be fine.”

“How can you be so calm about this?” Adora demanded.

“Me? I have a lot of practice.” Catra looked down at her fingers, sheathing and unsheathing her claws. “At least this time I’m not getting zapped by Shadow Weaver or suffocated in Hordak’s torture chamber.” Shaking off her fatigue, she stood up. “Didn’t any of you find food? I’m not going to get banished on an empty stomach.”

No Surrender

Chapter Summary

Catra makes a speech.

Catra should not be this calm. The thought kept repeating itself in Adora's head as she watched her girlfriend head back into the tent and emerged with a leather bag.

"Here you go." Catra threw a ration bar each at Adora, Glimmer, and Bow and took one for herself. "I even got the grey kind." She smirked at Adora as she took a bite, then sighed and rolled her eyes when Adora didn't even try to smile.

"How can you be okay with this?" Adora demanded of Glimmer. "Couldn't you like, I don't know, just grant her amnesty or something? You already did that with everyone else from the Horde who joined us! What about Entrapta? And Scorpia? They fought against us with the Horde! What about Hordak?"

Glimmer sat on the ground next to Bow. "The Council is going to figure out what to do with Hordak tomorrow. Dad and I sat up talking about it all night. We don't want the whole peace process to fall apart in two weeks because people feel like they haven't been treated fairly." She took a bite of the ration bar and grimaced. Adora couldn't tell if it was from the ration's taste or distaste at her own words. "All those villages and towns the Horde took before Prime got here; they deserve to know we're taking their grievances seriously. "

"People are going to want payback," Catra said quietly as she retook her seat at Adora's feet. Melog curled up on her other side as if to provide moral support. "I knew it was coming. Someone has to take the fall." She finished her ration bar in about three bites and then leaned against Adora's leg again, closing her eyes.

Tentatively Adora rested her hand on Catra's shoulder and was rewarded with Catra snuggling closer. She tried to calm the rising sea of panic in her stomach by filling it with the ration bar. It didn't really work.

"So who's on this Council?" Adora asked anxiously.

Glimmer seemed to give up on the ration bar, handed it to Adora, and sighed. "My dad, Mermista, Perfuma, Netossa, Scorpia...the usual. Plus, some of the heads of the areas the Horde took before Prime got here."

Adora nodded, taking a bite of Glimmer's ration bar. That was okay. They wouldn't do anything too bad to Catra, would they? But Mermista...Her people were the ones pounded under the Horde's heel, and Perfuma had taken heavy losses from Horde incursions. Catra had shipped Entrapta off to Beast Island and had so profoundly betrayed Scorpia that the woman had defected to the Alliance's side.

"It'll be fine." Bow said, ever the optimist.

Something Catra just said caught up with Adora. "Wait...What do you mean 'suffocated in Hordak's torture chamber'?"

Catra sighed and opened her eyes to glare back up at Adora. "It's not important." She folded her arms and looked away, curling her legs up into a defensive posture. Melog's mane darkened, and he growled at Catra.

"What?" she growled back, then rolled her eyes at his reply. "Fine."

Her jaw hardened, and she took a deep breath as if gathering herself before blurting out, "When Shadow Weaver abandoned me in the Fright Zone, Hordak thought it would be useful to make an example of me." She spoke rapidly. Almost as if she stopped; she wouldn't be able to keep going. She took a quick gasping breath. "He has this thing in his lab that removes the atmosphere from an area. He put me in that until I passed out from lack of air. Then

he stuck me in solitary. In Shadow Weaver's cell, actually. I thought he was going to execute me, but Entrapta…" She unfolded her arms to put her hand on Melog's head, "Interceded for me. He sent me to the Crimson Waste instead. He never expected I'd come back."

Adora stared. "Wait. This is why you were in the Crimson Waste?" She asked softly.

"Yeah. I was sent there to die, pretty much."

"But...why would you be punished for Shadow Weaver's escape?" Bow asked.

Catra shrugged and looked away. "Because I was the one who lost her. He wanted her sent to Beast Island. I felt bad for her. I was so stupid; I believed her when she…" Catra clenched her fist and trailed off for a second, then went on. "She...tricked me into giving her what she needed to escape." She paused to clear her throat. "So yes, I've got lots of experience waiting around to be punished."

The other three eyed each other uncomfortably. Adora's insides squirmed. She wanted to say something, but she knew Catra probably would not want to hear it right now. Glimmer opened her mouth; then she closed it. Even Bow couldn't come up with anything to say.

Melog growled at Catra apparently having an intense conversation. "Yeah, okay," she muttered back to them. "Well, what do you reccomend?" More growls and purrs. "Do you think that would work?" The magical creature chirruped and mewed. "Thanks." Catra's tail lashed back and forth as they spoke.

Two women in Brightmoon Palace Guard regalia marched up to the group. "Your Majesty," one said. "Your father requests your presence and wants us to escort Force Captain Catra to the Council meeting."

Adora, Bow, and Glimmer stood as one. Catra waited for just a beat before rising from the ground and giving Adora a pained half-smile. "It'll be fine." She said.

Adora reached out and took Catra's hand, gratified when Catra squeezed back. They let Glimmer go ahead of them; the Brightmoon Guards flanked Adora, Catra, and Melog. Bow put his hand briefly on Adora's shoulder to let her know he was there.

The night before, they had purposely set up their tent on the furthest outskirts of the camp, a good fifteen-minute walk from the tents that had been set up for meetings, cooking, or other camp business, hoping to get some privacy. However, tents had sprung up all around theirs. Many more people were here this afternoon than there had been when Catra and Adora had gone to bed last night.

"Does...does it look like there's a lot of Horde uniforms here?" Catra asked, craning her neck to look around.

Bow nodded. "A lot of people from both sides have shown up here today. They're looking for help or direction on what to do next. Trying to figure out how to clean up the various messes. Someone heard that you, Hordak, and Scorpia were here, and now we've got a whole lot of Horde folks hanging around. That's why the Council needed to meet right away."

"Maybe King Micah shouldn't have sent the Palace Guard to come to get us," muttered Adora nervously. "They're drawing attention." She nodded at a small group of people in Horde insignia who were nudging each other and staring. One ran off, and the rest of the group fell into step behind them. After a couple more steps, the first one brought ten or fifteen more.

Voices within the clusters of veterans were beginning to take on a menacing tone, and Adora noticed that the Brightmoon Guards' stance had gone from "ceremonial escort" to "combat-ready," gripping their weapons tightly.

Melog disappeared. Catra remained, however."Hey, Sparkles?" she said to Glimmer, "Could you ask your guards to stop for a minute? I don't want this to get out of hand."

Glimmer stopped moving and turned around. "Okay." She nodded at her guards.

Catra smiled. "Thanks." She kissed Adora's hand before dropping it and walked past Bow. She put her hands behind her back as though this were a parade ground inspection and *strutted* up to the two soldiers unlucky enough to be at the front of the crowd. They snapped to attention. "What's happening here?" she demanded of the one closest to her, getting right up in his face.

The Horde soldier, a young man with dark skin, saluted, "Ma'am. We...ah...we...wanted to know if…well they said the Rebels had captured you, but then they said they're allies now, and we want to know..." Quailing under the force of her gaze, he trailed in almost Kyle-like confusion.

His companion, a tall aquatic type, was apparently made of sterner stuff. "Ma'am, we are here to represent the interests of the Fright Zone."

Adora noticed that quite a few faces in the crowd were turned towards him, probably his subordinates.

Catra narrowed her eyes."In what capacity?"

"Well, ma'am," the man replied. "We just wanted you to know that if the Princesses are planning to send you to Beast Island or execute you. Well...we are here to…not let that happen."

"What do you mean?" Adora asked, stepping forward, looking around at the mass of unfriendly faces that now encircled them. Her stomach dropped, and she began to reach out her hand, ready to summon her sword if necessary.

Growling, Catra held up her hand to shush Adora. In the next motion, she pointed at the man with one unsheathed claw, almost

brushing his nose with it. “You. Will. Do. NOTHING.” Her voice rose so that everyone would hear, and she gestured broadly to encompass the entire crowd. “We just ended one war yesterday. I am not about to start another one today.” She glared around at the gathered soldiers, “You will stand down. Now!”

“But, Ma’am..!” someone stammered.

“No!” Catra snapped. “I won’t have it. Do I make myself clear?”

A few murmured assents, but they soon died away. The crowd seemed undecided.

“I am giving all of you direct orders,” Catra shouted. “You will stand *down* . You will *not* initiate hostilities.”

“Are we...surrendering?” someone called out. Growls and fearful, angry mutterings circulated the crowd at this. An ugly riot-waiting-to-happen mood was telegraphed in the clenching of fists and gritting of teeth. Hands went into pockets or rested on the pommels of weapons to negate even the suggestion of surrender.

“Who said that?” demanded Catra, drawing herself up and looking around. “WHO SAID THAT?” She seemed to look for the source of the voice, turning her head as though listening for the offender, peering into every face, prowling the broad half-circle of people gathered around the escort party. The clear spot in the crowd widened as Catra circled, edging menacingly into people’s personal space so that they pressed backward, trying to avoid attention.

No one admitted to it. In the stillness, the only thing to be heard was Melog’s chirrups somewhere near Catra and a few involuntary whimpers within the mob. Adora was dizzy with relief that Melog was still present and, hopefully, ready to defend Catra from the mob if need be.

Not that Catra needed any help, Adora chided herself. Still, it was hard to keep herself from stepping in, even though she knew that She Ra appearing here and now would be a huge mistake.

"Listen to me!" Catra raised one hand over her head for attention and paced over to frame herself between the Palace Guard, who stood as motionless as if they were taking part in some elaborate ceremony in Brightmoon. Glimmer and Bow moved off to the side, and Adora to the other side and a little behind the group, watching everyone's back.

When she was sure every eye was on her, and the crowd was silent, Catra dropped her hand. "It is time for us to *stop* fighting," she said. Her voice was measured and forceful. "Horde Prime is *gone,* and the Etherian Horde played its part. The conflict with the Princesses was based on Prime's lies, and we are *done* with it." She let that sink in.

"We are *not* surrendering!" she paused a beat and clenched her fists at her side while she kept her eyes steadily on the crowd. "The Etherian Horde will never surrender!

A few "hooray's" and shouts of assent were heard in the crowd. Catra let them fade before continuing, "We have agreed to pull back to our traditional territory, but we are not surrendering our sovereign rights!"

"They have *already* agreed to recognize Force Captain Scorpia as the Fright Zone's Princess. They have *already* agreed to amnesty to any fighters caught outside the Fright Zone. And, as a gesture of good faith *, I* have agreed that any fighters who joined the Princess alliance during Prime's occupation are to be fully reinstated into the Etherian Horde with complete amnesty. If they choose."

More cheers. Were those supposed to be in the peace treaty? Adora had no idea, and she didn't think Catra did either, but it sounded doable. She glanced at Glimmer, who smiled and gave Adora a little thumbs up.

"The only thing we are surrendering are the lies we were taught! We are surrendering the idea that we can never be more than soldiers, machines to be fed into battle. That we are

interchangeable drones who can never dream beyond the next battle plan. Etherians should never have fought Etherians." She drew in a deep breath. "From this peace, we can gain more than we ever could in conquest. We can rebuild our cities, heal our wounds, bring about the peace and order that Hordak always promised but never delivered. Fright Zone citizens will see the world, and the world will see our worth." Catra raised her fist in the air and shouted, "For Etheria!"

The crowd and even the Brightmoon Guards joined in as Adora, Glimmer, and Bow raised their fists. A resounding chorus of, "For Etheria!" echoed through the canyon.

Dropping her fist, Catra paused for a beat, looking around, making eye contact with the thin war-weary faces that surrounded them. When she spoke again, her voice was softer but still loud enough to be heard by everyone in the crowd and rich with resolve. "But in order to take our place in the rest of Etheria, we have to face that we have caused harm. We were taken in by lies, but in believing those lies, we have hurt people. Destroyed lives. Killed people. Those we..." Catra hesitated for the first time. She glanced behind her at Adora, apparently unconsciously, and Adora's heart turned over in her chest. " *I've* hurt need to have their say."

The crowd absorbed this. People of the Horde took payback very seriously, and Adora could hear the wheels starting to turn in their heads.

Catra squared her shoulders and raised her head. "I go to face their judgment, but I have surrendered nothing. *This is my choice* . If any punishments are to be dealt out, then it should come to me. The plans were mine, so is the blame. I am going to hear what this council has to say, and I will accept their judgment. If going into exile or even facing execution will buy this peace for my people, I will do that.

If this works, then everything, *everything* we have worked for will be worth it."

“So, you will cease hostilities right now, and you will stand down.” Her voice ended the sentence pitched low and deadly before it rose in volume again to finally crescendo, “Do I make myself clear?” Adora knew from the way held herself that she was giving the crowd her most menacing scowl.

“Yes, ma’am!’

“I can’t hear you!”

“Yes, ma’am!”

Cheers of “Catra! Catra!” swelled, but Catra gave them only a grave nod and a hand wave. “Dismissed. ” Putting her hands behind her back again in that parade-ground pose, Catra neatly turned and walked back to Adora without looking behind her.

“You’re welcome,” Catra said sardonically to the Palace Guards as she passed them. To Adora, she said, “Don’t stare at them, idiot. Don’t give them a reason to think, and they’ll just disperse. Just start walking like it's part of the plan.”

It was true. Already the crowd was moving off.

“That was…” Adora trailed off, unsure what to say as she followed. “Catra…” She couldn’t say what she was feeling right this moment, but her heart was so loud that she was sure the other woman could hear it. She wished they were alone. She wanted...she didn’t know what she wanted other than Catra.

Glimmer fell into step beside Adora. “That was amazing! Seriously, thank you for that, Catra.” Glimmer told her, sounding breathless and excited. “We’ve been hearing some...unexpected things this afternoon, and Dad and I were getting nervous.”

Catra shrugged, looking a little confused. “I’m not really sure what that was about. I didn’t expect anyone from the Fright Zone to be worried about me.” She shook her head. “Whatever. I talked them out of rioting for the afternoon, at least.” She looked past Adora

towards Glimmer, “I hope you won’t make a liar out of me, Sparkles.”

Trial

Chapter Summary

Catra receives her judgment.

How many times had Catra taken this walk before? This long walk towards judgment and punishment felt as familiar as her skin, as natural as the light that fell on her face.

The Brightmoon Guards conducted themselves respectfully. Neither one had yet made a move to put her in restraints. That was likely to change once this meeting was over, but for now, Catra was grateful. She blanked her mind, trying not to think about the moment that was coming, the moment when it would all fall to pieces. Feeling unreal, Catra walked between Adora and Melog, comforted by their solidity.

" *Are you all right?"* Melog snarled softly, slinking along beside her, their mane dark and jagged.

"I'm okay." Her bones vibrated with a fine tremor, and she felt the hackles on the back of her neck raised as they got closer to the area that was serving as a meeting place for the Council.

"Thanks for the help back there, by the way." The groups of Horde soldiers that stopped to watch the little procession seemed less likely to pick a fight, but that could change. "I hope the rest of your idea works."

"I only gave you a few words of advice," Melog replied serenely. *"This has worked many times before and I believe this council will see the sense in it."*

Glimmer teleported from the other side of Adora to pop up between Catra and Melog. Both the woman and the currently-visible magical cat jumped and hissed involuntarily.

“Sorry.” Glimmer said, walking close beside her. “And I’m sorry about all of this nonsense.” She waved her arm around to take in the scene. “It’s just…”

Scraping up a smile for her, Catra nodded. “Yeah. I got it.”

“Look, it’s going to be fine. Right?” Adora said nervously. “I mean, what’s the worst that can happen?”

Glimmer sighed. “Well, I’m not sure. Dad and I talked about this...we don’t want anyone accusing us of going too easy on her because of you or me. That’s why my dad suggested keeping us out of it.

That drew a strained chuckle from Catra. “Yeah, because you can’t have anyone going easy on me because I might have helped you out of a mess or two. Appearances are everything.” As always, it didn’t matter what good she did, how many battles she won, how well whatever she did *worked. Only* her mistakes would be remembered. Her stomach twisted at the thought, making her glad she’d only eaten plain rations today. That was far less likely to make her throw up from nerves.

Sensing her agitation, Melog put in, *"I will not let them harm you."*

Glimmer and Adora exchanged a worried glance across Catra.

Speaking of harm, Catra felt she should give Glimmer some fair warning. “Um, Sparkles?’ Catra pitched her voice low so that the guards wouldn’t hear her. “Listen…” She reached out to grasp Glimmer’s arm and pulled her closer. “I...understand that you’re the reason these two aren’t like…” She indicated the tall Palace Guard with her eyes, “cuffing me or whatever you guys do. Thanks for that. But, if this goes bad...”

“Catra…” Glimmer covered Catra’s hand with her own. “It’ll be okay.”

Without letting go of Glimmer’s arm, Catra stopped walking. They were almost there, and if she didn’t say this now, she'd lose her chance.

“No. Don’t tell me that.” The former soldier's voice shook, and she had to consciously prevent her claws from digging deeply into Glimmer’s bicep. “This kind of thing always ends badly for me. I just need a favor.” Letting go of Adora’s hand so she could put both hands on Glimmer’s shoulders, Catra looked into the Queen’s eyes, knowingthat of anyone here, Glimmer would understand. “Don’t...don’t let them try to restrain me. I can deal with just about anything else, but if they try to...” She trailed off, looking away and unable to finish. “Just...I'd prefer it not to get ugly.”

Melog added a low growl that intimated they were willing to shed blood in Catra’s defense.

The other woman’s eyes became overly bright, and she leaned forward to give Catra a hug. “I promise. Whatever it takes, I won’t let that happen.”

Burying her face in Glimmer’s shoulder, Catra nodded, grateful beyond words that Glimmer hadn’t tried to tell her any comforting lies about the Rebels being different. Melog put their paws up on Glimmer’s shoulder and licked the side of her face with their blue tongue Bow and Adora joined in, wrapping their arms around both women and Melog.

For a moment, Catra leaned into the contact, remembering all the times she’d waited alone to see Shadow Weaver, or Hordak, or Prime.

“Okay. Let’s do this.” Catra let go of the others and brushed one hand through her hair.

“We’ll go ahead and let them know you’re coming,” Glimmer said. She grabbed Bow, and they both disappeared.

Adora took Catra’s hand and squeezed but didn’t speak while they continued on with their escort to the large central tent that had

been set up to serve meals. At the sedate pace the guards set, it was a good ten minutes before they got there. Another small crowd had formed, held back from their path by more Brightmoon guards.

Bow stood out front and said to Adora, “Glimmer wants us to sit with her.” He turned to Catra, “People wanted to come and watch,” he said, apologetically, “So we had to bring in more chairs.”

“Greaaat,” Catra drawled very quietly. “I get to be the entertainment.”

Bow looked devastated. “No, it’s not like that.”

“Don’t worry about it, Arrow Boy.” Catra gave him a little smile. “This isn’t my first bot-sim. Actually, as far as I'm concerned, the more eyes the better.”

Adora turned to face Catra and held both her hands, “Catra! We can still just take Darla and leave, got it? I won’t let them hurt you, and I won’t let them lock you up. You don’t have to do this. We can go right now.”

Catra moved to cradle Adora’s chin, leaned forward to brush the taller woman’s lips with her own. “Thanks,” she whispered, before turning away. “But, come on, Adora, you said it yourself. I have to face the people I hurt sometime.”

Adora’s reply was lost in the noise of the surrounding crowd (or maybe it was the roaring in her ears).

Melog disappeared from sight but stayed close enough that Catra could feel their warmth on her leg. *“These Princesses have behaved honorably thus far,"* they said, *"but this is their true test. You do not face them alone.”*

“Thanks.” Catra reached out, and Melog brushed their head against her hand. She straightened up and squared her shoulders.

Usually, a tent this large would have had ten tables so people could gather and eat or talk. Today all but one of the tables had been removed, and chairs and cushions had been set up so people could watch the proceedings. That meant that Catra had to walk through a center aisle with everyone's eyes on her.

Five people sat at the table: Mermista sat with her arms folded and a sour expression. Nothing new there. Perfuma sat beside her, toying with one of her everpresent flowers and looking troubled: not a great sign. King Micah sat deep in conversation with Netossa and Spinnerella. No Scorpia or Entrapta. In all likelihood, they were also being kept out of this, so she had no real allies on the Council.

If the gathered people wanted a show, she'd give it to them. For about four or five beats Catra paused at the entrance. It was just long enough for everyone to register that she stood there and for the talk to give way to silence. Keeping her gaze on the table where the Council waited to decide her fate Catra paced unhurriedly down the center.

King Micah steadfastly met her eyes as she walked to the lone empty chair that sat in front of the table.

For a moment, Catra wondered what style of greeting people did when they met a King. Did they bow? Get down on one knee? Touch their foreheads to the ground? No guard rushed forward to make her kneel, so she settled on a little half-bow and then adopting a parade rest stance with her hands clasped behind her rather than sitting.

"Force Captain Catra," said Micah. "Thank you for coming."

With an act of will, Catra restrained herself from rolling her eyes and making a sarcastic remark. Instead, she nodded seriously. If he wanted to play the benign ruler for the gathered crowds, who was she to interfere? And, it did play into the idea Melog had.

“Please, sit down.” The man smiled as though he were honestly trying to set Catra at ease. She gave him another curt nod and sat. Melog reclined invisibly at her feet.

“I should let you know this is being recorded. Is that all right?”

Why was he asking her? “That’s fine.”

“We’ve spent the morning discussing your actions as Hordak’s second-in-command. We’ve heard testimony from towns and villages the Horde conquered under your command, and the list of the proposed charges are as follows...”

“Excuse me? Your Majesty?” Catra held up a hand to interrupt. “I’m sorry. Could we just skip the part where you list all my crimes?” She examined her nails as she spoke. “I’m kind of tired, and I’m sure everyone is well aware.”

The Council members looked at each other. All of them nodded their agreement to Micah. “Very well. Let the record show that Force Captain Catra waived her right to hear the proposed charges.”

Behind her, Catra heard the audience mutter to each other. This was probably a terrible idea, but Catra was fairly certain what she said wouldn’t make a bit of difference.

“We actually only have a few questions,” Perfuma said, giving Catra one of her gentle smiles.

Micah drew a sigil in the air. “This is a truth spell. You will be compelled to answer honestly,” he told her.

A spell? Catra’s breath caught, and she gripped the arms of the chair she sat on, sinking her claws deeply into the wood.

Before Micah could throw the sigil, Melog leaped in front of Catra, growling. Melog’s sudden appearance between her and the sorcerer made the audience gasp, and Netossa pulled back her hand, ready to throw a net around the creature.

“Melog!” Catra hissed. “Enough. If that’s the way it needs to be done, then fine.” She didn’t want this to spin out of control just because she couldn’t cope with whatever bullshit spells the sorcerer wanted to throw around.

Melog subsided, disappearing again.

“Go ahead.” Catra set her teeth and closed her eyes, waiting for the pain of the spell to start.

Nothing happened. No fire arced through her veins. No paralysis gripped her. She wondered how long this was going to take.

“Um...okay.” By his tone, Micah seemed entirely thrown off his game. “So...uh...”

After a second, Perfuma asked, “Catra? Are you all right?”

Catra opened one eye to squint at them, not releasing her death grip on the chair. “Did you...do it already?” Slowly, she opened her other eye.

“Yes,” Micah said, softly.

“Oh. Wow. Shadow Weaver’s spells always hurt like a bitch,” Catra said. “So...what? I only get zapped if I try to lie?”

“Ah. This spell just makes it so you can’t lie. It shouldn’t hurt at all.” Spinnerella supplied.

“Oh,” Catra replied mulling that over. “I sort of assumed that torture was going to be involved here somewhere. I mean, I always thought you sorcerer and princess types must really enjoy it.” Shit. She hadn’t meant to say that.

Mermista and Netossa looked more alarmed than they had when Melog was snarling at them. Perfuma and Spinnerella looked near tears.

“We won’t hurt you, Catra,” Micah said softly. He glanced at the other members of the Council, and his jaw hardened. “But while we’re on the subject, have *you* tortured prisoners?”

“Tortured prisoners?” Catra asked softly. Her heart contracted and to her utter horror, tears filled her eyes. “Only one,” she choked out.

“And who was that?” Micah asked, his eyes hard.

“Shadow Weaver.” Catra closed her eyes but that didn’t help because now there was nothing to stop her from picturing Shadow Weaver’s mask lying broken and burned on the floor of that huge dark room.

“What did you do?” Spinnerella asked.

“Nothing she didn’t do to me first,” Catra growled, then slapped her hand over mouth. When she felt like she had more control she started again. “I put her in solitary. Made sure I was her only visitor. I wanted to make her feel the way she made me feel.” She bit down hard on her tongue to stop the rest of her thoughts from tumbling out between her lips. It appeared the spell couldn’t MAKE her talk, it just completely removed her filter. She used the heel of her hand to wipe her eyes.

“You know, I think we can honestly just let that one go,” Micah muttered, almost to himself.

“Okay, so like,” Mermista huffed, speaking for the first time, “why did Entrapta join you? I mean, you and Shadow Weaver did something, right?”

“Nope,” Catra shook her head. “Shadow Weaver wasn’t involved. I found Entrapta and took her prisoner. I was planning to do the full scary interrogation thing and I just couldn’t pull it off with her. You know that thing she does of wandering off?”

Mermista rolled her eyes and nodded. “Oh, yeah. We know all about that.”

"Yeah, she did the same thing in the Fright Zone. She was all over the place." That was almost funny now.

Pausing for a second, Catra weighed the cost of antagonizing the Princesses, but she wasn't tactful at the best of times. "When I caught her all I had to do was listen to her talk for five minutes and she poured out her heart. I gave her a spot to work, a few words of encouragement, and the next thing I know we're ass-deep in really useful tech."

"That's it? She started building weapons for you because you were *nice* to her?" demanded Mermista.

"I'm not sure what to tell you. You abandoned her. What else was she supposed to do?" Internally Catra winced, she really hadn't meant it to come out so harshly, but it was hard to keep a lid on her feelings. The spell felt like some kind of internal pressure that could be relieved by talking. "I guess you'll just have to ask her."

"We have, actually," Micah said. "She recorded just about everything that happened to her in the Fright Zone and stored it in Emily. We need you to verify some evidence." He looked over Catra's shoulder. "Entrapta? Could you play that clip we listened to earlier?"

"Yep. Just give me a second," called Entrapta's chipper voice from somewhere near the far back corner of the tent, near the entrance. "Okay. Emily, play Fright Zone record number 5886."

A little metallic whirring, then a voice. "So, is that First One's tech I found going to help?" It took a moment for Catra to recognize it as her own. It sounded high, tinny, and strange coming from Emily's speaker. Catra didn't bother to turn around, instead she watched the faces of the council.

"Oh yeah! This is going to be great!" In the clip, Entrapta's enthusiasm bubbled over into one of her crazy laughs, and then she kept talking, picking up speed. "Once I integrate these circuits the AI algorithm will be able to detect the aural vibration

differences in thaumaturgic signatures. Those entities with the strongest auric signatures will be selectively targeted allowing for the weaker signatures to be ignored. Therefore that should prevent excessive and inadvertent collateral damage in conflicts where non-target structures or creatures might be otherwise under threat."

"And that means..?" Catra's voice asked patiently.

Entrapta's voice now took on the characteristic slow pace she used when trying to break down complex ideas. "The. Bots." Catra could picture her pointing to Emily. "Will be able to. Track. Princ-ess-es" She would have pointed to one of Scorpia's drawings. "By look-ing for ma-gic." She went on in a more normal voice. "They'll just ignore civilians."

"Okay, but will they still defend themselves against, I don't know, people with sticks?"

"No. You'll have to have some sort of energy weapon to get their attention. Sticks won't actually hurt them."

"That works for me."

All five of the Council members peered at Catra with identical frowns. "We've heard and seen several of these kinds of clips, Catra," Micah said. "Why is it so important that the bots exclusively target Princesses?"

Catra took a deep breath. She could feel the spell's pressure in her chest and she just gave into it. "Because letting Princesses beat up my soldiers when I can send bots is stupid. I can build new bots, but every soldier I lose is years of training and experience lost. And frankly, the Fright Zone already has way too many war orphans." She had gone down to the infirmary once after the Battle of Brightmoon. Only once; that had been enough to convince her that Entrapta's machines were the future.

Mermista whispered something to Micah. He nodded and said, "The Horde was able to conquer Salineas under your leadership."

“Yes,” Catra said simply, wishing he’d get to the point.

“But apart from a few places, the villages were left intact, for the most part. Why is that?”

Catra sighed. “What’s the point of taking territory if you’re going to raze it to the ground? How the hell are we going to feed an army if we burn the fields and the people farming them? If you pay the villagers for their stuff instead of stealing it, you can hold a village with just a little garrison, rather than leaving a whole damned battalion. Most of the time, I found they don’t care whose kingdom they live in as long as they can just live their lives.”

Perfuma’s eyebrows furrowed. “So, you’re saying that using the ‘bots prevented casualties among both your own soldiers and civilians?”

“Well, yeah. Sending ordinary soldiers against you guys is... Well, it’s not quite murder, but it’s not okay.

We took a lot of casualties during the Battle of Bright Moon. The way Hordak and Shadow Weaver were doing things...It was almost like they didn’t understand that actual people were involved. And it worked. I took and held more territory than the Horde had ever done before.”

“Thank you, Force Captain Catra,” Micah said. “I think we have enough to pass judgment.”

“Wait...wait…” Catra jumped to her feet. She’d expected this to go on hours longer. “Before you do that. Can I make a statement?”

Micah glanced at the women on either side of him. They all nodded.

Catra straightened up and put her hand on the back of the chair to steady herself. “I just wanted to say that I was the one who made most of the plans to conquer you, so most of the blame should go to me, not the people who worked for me and definitely

not Entrapta or Scorpia." She paused to breathe, then said, "and I wanted to say that...I'm sorry."

That had a profound effect on the Council. Perfuma teared up and gulped hard. Spinnerella held Netossa's hand while they both whispered together and wiped their eyes and even Mermista's scowl softened into something misty and sad.

Micah seemed more curious than anything else. "How old are you, Catra?"

"About twenty. Why?" The question was so irrelevant it confused her.

Instead of answering her, Micah looked at the rest of the Council. "Does her statement change anything for anyone here?" he asked. "We can debate privately if it does."

The four women shook their heads.

"It pretty much confirms what I've been thinking," said Netossa.

The others nodded along.

Micah stood. "Catra has been a feared name in the Alliance for the past few years. And I can see why. Honestly, I'm glad I never had to face you in battle."

"Um, actually you did, but who's counting?" Catra couldn't stop herself from saying.

Micah smiled a little as if he found her funny. "Yes. This is true. Unfortunately, I'm not all that clear on the details." He sobered. "Regardless, after those on this committee have examined all the evidence, I cannot find any proof of evil intent. Not in any way that relates to the war or the waging thereof."

Micah paused to let Catra take that in and then went on. "I hardly think it would set a good precedent to prosecute you for the crimes of being loyal to your kingdom, or being clever, or

attempting to save the lives of your own people. Especially given that this conflict has been going on for longer than you have been alive. The goals of Hordak's conquest were set long before you were born, and you suffered as much from it as any of us here."

He picked up a dagger that had been lying on the table and struck the butt end of it against the tabletop so that it made a decisive *bang.* "It is the finding of this council that no charges of war crimes are to be brought against Force Captain Catra by the Princess Alliance."

A New Way Forward

Chapter Summary

Catra has a better idea
Adora confides in Bow

The tent was silent after Micah's pronouncement. Bow grasped Adora's cold hand and whispered a triumphant, "Yes!"

The three of them sat off to the side of the council table, and Adora could only see Catra's profile as she stood rigidly in the front. Adora wanted to sob in relief, to run to Catra's side, to shout, to scream; *anything* to release the tension that had twisted her insides since she woke up this morning and heard that this travesty was happening. Taking couple of deep breaths, she waited impatiently for Micah to dismiss them or some other signal that it was over. She wasn't at all sure about the protocol here, having never gone to see how Brightmoon courts were handled.

No emotion showed on Catra's face. Her tail lashed slowly as she seemed to process what Micah said. Everyone waited expectantly for her to react. "So...that's it?" she asked, a little blankly, as if she didn't quite believe it. "I can just leave?"

Micah nodded soberly. "Yes."

A chirrup came from where Adora thought Melog was sitting. Catra nodded at whatever the invisible cat said to her. Her tail stilled, but otherwise, her stance didn't change at all. "Okay. Um. Thanks, I guess." The shock of their decision apparently wrong-footed her. Again, Melog mewled. Catra flicked the end of her tail. "Ah. Before I do, I have a question." She addressed Micah directly, not looking at any of the other council members at all. "I'm told you're planning on trying Hordak tomorrow?"

"Yes."

"For what?"

The four Princesses and King Micah looked at each other as if the question didn't make sense.

"Uhhh. He kind of, I don't know, invaded our kingdoms." Mermista grunted, folding her arms against her chest. "That's for starters."

"So...you want revenge?" Catra relaxed, crossed her arms, and tilted her head as if she felt she was on more solid ground.

"It's not revenge. We want justice," Netossa said hotly. "He needs to pay for what he did."

"Uh-huh. "

"Look," said Mermista, "he's the one who started the war in the first place. He shouldn't get to have a cozy little retirement in the country or whatever. He wrecked my kingdom. And okay, I'll accept that you're like, not evil or whatever, after everything we've heard before you got here, but Hordak definitely is."

"Sounds like your minds are already pretty made up. Okay, so what's the plan? Hard labor? Exile? Execution?"

The Princesses all shifted uneasily in their chairs, glancing at each other.

"How is that going to help you? Do you really think you can make him suffer any more than he already has?"

"Catra, I'm surprised to hear you defending him. I know he didn't treat you well." Perfuma said. She leaned forward, and Adora couldn't get a good look at her face from where she sat. Her voice sounded curious rather than annoyed.

The corner of Catra's mouth quirked up in a little smile. "Oh, trust me, I'm not defending him. I'm just trying to understand."

"Oh. Well, Hordak hurt a lot of people," Spinnerella put in. "We know he did mistreat prisoners, and he deliberately targeted

civilians among other things. The people of our kingdoms deserve justice. And I'm sure the people in the Fright Zone will be happy to see him go."

Solemnly, Catra nodded. "I won't argue with that. And what about any others who have committed war crimes or illegal acts against noncombatants? Are you planning on trying everyone who can be accused of war crimes? Is that part of this peace treaty process?"

"Everyone accused of transgressions against Etherian Common Law will be given fair trials," Micah said positively.

"Everyone?"

Perfuma jumped in before Micah could answer. "People need closure. They need to see that we're serious about building lasting peace. That's why...that's why we decided to start with you and Hordak."

"So, which of you are up first?" Catra asked. Her voice was level and serious; it held absolutely no trace of sarcasm or mockery. "And who are you appointing to judge?"

"Excuse me?" demanded Netossa sounding scandalized. "We don't need to be on trial here. We don't destroy towns. We don't torture prisoners."

"Really?" Catra's eyebrow went up, and her ears tilted forward. "I know a shopkeeper in Erelandia who would disagree."

Spinnerella squeaked and covered her mouth with her hand.

Taking her wife's other hand, Netossa glared at Catra. "Hey. That's not fair. You know she was chipped when that happened!"

Micah cleared his throat, "Maybe we should do this in private…" He glanced uneasily around at the rapt audience that held so many people in tattered Horde uniforms.

Narrowing her eyes, Catra gestured around the tent. "You're the ones who decided we should have an audience. If you want people to 'feel heard' or whatever, I don't think you can back out of it now."

"Uugh! Why are we even talking about this?" Mermista demanded, throwing her hands up in the air.

Catra's tail lashed, and her ears went back, but Adora thought she was probably the only one who caught those signs of her internal agitation. To anyone who didn't know her, she looked the picture of calm. "Because I was raised to believe that Princesses were monsters, with no moral code and no sense of honor, fairness, or decency. Everyone in the Etherian Horde was taught that."

A murmur of agreement went through the space. Catra paused, but she didn't seem to be paying attention to the gathered people. Her entire attention was still on the council members. Deliberately she lowered her voice so that everyone leaned forward to hear. "I came here today because I no longer believe that. I came to show my people that I believe that we can have peace. I told them that I was willing to put my freedom or even my life on the line for it. Are you saying you're *not* willing to do the same for your people? Are you saying the things I was taught about you were true?"

The inflection and cadence of Catra's silky remonstrance were so like Shadow Weaver's that Adora shivered.

"No. Look," Netossa leaned forward over the table and tapped her finger on the tabletop. "It's not about that…"

Spinnerella placed a hand on Netossa's shoulder. "Darling. Stop." Her voice shook with emotion, and tears spilled out of her eyes. "She's right. We...I...did terrible things."

Netossa turned and took both of Spinnerella's hands in hers. "No. She's not. You were chipped...Prime made you do all that. She has no idea what you went through!"

Sharp, staccato laughter filled the air. The hair on Adora's neck stood up as she recognized the sound--That same laughter had come from Catra when they'd fought on Prime's ship. When Prime had been using her.

"Adora," Bow whispered, his voice strained. "Ease up. You're breaking my hand."

Adora jumped and let go, wiping her damp palm on her thigh.

Spinnerella's face was pale to the lips, and Mermista was ashen. Micah closed his eyes and rubbed at them with one hand. Netossa and Perfuma sat back in their chairs in confusion as Catra laughed for what seemed like forever.

Abruptly Catra stopped to take a breath. She scrubbed her face with both hands and shook her head before clasping her hands in front of her nose and inhaling. She blew it out and dropped her shoulders, holding the posture for a second before she opened her eyes and said, "I think I know *exactly* what it's like to be chipped." Her quiet voice held an edge of steel.

Netossa flinched, apparently belatedly remembering. "Oh, shoot. I didn't mean…" she mumbled.

"That's the thing, isn't it? A lot of people have been hurt." Catra's voice softened again, sounding sad. "Maybe we need to change what we're doing. Maybe trying to find someone to blame is a bad idea."

"Well, what are we supposed to do? Just let Hordak get away with it?" shouted Mermista, losing patience entirely. "He's the reason Prime invaded. He's the reason we all got chipped."

"Huh? Really? Because Hordak never figured out how to trigger the Heart to create a stable portal. That was done with the Runestones," Catra paused again, an ironic little smile playing at the edge of her lips, "Or so I was told."

Glimmer, who had been sitting on the edge of her seat next to Adora, gasped and grabbed Adora's arm with both hands.

Another mutter circled the room. Perfuma looked down at the tabletop, and Mermista shrank into herself, looking away.

Melog shimmered into sight and Catra put her hand on their head as if she needed the support but Adora suspected Melog was helping Catra figure out what to say.

The idle thought was forgotten as Catra went on. "Look, Scorpia can sign the Fright Zone onto the peace treaty. I can tell my soldiers to stand down. But if we don't do something to bring real healing, we'll be back at it in no time. You know people will keep holding a grudge. The next thing we'll know is that we're back to border skirmishes because someone needs payback. And then little skirmishes become big battles." She smiled lopsidedly. "I'm pretty familiar with the thought pattern. You hit one of mine, I hit one of yours. Then you come back for two of mine, so I get three of yours. It goes on forever. If the war is ever going to end, we have to decide that it's enough."

"But if you only care about punishing the guilty, it looks to me like it *is* about revenge." Catra sighed and her ears and tail fell in disappointment. "I get it, I guess. I'm pretty much an expert on revenge. I was hoping I could talk you into something better." She started to turn away, the picture of dejection.

"Catra?" The sound of Horde soldiers beginning to get to their feet nearly drowned out Perfuma's words. "Catra! Please," she stood up and spoke more loudly when King Micah and the other Princesses continued to sit in silence. "Wait."

Everyone went quiet again as Catra turned back, her tail and ears rising with interest.

Perfuma sat back down, twisting her fingers together nervously. She said, "Catra, I am so sorry. You are completely right. We need to rethink what we're doing." She turned to the others. "I told

you, I only agreed to this because I do believe people need their stories told...but doing it this way...it's just wrong."

Perfuma's gentle words seemed to disturb the others far more than they should have. Mermista put her elbows on the table and her head in her hands. Her shoulders shook. Netossa and Spinnerella began whispering intensely to each other. Micah sat back, his eyes focused somewhere in the middle distance.

Finally, Micah stirred, seeming to drag his attention back to the here and now. "What are you suggesting? That we're not going to punish the guilty?"

"Sometimes people *are* to blame." Netossa spat, as much to Spinnerella as to Catra.

Catra nodded. "I'm not saying we should just forget what happened. Holding someone accountable for what they've done is essential. But maybe we should ask their victims what *they* want and need rather than just deciding for them what should happen?"

For the first time since she began to speak, she looked uncertain. "I know it's a lot, but we have the opportunity to start something brand new here." She shifted her focus to Spinnerella, "I know how it is to wake up and remember what I..." She clamped her mouth shut as if she were biting the words back. Adora wondered if Micah's truth spell was still working on her. Taking a breath, Catra started again. "I get what you're going through, that's why I even came. Trying to fix it...feels better."

Spinnerella nodded.

"Maybe instead of concentrating on how to punish the guilty, we should think about how to help those who were hurt?" Catra brushed her hand through her short hair. "I mean, have you *asked* any of those people what would help them? I can guarantee that most of them would prefer some help rebuilding their homes or getting supplies than Hordak's head on a pike."

Perfuma started to smile slowly. The crease between her brows and the tension in her mouth that had been there since Prime's invasion smoothed out.

Catra put her hand on Melog's head again, "We've got all kinds of skills back in the Fright Zone that could help you. You've got all kinds of things that could help us. None of it matters if we can't get away from looking for payback."

Everyone on the council but Perfuma looked away from Catra as if ashamed but the Princess of Plumeria smiled broadly. "What if," she said, looking at the other council members, "instead of a council deciding if people were guilty or innocent, we held a space for people to tell their stories and they could tell us what they need? After all, that was a lot of what was happening today. People need to be heard."

King Micah nodded as if to himself, before raising his eyes back to Catra. He cleared his throat, "Force Captain Catra. I'm afraid we must really extend our apologies to you. If my wife were here," at the mention of Queen Angella, Catra looked away, but Micah went on, "I think she would agree with me. Of course, if my wife were here I doubt this..." He trailed off vaguely before going on in a stronger voice. "We didn't think this through. I'm...sorry." He looked around at the audience and sighed. "I think we will need to adjourn for now. It is late and I know that some preparation for supper is going to need to happen."

Catra nodded and turned on her heel, not waiting for dismissal. For the first time, she faced the audience that sat on chairs or stood in the packed tent. Again she took that parade ground pose and held it for just a moment. The clatter of armor and boots was deafening for a moment as every Horde soldier in the tent jumped to their feet to salute her. Instead of returning the salute, she gave them all a grave nod as she glided out. Not a single one of them moved until she was out of sight.

"Glimmer!" whispered Adora. Her friend understood what she meant and the three of them teleported outside so they didn't

have to deal with the mass of people that erupted with excited chatter about the last hour blocking their way.

"Where'd she go?" Bow turned circles looking for her. There was absolutely no sign of either her or Melog in any direction.

"Melog probably made her invisible the second she got out the door." Glimmer said. "Listen, I'm going to go check on my dad. He didn't look good. Give this to Catra for me." She hugged Adora hard. "I'll be back in a bit." She disappeared.

With Glimmer gone, Adora turned to Bow for the answers she had been too freaked out to ask before the whole fiasco. "Why did they do that, Bow? Put Catra on trial? Whose idea was it?" Adora took his hand so they didn't get separated as they made their way through the dense crowd that seemed to be in an increasingly festive mood.

Bow shook his head and frowned faintly, "I don't know, but I guess it all started last night when Mermista sort of freaked out and started demanding that we do something about Catra and Hordak. Perfuma and Seahawk tried to talk her down, from what I hear, but no luck. Then I guess all these Horde soldiers showed up from outside the Fright Zone and then a bunch showed up from inside the Fright Zone. And then of course you had all the Rebel soldiers that were already here. People wanted decisions."

"Well, it was a shitty decision," Adora growled. "I can't believe Glimmer went along with it. I can't believe Catra went along with it. And I can't believe nobody woke us up to warn us."

Bow sighed. "Yeah, that was probably my fault. You both just looked so wiped…"

"I just got her back and you were going to take her away again!" Adora stopped walking. Her shoulders started to shake and her hands felt oddly tingly. "Th-they just made up their minds without even listening, and now she's gone again, and what if she never comes back? What if she..."

“Whoa! Adora! Are you okay?” Bow pulled her along out of the path of the crowd into the space between two tents.

Her vision narrowed, and she looked at her friend as if down a long tunnel, while little flashes of light sparked across her periphery. “No. I’m not okay.” Tears started to fall down her cheeks. “I should have stopped it before it got started. We should have just left. Everyone was just ganging up on her and I just let it happen. Again!”

“Adora,” Bow grabbed both her shoulders, “sit.” He pressed her downwards until they both sat crossed-legged on the ground.

“This is my fault. And now she’s gone again!” Adora’s heart pounded in her head and she was breathing as if she’d just got done fighting a million clones. “If she’s gone, I don’t know what I’ll do. She can’t be gone.” She couldn’t get her breathing to slow down.

“She probably just needed a minute. Maybe she went back to the tent?” Bow’s optimism sounded a little forced.

“You don’t understand!” Adora wailed, pushing Bow away, getting to her feet to look for Catra before she got too far. “And Micah put a spell on her! And I let him!” She remembered the times she’d seen Shadow Weaver enfold Catra with her shadow things or zap her with the Red Garnet’s power and the ration bars in her stomach threatened to make a reappearance. She felt like someone had clubbed her in the head. Her hands went numb and the grey tunnel of her vision narrowed to a single bright point before going completely black.

From far away, Bow’s voice called to her and she blinked to find his worried face hovering over her.

“What happened?” She muttered, wondering vaguely why she was flat on her back.

“You hyperventilated and passed out,” he told her.

"Oh." This had happened a couple of times in front of Bow before they had gone to rescue Glimmer. The first time it happened, he'd wanted her to see one of the Rebel healers that were around camp, but she'd refused, just like she'd refused to see them for any of the injuries she picked up. She had told him at the time that she didn't want to strain their scant resources. She thought he suspected the real reason, but he never called her on it.

"I got you some water," he said, helping her sit up. "And this is why I let you two sleep this morning. What you did yesterday at the Heart took a ton out of you, and then you had so much to do that you didn't get any rest until last night." He handed her the water bottle and glared sternly at her until she drank the whole thing.

Meekly she handed the flask back to him. "Sorry," she said. She didn't get any further. She started to cry, and she wasn't sure what for.

"Aw. C'mere." Bow wrapped his arms around her while she sobbed softly into his shoulder. "I'm sure she's around." Holding each other while they cried had become common practice for the two of them in the time Glimmer was missing.

Finally, the tears ran out. "Better?" Bow asked.

Sitting back, she nodded. "Yeah. A little." But Catra was still not in sight, and that thought made Adora's heart clench. She should get the Brightmoon tailors to sew a communicator to all Catra's clothes from now on. Assuming Catra came back.

Bow sighed. "I'm positive she's still here. I think she just wanted to take a walk and get away from people for a little while."

"You think so?"

"Well," Bow took a breath as if trying to frame his words carefully. "When she and Shadow Weaver showed up to help, the one thing she said was that she couldn't risk losing you again. She and you...you know...you've always had a thing. Even when you were

trying to kill each other." He dragged in another breath. "Have you told her how you feel about her?"

"Catra's the reason why we're not all dead." Suddenly, it came to Adora that she hadn't actually told anyone what happened. Probably they could have headed this whole thing off if she had gone to the debriefing last night instead of selfishly skipping it to go to bed.

"Bow...I-I failed." Unable to meet Bow's eyes as she spoke, the woman looked down at the ground and admitted, "Prime's virus...it had infected me. I couldn't transform and the Failsafe wouldn't work. I was dying." Tears threatened again and Adora made a fist to will them back. "Prime had already won."

"So, what happened?" asked Bow, his voice low, almost reverent.

"Catra wouldn't let me go. She said...she said loved me." The outline of the Failsafe burned under Adora's skin and she put her hand on it, marveling at the thought.

"You mean *love* love?" Bow asked, his eyes huge and liquid. "That's the most beautiful thing I've ever heard." He whispered, delighted. Then he took in the expression on her face. "So did you tell HER you loved her?" he asked.

"And then she kissed me." Adora nodded, blushing. "And then...She Ra came back. Just like that. You saw the rest."

Bow seemed near happy tears at this. "Oh, wow. That's amazing!"

Adora's mouth curved into a little smile, in spite of her anxiety. "Yeah. It was." She looked up at Bow again. "That's why I should have put a stop to this! I should have…"

Bow put his hand on Adora's arm to stop her. "Did you miss the part this morning where she told you to stay out of it?"

Adora opened her mouth to answer, shut it again, and then said, "that's not the point. I should have realized..." she trailed off,

confused. “Never mind.”

Bow stood and reached out to help Adora up. “Come on. We’ll start at your tent. She’s here, somewhere.”

“Thanks, Bow,” Adora said, taking his hand. Everywhere Adora looked, people were starting the process of just getting on with their lives and it occurred to her that it was beautiful.

The camp was taking on the dimensions of a small temporary town. Horde skiffs mingled with animal carts on the wide lane that now ran down the middle of the camp. Several Bright Moon guards lounged next to an open fire with their helmets off and weapons put aside. They had a variety of small game spitted on sticks. They seemed to be discussing the virtues of charred vs underdone rat with three Horde soldiers. A group of shocked-looking clones clustered around a young man that Adora recognized as one of Perfuma’s people was trying to get them to eat something. People were sitting outside of tents chatting or sleeping in the sun. A few people were doing laundry and hanging it on tent lines. There were even a few ragged children in the camp. They marched in two straight lines behind an old woman who looked like one of Scorpia’s kin.

“Do you remember the day we met?” Adora asked Bow, softly.

“Of course.”

“Doesn’t this remind you of that?”

Bow smiled, “I guess it does.”

More tears slipped down Adora’s face. “That was the worst day ever.” And then she winced because she realized how it sounded.

“Because you lost Catra that day?” His voice was gentle. Adora was never more appreciative that Bow really understood feelings than right then. She never had to worry that he’d take things the wrong way.

"Yes."

"And now you're scared that history is going to repeat itself?"

She nodded, not trusting herself to speak as they reached their destination. She dashed inside to check.

No Catra. No Melog.

"Hold up." Bow said before she could spin off into another panic attack. A crumpled piece of paper was stuck to the tent pole with one of Bow's arrows.

Hi Adora,

I went for a walk with Melog.

Don't worry, I just needed some time to clear my head.

I'll be back by sunset.

I promise.

Catra

Underneath the writing were the little cartoons of the two of them that Catra used to draw to make Adora laugh. In between was a tiny heart.

Recon

Chapter Summary

Agatha and the cadets come to camp.

The late afternoon sun felt good on Agatha's carapace. It had been a very long time since she'd been able to sit and soak up the heat of a summer afternoon watching the children in her charge play. Truly, she had believed that she would never see such a sight again.

The night before last, when everything went mad, she'd assumed that Prime's final push was here. The children scattered and hid, as they'd done a hundred times since Prime's invasion. Most of them were able to make their way to the rendezvous without incident. All of them had deliberately avoided the noisy gatherings breaking out all over the city, fearful of what new devilry it meant.

She had been hiding the children from Prime's forces for so long that when Force Captain Catra had brought Felina back to their warehouse, Agatha had automatically assumed it to be a trick. But the children were so hungry, there was no way she could have redirected them once the bag of rations had appeared. It was despair rather than hope that prompted her to take the offering; poison or even chipping was better than this slow starvation. So she'd treated Force Captain Catra exactly as if she was who she said she was.

The children ate two whole meals and played games until bedtime. Through the long watches of that night, she sat with her rifle powered up--waiting for the food to turn them into the green-eyed husks that shuffled through her city or for the cries of pain as the children succumbed to tainted rations. Her plan had been that when the first one of them showed the signs, she would simply turn the rifle on all of them and then herself.

When the sun miraculously rose over living children rather than soulless corpses (of either the animate or the inanimate type), Agatha had found a transport and some fuel at the warehouse and loaded all of the children into it, striking out towards the Whispering Woods. Yes, she was defying orders but though she seldom thought of herself that way, she was the oldest living member of the erstwhile Scorpion Kingdom royalty. She wanted to see for herself what this alleged peace with the Princesses was about.

She wasn't the only one in a vehicle headed that way, from all over the Fright Zone, skiffs and transports were heading to the place Force Captain Catra had spoken of. It had been almost mid-morning when she'd rolled up and heard rumors that the damned Rebels were getting ready to put Force Captain Catra on trial for "crimes against Etheria."

Parking the transport on the outermost edges of the camp, Agatha marched her cadets to the center of camp where this nonsense was to be played out so that they could see for themselves the worth of these Princesses.

"Agatha?" A voice she didn't expect called to her over the camp noise. "Is that you?"

Delight warred with terror within her as she turned. "Scorpia?" The last time she had seen Scorpia, her brother's granddaughter had been haunting Hordak's Sanctum, a green-eyed shell who struck down anyone she came across with the Black Garnet's fire.

"Oh, wow! It is so good to see you!" Scorpia took two strides to close the distance. Felina, Lee, and Mike, Agatha's oldest cadets and her squad leaders, jumped between them, brandishing their makeshift weapons.

"Woah! Hey, kids. It's okay!" Scorpia held up her pincers to show she wasn't armed. The cadets didn't move.

“Oh, yeah, I gotcha.” Turning around she showed them that chip on the back of her neck was gone.

Now, the delight won. “Scorpia!” Agatha strode over and grabbed the younger woman up into a long, satisfying scorpion hug. “You’re here. You’re safe.”

Scorpia stepped back, “You look…” Agatha suspected she was going to say “great” but lying had never been Scorpia’s way.

“I look dreadful.” Agatha finished for her, grinning. “But I feel much better now.”

“Yeah, Catra said she ran into you yesterday.” Scorpia said, “She said that you’d kept all the cadets in your cadre unchipped. That is...that is amazing.” She looked at the children who’d fallen into their three neat lines. “But, what are you doing here?”

Wondering what to say, Agatha settled on, “I don’t trust these Princesses to keep their word. They never have before. I hear from the other soldiers they’re putting Force Captain Catra on trial?”

Scorpia shifted uneasily, “Well, yeah, but that’s only because…”

“Only because she was beating them.” Felina piped up.

Agatha hid her smile and gave the girl a glare, “Did I speak to you, Cadet?”

“No, ma’am. Sorry, ma’am.”

“If they think that we’ll give Force Captain Catra up without a fight, they are much mistaken,” Agatha said, stoutly. “So, what is the plan, Scorpia?”

Scorpia rubbed the back of her neck with her pincer. “Yeah. Well, see...” Scorpia looked troubled, then her face cleared as if she’d thought of a solution to a problem. “Hey, Agatha, we’re actually collecting statements from people about how things changed after

Catra took over as Hordak's second. Would you mind talking to them?"

If the request had come from any other source Agatha would have told them where to put it, but Scorpia was family. "All right," she said grudgingly.

At that hour of the morning, the tent had been empty but for a very few. A group of four women and one man sat at the table. Scorpia whispered to them gesturing at Agatha, before giving Agatha a claws-up and leaving the room.

"Agatha?" said one of the women, a thin freckled blonde with flowers in her hair, "We just have a few questions to ask. We won't keep you." She eyed the cadets behind her. "Maybe the children want to play outside while we talk?"

"No. I don't think so." Agatha gave Mike, Felina, and Lee a meaningful look and they nodded their understanding. Agatha sat in the chair and her senior cadets arranged the others until they sat cross-legged in a semicircle on the floor surrounding her.

The makeshift committee's questions were relatively simple and straightforward. Agatha was able to tell them that while had never met the Force Captain as an adult, Catra's policy decisions had impacted everyone. She told them how Catra raised the food and clothing rations, how she'd made sure every soldier had adequate armor, how she'd stopped throwing common soldiers at the overpowered monsters known as Princesses.

"But...Princesses aren't monsters," the thin woman said with a stricken expression.

"Tell that to my cadets who have lost parents to them," grunted Agatha. "I can give you the name of the battle where each one died."

"Yeah, but the Horde was like, attacking us. We had to defend ourselves." The dark-haired woman said, crossing her arms.

Agatha had stayed alive this long because she always kept a tight rein on both her mouth and her temper. Today, after so much time and so many hardships, she found that could do it no longer.

"The time to defend yourselves was when Hordak first brought the Horde!" she exclaimed. "I was a child and I remember my brother calling on the other kingdoms for help. I remember the sound of the bots Hordak sent after us. My brother told me the other rulers would come, but they never did. He begged and pleaded with them to uphold their mutual aid pacts."

We were *abandoned* by Etheria. My brother bent his knee to Hordak and he *wept* ! He gave Hordak the Black Garnet in exchange for his family and subject's lives. The Rebellion only fought Hordak when their own homes were threatened. The Princesses are the monsters who allowed Hordak to conquer the Scorpian Kingdom and left us to *die* ." Breathing hard, she glared at the five silent people sitting at the table.

Done with this nonsense, Agatha stood, turning around to her children. "Cadets," she barked. "Two lines. Fall in."

Lee and Mike jumped up to head the lines. Felina took a place at the back since she held her youngest squad mate, Rosa, who was barely out of diapers and had fallen asleep during the meeting. Agatha gave the cadet an approving smile, Felina's ability to soothe the little ones into silence had been instrumental in keeping all of them hidden.

"They're so little," one of the women whispered. "How can they be like that?"

That pissed Agatha off even more. How the hell did they think she'd kept all of them alive? "Cadets. Follow on." She marched out of the tent, into the bright light beyond.

For the rest of the morning, she had lurked, waiting to see where this was going. She had witnessed Catra's testimony and her

subsequent scolding of the committee from the door of the tent with great satisfaction.

Now, Agatha sat on a rock in the sunlight near where she'd parked the transport, watching the children play.

A shadow on the ground made her look around, leveling her rifle at the newcomer.

"Hey, Agatha." Force Captain Catra stood with her arms crossed, watching the cadets chasing each other up and down the field. The giant animal she'd ridden through the Fright Zone sat sedately at her side.

Agatha put up her weapon and started to stand.

"No. Stay put," the Force Captain said. She smiled slightly. "I'm too tired for that."

Agatha nodded. "Yes, Force Captain."

The woman hugged herself and sighed. "Yeah. I'm too tired for that too. Just...just call me Catra. Okay? And, anyway, what are you doing here? Didn't I tell you to head to the central dining hall?"

"We did check in at the hall. I registered all my cadets as living, then we came here." Agatha had done it over the transporter's comm rather than in person, but she had done it.

"How're the cadets? Do you have enough water and rations?"

"We had what you left us yesterday and I picked more up at the warehouse," Agatha said. "And it looks like there's a lot more game around here than there used to be. We could forage if we had to." The green grass and blue sky reminded Agatha of when she was a child before the bad times had started.

Catra nodded, still watching the children. The youngest ones were chasing each other around a game of tag while the older ones mostly were sitting or lying idly in the grass. “Can I ask you a question?” she asked.

“Of course, Force...I mean Catra.”

“You said you knew me when I was little?”

Agatha nodded. “I’ve been looking after cadets since I was about your age. I used to work in the creche with the very little ones. Shadow Weaver started her special squad when I was there.”

The woman turned to look at Agatha. “Special?” she asked, raising an eyebrow.

Agatha nodded, “Oh, yes. It was very competitive. She only wanted the very best. We tested all the children. You were the first one to pass all her tests.” The old woman couldn’t help but smile fondly at the memory. “Shadow Weaver brought her ward with her one day. The girl was perhaps three or four? I was never clear on where she came from because Shadow Weaver never brought her to the creche to be looked after.”

Agatha refrained from repeating the ridiculous rumors that the blonde girl was somehow Shadow Weaver and Hordak’s natural child.

“We sent her out to play with the other children who’d tested well, but the poor little thing just stood looking terrified, as though she’d never been near another child before. To be honest, I was concerned that the others would hurt the girl. She seemed very fragile. I never saw a shyer, lonelier child.”

Catra made a little noise in her throat that sounded like, “huh.”

“Anyway, we always kept cardboard shipping containers around because the children love them so much. She went to hide in the very shipping box that was your favorite. You were always so kind to the other children, especially the ones who needed extra

help. By the end of the afternoon, you both were fast friends. And that was really the last I saw of you. Shadow Weaver signed the transfer paperwork that very afternoon and took you with her as her ward."

Catra stared at Agatha, her brow furrowed and her ears raised. "That is so...not how I remember that story."

The blue creature butted against the young woman's side and mewled.

"Well, yeah, I guess." Catra turned her head and spoke to the animal, as if in response to something it had said. It purred and yipped again. This time it was clear the creature had said something because Catra replied, "Yeah. That *was* kind of her whole thing."

"Is...is Shadow Weaver coming back?" Agatha asked, carefully neutral in her tone. Things had been so much better since the witch's disappearance, but there was no sense tempting fate. It was rumored Shadow Weaver had defected to the Princess side when she disappeared. Who knew if they'd appoint her to run things again?

Catra's ears and tail dropped. "No." Her voice was flat, emotionless. "She's dead." She cleared her throat. "I saw her die."

"Oh." Agatha didn't know what to say to that. Condolences seemed wrong. Especially as the old soldier breathed a silent sigh of relief.

Fortunately, they were saved from further awkwardness when the animal next to Catra spoke in a series of mewls.

Catra nodded sharply. "That's a great idea," she said. "Agatha? Do you think your cadets are up for some games?"

Grinning, Agatha replied with a nod. "They've been fed and watered. If they don't do something with their energy they'll start

driving me mad soon." She reached into her pocket and handed Catra her whistle.

Catra gave it three blasts to get their attention and then walked forward calling. "Cadets! Line up! Count off for two teams! We're playing capture the flag!"

Worst Days, Best Days

Chapter Summary

> Adora and Bow finish their talk. Frosta teaches the cadets to play iceball.

In the three years that Bow had known Adora, there had been times when the differences between them seemed nearly insurmountable. Perfectly ordinary things to Bow were just so outside of Adora's experience that it was challenging to figure out the best way to help his friend when she was in trouble. For instance, Bow would have assumed that Catra's note would have helped Adora calm down from her panic. Instead, she sat down on her bedding and started to cry quietly.

"Oh. Hey." He sat beside her, relieved that she was no longer hyperventilating but baffled at the tears. Happy tears? Exhausted and overwhelmed tears? He couldn't tell, but she had crushed the note in her fist and held it tight to her chest.

"Talk to me, Adora." How many times had they done this when Glimmer was missing? They'd spent so much time talking about her, worried sick and laser-focused on rescuing her, but not once had Adora talked about Catra until they received that transmission.

"Sorry." She smiled at him through her tears, still clutching the scrap of paper as if it were precious. "I was just so worried…."

Happy tears, then. Maybe with a side of overwhelmed. Bow slipped his arm around her shoulder. "I know."

She wiped her eyes and uncrumpled the scrap of paper. "These last few days…" she trailed off, sniffling again.

"It's been a lot to deal with." Bow finished for her.

“Yeah.” Adora smoothed the note out on her knee and then neatly folded it to put into her jacket pocket. “Bow...I missed her so much.”

“Yeah?” Bow prompted her gently when it seemed like she wasn’t going to say anything else. “You never talked much about her.”

“It...hurt too much,” Adora whispered.

Bow knew that from the many times she would cut herself off when Catra’s name came up, but it was probably a good thing that Adora said it out loud. As much as Bow loved her, she wasn’t the most self-aware person. “But everything’s okay now.” He felt like she would need to hear that a lot for a while.

She nodded almost absently. “I still can’t believe they decided to put her on trial. And she just went along.”

“Well, maybe she realized nothing seriously bad was going to happen and just decided that this was the best way to get things out in the open.”

“Why would she have any reason to think that?” Adora snapped, jumping up to pace. “We’ve spent most of the last three years trying to kill each other. She was serious when she said she thought sorcerers were into torture. That speech she gave to the troops? She really thought she was walking into that!”

Bow flinched, remembering the day Adora had found the sword. How she had sincerely believed the Princesses were monsters. Then he considered Scorpia’s surprise at how prisoners were treated at Brightmoon. And since the only sorcerer the Horde had was Shadow Weaver, he could see how they would automatically assume sorcerers were into torture.

When Glimmer had first told him about the planned trial, after coming back from the all-night session with the other Princesses and King Micah, a trial seemed reasonable. A way to calm down nervous civilians and impose a sense of order.

It dawned on Bow that the Etherian Horde might not view it the same way. The Princess Alliance had assumed that Scorpia would automatically become the Fright Zone's ruler due to her heritage. That didn't necessarily mean the denizens of the Fright Zone would recognize that.

When Micah said he was going to cast his truth spell, Melog wasn't the only one to react. Every Horde citizen in the tent gripped their weapon, ready to defend their recognized leader.

"I guess we get so used to thinking of ourselves as the good guys that we never realized how it looks from the other side." Cold sweat trickled down his back as he belatedly realized what a disastrous decision it could have been.

"She told me once that I never had much faith in her," Adora whispered, stopping her pacing to cover her face. "She was right. If she'd wanted to today, she could have started the whole war all over again. Everyone in the Fright Zone would have followed her."

"But she didn't. She probably saved the whole peace process." Bow smiled, walking over to Adora to gently take her hands. "Catra saves the day again, I guess."

"Yeah." Adora smiled a little, thinking of that. "But, how can I make it up to her?"

"I'm not sure. But, look, you two have time now, right?"

"Time..." Adora's smile broadened. "Yes, I guess we do."

"So, come on. Let's go look for her. If we don't find her, we'll come back here at sunset, and she'll be back, right?" He led her out of the tent. "And we can go look for some food other than ration bars, okay?"

This was the best day ever, Felina decided.

Not only had Agatha given them double rations for breakfast, but then she'd loaded them up into the transport so they could do some recon. They were further away from the Fright Zone than Felina had been in her *life*. Right on the edge of the Whispering Woods under one of Prime's creepy spires.

They'd rolled up here in time for Agatha to help out Force Captain Scorpia by telling the Pretty Committee (as Felina had disdainfully dubbed them in her head) how Force Captain Catra had fixed things in the Fright Zone. *Then* they got double rations for lunch. *Then*, they'd gotten to see Force Captain Catra give that same Pretty Committee a swift verbal smackdown. *Then* Agatha had told them that they could have free time for the rest of the afternoon, and she'd promised double rations for dinner.

And now, Force Captain Catra had shown up and taken an interest in them. This was seriously the best day *ever.*

After so many days spent being silent, being still, being hungry, and being cold, nothing could compare to the sheer physical joy of racing up and down in the warm sunlight. The younger kids had now all tapped out. They sat or lay around on the soft padding of green vegetation that had sprung up over the ground overnight(Agatha called it "grass"). Now the older cadets could get to the rougher (and better) games. They gathered around Catra to find out what they were playing next.

"Hey, Frosta!" Catra called out to a girl dressed in blue who was standing on the side watching them. She looked about the same age as Felina, and she jumped when the Force Captain called out to her.

"What?" the girl asked suspiciously, crossing her arms over her chest.

"Are you interested in a game with my cadets?"

"You...you want me to play?" the dark-haired girl asked, sounding incredulous, but a longing flashed across her face.

“Sure, why not? Just remember this is a friendly game. Don’t...I don’t know...turn anyone into ice chunks or anything.” Catra paused for a moment, looking at Felina and the other eight older cadets who stood around her. “And you guys shouldn’t try to murder her either. No sense in getting the Princesses all bent out of shape again. This is a friendly game. Emphasis on ‘friendly.’”

Felina giggled involuntarily, quickly stifling it until Catra gave her a grin and a little wink.

The girl in blue smirked a little like she also enjoyed the joke, but she still looked wary. “What are you playing?”

“Uhh...” Catra looked around, thinking. “Well, shoot, we could play Princess and soldiers, but we don’t have any light guns. And then that might not stay friendly.”

“How about iceball?” Frosta said, “If you play, we’d have the same number on each team.”

Felina looked blankly at the others, then back at Catra, who smiled a little lopsidedly as she said, “Yeah, that’s not one we know.”

Frosta grinned. “I could teach you! It’s really fun. And it doesn’t even involve punching anyone.”

“How can it be fun if you don’t get to punch anyone?” Lee rumbled quietly in Lizardspeak to Felina.

Unlike most of their instructors, Catra was not half-deaf. She turned in their direction. “You don’t want Frosta punching you, cadet. Trust me.” She rubbed her jaw as if remembering an injury. “I’m still probably recovering from the brain damage.” She smiled to let them know she was joking, but Felina still elbowed Lee to shut him up.

Frosta’s smile widened, and her cheeks turned a little pink at the praise. “Aw. You were probably brain-damaged way before that.”

Catra laughed. “No argument there. So how does iceball work?”

It was a pretty easy game. The rules the girl outlined were a basic, two-team, get-the-ball-over-the-net-without-letting-it touch-the-ground type of thing.

Mike raised his hand. Catra nodded to acknowledge his question. “Where do we get a net, ma’am?” he asked.

Catra turned her head, looking around, “I’m sure we can figure something out…”

A woman with white hair, dark skin, and shiny silver armor walked over from where she’d been talking with Scorpia and Agatha. “I got it,” she said to the Force Captain. Though her tone was friendly, her smile seemed strained. Felina recognized her as one of the people on the Pretty Committee. “Frosta, give me some anchor posts.”

Frosta somehow produced two sticks out of nowhere and set them several meters apart. The woman cupped her hands together and then made a throwing motion. Suddenly a net was just there, hanging between the two posts.

“Thanks, Netossa.”

The woman nodded, then she said, “Uh...when you’re done with the kids, we should talk.”

Catra went very still. Felina couldn’t decipher the look the Force Captain gave the woman. Melog (Felina was pretty sure the creature wasn’t a pet--somehow, she knew it was a person) who had been sitting in the middle of the group of younger cadets, stood up, and their mane and tail darkened. They moved to stand next to Catra, and she sunk her hand deeply into their mane.

“No. We shouldn’t,” Catra said firmly. “I’ve pretty much said everything I need to say. Let’s not push things. Okay?” Catra’s tail lashed, and her ears went back, but she seemed determined to be pleasant.

The woman shifted nervously, looking over her shoulder. A few yards away, Force Captain Scorpia stood next to where Agatha sat. Next to her was the big, purple-haired woman Felina had seen that morning. Her eyes were red and swollen, but she gave the white-haired woman a little smile and a nod as if trying to be encouraging.

The white-haired woman turned back. "All right. Fine. I'll just say it now." She took a breath and straightened up. "We're really sorry. We're jerks. You were totally right. We were just running right over people because we thought we knew best. The council sent us to ask you, will you join us when we reconvene? As...as a member of the council and one of the representatives of the Etherian Horde?" Maybe to forestall an instant refusal, the woman added, "we don't need an answer now. Just think about it. Okay?"

She glanced quickly over her shoulder again and dropped her voice, talking more rapidly now. "And... there's this other thing. It's personal. I'm worried about Spinnerella. Spinny's kind of messed up about the whole chip thing. There's something she doesn't want to talk about with me. But she says she wants to talk with you." The woman shook her head impatiently. "I get if you're too mad to talk to me right now. And if you don't want to sit on the council, I get that too. But...would you talk to Spinnerella maybe...sometime? Please?"

Melog's mane smoothed to white, and they bumped their head into Catra as her ears came forward in surprise. "Um, okay. Maybe. I guess. Ask me later?"

The woman nodded and walked away. The tension in the air dissolved, and the woman walked back to stand with the purple-haired woman.

Instead of counting them off, Catra split them up herself. "Mike and Lee, you two are the biggest. I'll take Lee, and Frosta can have Mike." Then she said, "Felina, you go over on Frosta's team, too."

A small noise of disappointment may have escaped Felina's throat, and she felt her ears drop.

"It wouldn't be fair if the two fastest people were on the same side."

A warm glow filled Felina's heart at the praise as Catra gave everyone their orders to match the teams equally.

When the game started, Felina saw that Catra spent as much time on all fours as she did on two. That was an impulse that Felina always fought within herself, worried that she'd be reprimanded. But if the Force Captain did it, it must be okay.

The ball they played with was about the size of Felina's two fists and made of hard-packed ice crystals, so it was pretty heavy. Catching and throwing it back over the net was more challenging than it sounded.

Two more strange adults, a dark-skinned young man who had lost half his shirt and a blonde girl in a red jacket drifted over from the larger camp to watch them. Far too interested in following Catra's movements for Felina's comfort, the cadet kept her eye on them, turning away from the game entirely as they circled behind her team.

Distracted, Felina never saw what happened, but she heard a squeaky yelp from the other side of the net. Spinning around, she saw that Force Captain Catra lay flat on her back, unmoving on the ground, with the remains of the iceball dripping all over her face and in her hair. Lee hovered over her looking sick.

"Catra?!" someone yelled from behind Felina. The cadet whipped her head around in time to see a flash of light and a figure emerged from that flash that sent her mind spinning in terror.

Instinctively bouncing across the grass to put herself between her downed commanding officer and the beautiful nightmare that pounded across the turf towards them, Felina unsheathed her

claws and flung herself at the monster, determined to defend her leader.

The white and gold-clad giantess wasn't even looking at her, with eyes only for Felina's injured CO. Apparently the magical abomination had just been waiting for the moment the Horde's second-in-command was distracted or weakened so she could move in for the kill.

So, this is how I die, the Horde cadet thought distantly as she leaped, knowing how outmatched she was. She knew her mom's story by heart, and she'd seen the other casualties come into the city on their way to the infirmary. There was no way she could live through this, but she would make a good distraction until Agatha's rifle powered up and Scorpia could call in reinforcements.

"Ahhh!" Halfway through Felina's leap, a tangle of silver rope wrapped itself around her. She thumped to the ground struggling against the bonds and yowling.

Mike and Lee set themselves between She-Ra and Catra. The others would have gone to help Agatha protect the younger cadets.

Abruptly the sword-lady skidded to a stop. Felina squeezed her eyes shut, not wanting to watch the slaughter of her squadmates while she blindly slashed at the net that wrapped ever more tightly around her.

"Adora!!" Catra's voice rang out. Felina's eyes snapped open. Catra was up, and she darted between the cadets and the golden-haired Princess. "Adora! What the fuck? Are you *trying* to freak everyone out?"

Everyone, including She-Ra, froze.

"Catra! You were down...I thought...I thought..." She Ra gasped out raggedly.

“I’m fine, you idiot.” Catra smiled up at her nemesis as the cadets looked on in confusion. She-Ra reached out and touched the shorter woman’s cheek. They stood like that for a few seconds, and the Princess seemed to glow even brighter in the golden light of the low sun.

Hordack’s Second grasped at the hand on her cheek and squeezed it before turning her back on She-Ra. “Cadets! It’s okay! Stand down. Long story, but... she’s with us now.” She turned towards Felina and spoke to someone the bound cadet couldn’t see. “Netossa!” she growled, “get that off my cadet. Right. Fucking. Now.”

“Yeah. no problem.” That was the voice of the woman in silver.

The tangled ropes disappeared. “You all right?” the woman asked, crouching down next to her.

Felina jumped back with a hiss, her claws still out.

“Hey. It’s okay!” The woman held her hands up at her shoulder to show she was unarmed, but Felina knew it didn’t matter since the woman was able to produce nets out of thin air. “I’m sorry, I wasn’t trying to hurt you.”

“*Are* you hurt?” Catra bent over her and stretched out a hand.

“I’m okay.” Felina nodded as she grabbed onto Catra’s proffered hand as though she were drowning and let herself be pulled to her feet. Her cheeks were wet, and the girl swiped at the moisture impatiently.

The Force Captain reached out to squeeze her shoulder. “Good job, Cadet.” Tactfully, she didn’t comment or bring attention to Felina’s tears. Instead, she turned to the others. “We’re all just a little hair-triggered.” She gave them all an encouraging smile before her face turned pensive. “Although if we’re going to do this peace thing, we all need to calm down, I guess.”

“I’m sorry.” She-Ra’s voice was unexpectedly soft and full of remorse. “I didn’t mean to scare everyone. Catra...Are you really okay?”

“I’m fine. It was just a snowball. Anyway, I wouldn’t have caught it with my face if you hadn’t distracted me.” Her smile and tone were teasing, but She Ra’s eyes were bright with unshed tears.

“Catra,” She-Ra started, then she stopped. She cleared her throat, looking around at everyone. “I just…”

A shimmer passed over her form and the much shorter blonde woman with the red jacket replaced the eight foot tall warrior. “I’m sorry. I guess I sort of overreacted.” She offered a tentative smile to the cadets. “You three... you’re really brave standing up to a princess like that.”

“They’ve been fighting clones in the Fright Zone since Prime invaded. They and Agatha kept the whole cadre alive and unchipped.” Catra informed her proudly. “I figure they all ought to get medals.”

The woman who had been She-Ra grinned at all of them. “At least,” she agreed.

Late Night Talks

Chapter Summary

Spinnerella and Catra talk

The surreal sight of three ragged, underfed, terrified teenagers going up against She-Ra was something that would haunt Spinnerella for a long time. She wasn't even sure what had happened. Catra took a snowball to the face and went down with a little squeak and then Adora just took off running towards her. The young woman didn't even appear to summon her sword or say the words; a flash of light and then She-Ra raced across the field.

The half-second before Catra bounced up from the ground to interpose herself between She-Ra and the children was like a scene out of Spinnerella's nightmares; a Prime-induced vision of the Protector of Etheria chipped and menacing the helpless.

On the heels of that thought, Spinnerella had a terrible realization that the children didn't fear that She-Ra was chipped, they feared *She-Ra* .

Netossa caught the cat-girl in one of her nets before she could complete her suicidal leap. The lizard-boy and the tallest human-boy in the group each grabbed Frosta's long ice poles and gave every sign of being ready to lay down their lives for their leader.

The other older cadets ran to take defensive positions behind Scorpia and Agatha, putting the young kids behind them. All of the little ones were abnormally silent in their distress. A few gasps and quickly stifled squeaks of dismay were all she heard from them. Agatha stood up to take aim at Adora with her rifle, but Scorpia pushed the muzzle down before the old woman could get a shot off.

Catra explained to the children that Adora was on their side, but the little ones (and a few not so little) hid behind Agatha, Catra, and Scorpia. Some of them youngest covered their eyes so they wouldn't have to look at the terrifying sight of the Princess--even after Adora let the transformation go.

"They were so scared of us," Spinnerella whispered to Netossa, as they lay by their fading campfire hours later. The sounds of revelry were dying off and the two had rolled out a blanket so they could lie on their backs and enjoy the stars together.

Netossa nodded pensively. "Yeah. It was a good thing Frosta went and found Perfuma."

Perfuma and Frosta's sweet frozen fruit juice had been a huge hit among the children. Then Perfuma had passed around an abundance of magically produced fruit and vegetables which had been met first with skepticism and then delight as the children tasted the new foods.

Spinnerella sniffed and snuggled closer to her wife. "They're all so thin."

"Yeah. But, I think Frosta's made some new friends." The last they'd seen of the ruler of the Kingdom of Snows, she was sitting with the oldest of the Horde children, introducing them to nuts and berries, and talking about how many clones they'd each taken out during Prime's Occupation. Spinnerella was pretty sure Frosta hadn't mentioned to them that she was a Princess yet. By the time Netossa and Spinnerella left, all the kids had regained their buoyant, celebratory mood.

Two mismatched eyes, bright blue, and amber, glowed in the darkness beyond the campfire. "Hey," a quiet voice called out.

"Catra?" called Netossa as both of them sat up and rearranged the blankets and pillows to sit comfortably.

"Yeah." She came forward into the firelight. Melog paced beside her. "You said you wanted to talk to me. Is...uh...is now a good

time?”

“Darling, can you give us a few minutes?” Spinnerella softly asked Netossa.

“Are you sure? I mean... ” the Princess looked from her to the former Horde soldier.

“This is private,” Spinnerella said.

“What?” Netossa bristled. “How *private* can it be?“ Hurt bled through the anger in her voice. “You can talk with her about it, but not with me? You’re my *wife* .” The last words were spoken with confused sadness.

“Netossa,” Spinnerella whispered. “Please. Let’s not fight about this.” She reached out and took Netossa’s hand. “It’s not...not about *me* .” She met her wife’s gaze and then looked sideways at Catra.

“What? I don’t understand.”

“Please. Darling.” Spinnerella brought Netossa’s hand to her lips. “I’ll be fine. It’s just...I need to talk to her. Alone. Please?”

Netossa searched Spinnerella’s eyes. Finally, she nodded. “I’ll...um...I’ll go see if Mermista’s okay. Last I saw, she was so drunk she was actually singing shanties with Sea Hawk.”

Catra winced. “That can’t be a good sign,” she said wryly.

Netossa stood and looked at Catra with narrow eyes. “I’ll be back in a few,” she said as she ambled off into the night.

Catra sat down on a convenient log and tossed a few pieces of wood onto the fire. The magical guardian who had been shadowing her lounged at her feet.

“How are the children?” Spinnerella asked softly.

“The cadets? They’re fine,” Catra replied. “They’re tough.” She smiled showing a fang. “Food is a great distraction.” Her smile sagged into something sad. “They’ve been on short rations for a while, I guess. I got Perfuma to leave a pile of food for them for the morning. And since there’s so much game around here, I figured I’d take them out tomorrow and forage. They need to gain some weight.”

“Let us know what they need. We’ll do whatever we can for them. For your people.”

Catra nodded. “You should tell Scorpia. Agatha wasn’t too excited about accepting help from Princesses, but she’ll listen to Scorpia.”

“Agatha would listen to you.”

Catra shrugged. “Yeah. Whatever.” She looked away as though embarrassed by her obvious concern for the kids. "But...I’m guessing you didn’t want to talk to me about the cadets.”

“Ah….no,” Spinnerella admitted. “Where...where’s Adora?”

Catra shrugged. “She's catching up with Spar...I mean, Glimmer. She just got back. She took King Micah back to Mystacore with Castaspella. She said he was a mess.”

Spinnerella nodded. “I’m afraid this afternoon was...just too much.”

“Too much for *him* ?” Catra rolled her eyes and scoffed. The beast beside her growled at Spinnerella.

“No.” The Princess put her hand out. “I didn’t mean it like that. I think we need to talk about this afternoon.”

“Look. I said everything I was going to say to you people.”

Spinnerella stared into the fire, without moving. She found it hard to look Catra in the face. “Please, I wanted to...explain, I suppose. You have a right to know.”

Silence. Spinnerella finally looked back at the Horde soldier. In the dim light, it was hard to make out the details of Catra's expression, but she frowned, and her ears were pinned back to her head. Melog chirruped and shoved at her hand with their nose. "What?" She said to them.

They looked at the young woman reproachfully and meowed.

Catra's ears came forward a little. "Fine," she said grudgingly to the softly glowing creature. She abandoned the log and scooted closer to the fire, her arms wrapped around herself. Spinnerella saw that she shivered as though with a sudden chill. "Say whatever you're going to say, but then I am *done.* Got it?" Melog settled down next to her and she crouched unmoving, her wide feline pupils eerily reflecting the dancing flames.

Spinnerella nodded her understanding. "We really thought it was the right way forward. We thought that the Fright Zone's people would be relieved to have Scorpia in charge. Entrapta agreed that she'd be happy to have custody of Hordak. But then...when your name came up last night...I don't know what happened. Micah, Mermista, and I...it was like we were just so angry at everything you'd done. Suddenly, we felt like we needed to make you pay.

But... luckily... the others wouldn't let us just hand out sentences like that... they wanted to abide by the law. Frosta wouldn't even sit on the council. She was the first one to bring up that just being on the other side didn't make anyone a criminal. And Perfuma said we had to hear people out. Then, we started to hear from your people. And the more the day wore on, the more I started to feel...not really real. Like I was in one of Prime's dream scenarios."

Catra's unnerving stare became more intense and Spinnerella hesitated, unsure suddenly whether this conversation was a good idea. Catra absolutely deserved to know what had happened, but there was no way to predict how the volatile soldier would take the information.

“Every time I thought of you...I was so *angry.* It didn’t feel like me. I wanted to *hurt* you." She stopped, swallowed, trying to find a way to frame the words. “I know Micah felt it too--we weren’t in control. Mermista may have noticed, but I’m not sure she could really tell the difference. At least not until we started getting reports about the Salineas settlements being protected from Prime by the Etherian Horde garrisons stationed there. That should have calmed her down, seeing that so many of her people had been saved from being chipped by Horde soldiers, but somehow it made her angrier.”

“Eventually, Frosta, Entrapta, and Scorpia talked sense into us.” Spinnerella chuckled derisively at herself recognizing the sheer arrogance of what she was about to say. “Micah, Mermista, and I...the three of us who were chipped...decided that we could *live* with pardoning you.”

A tight knot of utter mortification locked Spinnerella’s throat for a moment and she stopped, horrified at their presumption. If Catra herself hadn’t decided that she was not interested in further hostilities, the highhanded act would have destroyed any possibility of peace negotiations with the Etherian Horde.

“I don't know if you know, but I was the first Princess to be chipped.” Spinnerella went on, changing tack completely. “I caught Prime’s interest. He wanted intelligence. And he was angry.”

“Yeah, I know. He couldn’t cope with the fact that Adora gave him a bloody nose, I guess,” Catra muttered, finally shifting her eyes away with a little smile.

Spinnerella shook her head. “It wasn’t Adora. He only saw her as one fool in a long line of fools. He was fixated on someone else. A little sister who had done the unforgivable. She had laughed at him.“

Catra flinched, closed her eyes, and hugged herself harder. “Get to the point,” she hissed. Melog cuddled closer to her.

“She made him crazy. He couldn’t stop thinking of how she’d laughed at him. We all heard it. We all felt it. He never named her in his thoughts. He kept trying NOT to think of it, but that made it worse. It was like when someone tells you not to think about a yellow fish. You won’t think of anything else.

He was disciplined enough that he kept a lot about her from me. I knew she was the first Etherian to be chipped. I suppose I thought it was Glimmer. Or maybe one of the first people he’d chipped in the Fright Zone. He kept her name and her face from me, but he couldn’t stop the sound of her laughter or the feelings it evoked."

“Look.” Catra opened her eyes and interrupted, suddenly. “I’m really sorry you had such a bad time and everything.” She spoke quickly, obviously desperate to flee the conversation. “But this all sounds like stuff Perfuma could help you with. I really don’t see why you’re telling me. And, anyway it's late and I just want to get to bed, okay?”

She unfolded herself to stand and smiled a little too brightly. “I get it. You were pissed because of the whole chipping thing and now you’ve decided you were probably a little over the top because you weren't thinking. I accept the apology. It’s all good.”

“I know what Prime did to you!” Spinnerella blurted before Catra could turn away.

The younger woman’s face twisted into the scowl that Spinnerella knew so well from battle, and she clenched her fists, ready for a fight. For a few heartbeats, she seemed robbed of speech. When she did speak, her words were low and dangerous. “What is *that* supposed to mean?” Beside her, Melog’s mane turned jagged and dark as they growled with the same menace as they had this afternoon when they’d defended Catra from the perceived threat of torture

Taking care to move slowly, Spinnerella extended her hand palm down in a calming gesture towards Melog rather than Catra. The

Princess was beginning to see that the creature not only reacted to the magicat, but the young woman's emotions were possibly being stabilized by the magical guardian. If they weren't, the Horde and the Alliance might already be at war again. "I just mean," she said softly, "that we owe you a lot. And you deserve to know the truth. Please. Sit down? Please?"

"Whatever it is you're going to say," the (former?) Force Captain growled, "just fucking say it."

An acid self-loathing burned in the middle of the Princess's chest as she said, "I suppose that's fair." She took a deep breath. "I'm trying to tell you that when we oh-so-magnanimously pardoned you, we expected you to be grateful to us for our *mercy.* " She spat the last word out like it was venom sucked from a wound. "But then...you *laughed* at us. Just like you laughed at *Him*. And the whole scene...I saw it like it was happening right in front of me. Like I was back in the hive mind and seeing it through His eyes. No one ever laughed at Horde Prime to his face, not for a thousand years."

She dropped her hands into her lap and stared at them. "I realized all the anger I felt... it wasn't *mine*. Then, it was like coming out of the hive-mind for the first time. I could think for myself again." Spinnerella stopped to breathe, fighting back sobs so she could finish.

"When you laughed at us, I suddenly saw what we were doing. How we were so sure of ourselves. So self-satisfied. We didn't want to repair the harm we had done, we just wanted to impose our version of *order,* never mind what the people of Etheria might want or need*.* "

"We had just thrown one monster off his throne and we could not wait to become the next. ″

Spinnerella slowly lifted her head so she could meet Catra's eyes. "If you had acted differently today, we would have become the

monsters you were taught we were. She-Ra may have saved Etheria from Prime, but you saved it from *us* .”

Chapter 9

Chapter Summary

Day 3: Spire Encampment

Edge of Whispering Wood

Dawn

"Tell me, Little Sister, was it worth it?" asked Prime's gentle, velvet voice. Everything that made her real burned away in Prime's light. Desperately scrabbling at the chip on her neck with her claws, Catra dug in and pulled *.*

Pain at the back of her neck jerked Catra awake. Her claws sank into the skin where the chip had been. Something heavy held her down and she couldn't think what it was or where she could be. The only reason she didn't panic was that Adora's scent was all around her. Then, she recognized the heavy thing was Adora's head on her chest.

"A*re you all right?"* Melog mewled very softly. "*You are bleeding."* They lifted their head and stared at her from the nest of blankets they slept on.

Catra supposed Melog could smell the blood. She sheathed her claws to feel the fresh punctures that throbbed and stung. Her hand came away wet. She pressed against the cuts with the end of the blanket. Their bedding was in dire need of a wash anyway.

"I'm okay. Just...just bad dreams." She whispered, trying to get her bearings. "I get them a lot." She relaxed into the blankets, putting her arms around her softly snoring girlfriend. The weather had changed; the air was cooler and felt damp.

The predawn peace was interrupted by the sound of soft feet creeping around outside of the tent, accompanied by small noises

of things being shifted around the campsite.

Great. Now what?

"Stay there, Granddaughter," Melog purred, standing and stretching. "I *will go see who it is."* Her friend vanished from sight.

That was the second time Melog called Catra "Granddaughter"; she'd have to ask them what it meant. It sounded...nice.

Outside, a soft voice whispered, "Good morning. I didn't wake you did I? I brought breakfast for the Force Captain." It was the voice of the little feline cadet. A pause and the girl giggled. "Hey, quit. You knock the tea over and Agatha will have my hide." She didn't actually sound worried.

"What's going on?" Adora muttered, hearing the voice. She lifted her head from Catra's chest. Her sleepy eyes sharpened as they met Catra's and a soft smile bloomed across her face. "Hey, Catra," she said. She snuggled back down into the bedding, shifting around so that her head rested on the pillow instead of the smaller woman's chest. Tentatively, she reached out to stroke Catra's hair.

Catra wanted to say something clever or charming, but nothing came to mind. Instead, she just melted into Adora's touch, purring loudly. Breakfast could wait.

Adora leaned forward and brushed her lips against Catra's, slowly trailing her hand down Catra's back to the sensitive spot at the base of her tail. Heat pooled low in Catra's belly as Adora skimmed her other hand gently over Catra's hair, brushing the fur under her ears and chin.

Something in that light touch felt unbearably familiar. In rare affectionate moments, Shadow Weaver liked to caress the dark blond tufts of hair that grew below her ears. It was the only way the woman ever touched Catra gently.

Prime had found those memories and mocked her for her presumption, the idea that a creature like her could ever be loved.

Prime.

All that delicious heat turned to cold lead in her stomach. She stiffened under Adora's hands, pulling back to stare into Adora's eyes, looking for a tell-tale glint of green in her girlfriend's gray-blue. Waiting for those warm, sword-callused hands to wrap around her throat as they changed to metal-tipped talons.

This isn't real, a panicked voice within Catra's head gibbered. *This **can't** be real. Adora didn't...she **wouldn't** come back for me. This isn't real.*

Adora stared back at her, confused. "You okay?" she asked. Her voice didn't morph into His voice. Her face didn't splinter into shards of green light. The air stayed damp and the scent of a newly kindled fire drifted in from outside.

Melog bounded inside, their mane dark and jagged. "*Granddaughter?"* they asked, looking askance at Adora. "*What has frightened you?"*

At the sound of her friend's question, the icy terror of unreality drained away. The heat was back, only this time it was hot rage flooding through her. *Prime doesn't get to ruin this,* Catra told herself fiercely.

She hitched a smile onto her face for Adora's sake and covered the other woman's hand with her own. "Yeah, I'm okay." She hesitated, searching for a way to smooth over the awkwardness. She whispered into Adora's ear, "It's just...I can hear people starting to wake up. And that cadet is just outside. Felina. She hears as well as I do." Adora never questioned Catra on her superior hearing. "And...You know. I just…" she shrugged and looked away, hoping that Adora would read her as merely shy.

Adora chuckled. "Yeah. I get it." Her cheeks turned a little red. "We can wait until we get to somewhere with a lock on the door."

She lowered her voice even more and whispered into Catra's ear, "And if that cadet outside can hear as well as you do...well...she's going to be freaked out enough that we're bunking together. Let's not make her listen to us making out."

"Yeah, let's not," Catra said to Adora, her smile feeling more genuine. To Melog she said more loudly, "We'll be right out."

Melog's mane and tale smoothed out but their eyes narrowed. "*You do not answer my question. What has made you frightened?"*

"Nope," Catra replied, hoping they'd get the idea. "We'll just put on some clothes and see what fresh hell the day brings."

"Well, aren't you chipper?" Adora grinned, jumping up. "Anyway, I'm starving." Stretching, she reached for the clothes she wore yesterday. "Perfuma gave me a bag full of stuff last night, so we're not stuck eating rations again." She wrinkled her nose and discarded the shirt she had in her hand, grabbing a clean-ish (or at least less dirty) one from her bag instead. "I need to do laundry today."

"*You are still avoiding my question."* Melog's tail darkened in displeasure.

"Yep," Catra said amiably to Melog, while she pulled on her own clothes. "Why don't you see if the cadet brought something you like?"

*"We will discuss this later," t*he great cat told her firmly, before walking out. They left Catra with the distinct impression that they were worried about her. She didn't understand what the big deal was. So, she had a bad minute, what was the point of talking about it? She didn't want to discuss this with anyone, even Melog. And she certainly didn't want Adora to know that Prime was still taking up this much room in her head.

"I know what Prime did to you." Spinnerella's words from last night echoed through her mind again. When the Princess said it,

Catra feared the worst; that those things Catra had convinced herself had merely been Prime-induced nightmares to torture her had happened for real. And that everyone *knew*.

The Princess's confession that Prime was still influencing her thinking had been unexpected and unsettling. Catra wondered if her own thinking was still being influenced. That was a spooky thought; could Prime still be sabotaging their efforts, even though he was dead and gone? Certainly, the whole drama from yesterday could have ended very badly if not for Melog's help. And she wondered suddenly about her own reaction to the whole mess. Had the chip left traces in her head? Implanted ideas and commands that could be triggered, like old First One's tech?

"Catra?" Adora had pulled her clothes on and stood with her arms folded and head cocked. "You okay?"

"Huh? Yeah, I'm fine." Catra realized that she had stopped moving and had been staring off into space. "Just thinking."

The blond woman's eyebrows knitted together as she closed the distance between them. "Are you sure?" She reached out to take her hand. "Listen," she said softly. "If you want to leave today, we can. We can go anywhere you want." She leaned her forehead against Catra's and squeezed her hands.

"What? And leave Scorpia and Sparkles to clean up this mess by themselves?" Catra smiled faintly, dragging herself away from her grim thoughts. "They'd never forgive us." She brushed Adora's lips with her own. "Why don't you go see what sort of breakfast you can make from what Perfuma gave us. You could even see what Agatha sent us over. It's probably just ration bars. I'll be out in a minute."

Adora shook her head. "I'm not going out there alone. I'm pretty sure Agatha would be happy to shoot me if I scare her cadets again."

“Yeah, well, it’s your own fault. I was kind of hoping that She-Ra could avoid making an appearance while we were surrounded by a whole bunch of Horde troops.”

“Sorry.” Adora sighed, squeezing Catra’s hand before going to get her boots. “Those cadets…” Her voice had turned pensive, “they aren’t that much younger than we were when...” she trailed off.

“When you found the sword.” Catra finished for her.

“Yeah.”

For a moment all that old pain stood between them.

“Catra...I…” Adora began, her eyes filled with remorse.

They were *not* having this conversation right now. “Don’t.” The word came out more harshly than Catra meant it to, so she tried again. “I mean, just...Not right now. Okay? Please?”

“Okay.” Adora’s voice was soft. “I’ll just go see if I can figure out breakfast, if...if you need a minute.”

As much as Catra didn’t want to admit it, she did need a minute. She was used to being alone and all this *togetherness* was exhausting. She felt like she hadn’t had a second to herself to process anything from the last few weeks. She nodded, closing her eyes. When she opened them again, Adora was gone.

The sound of boots against gravel made Felina jump up from where she crouched by the fire. She turned to greet the person who bunked with Force Captain Catra last night.

It was *that* woman. The one who turned into a Princess. The one who turned into *She Ra.*

“Oh! Um...hi?” the cadet's voice went squeaky with fear. She hesitated, hand half raised, knees bent, eyes wide, fighting every fiber of her being that wanted to run.

"Good morning." The Princess's voice was friendly and she smiled.

Felina took a deep breath, pulling herself together and coming to attention, snapping off a sharp, inspection-quality salute. “Ma’am. Good morning, ma’am.”

“As you were, cadet,” The woman said, returning the salute. "And, thank you for starting breakfast."

“Yes, ma’am.” Felina didn’t even try to return the smile. She went back to crouching at the fire while keeping one nervous eye on the woman who stood as though wondering what to do.

"Do you need any help?"

"No, ma'am. Thank you, ma'am."

After a moment, the Princess opted to head to the latrine. Felina irritably smoothed her fluffed-up tail as the woman walked away.

Melog paced over to sit next to the girl, sniffing at the different containers she’d lined up. “Agatha said you might like this,” she told the creature, pouring a little of the white stuff Agatha bought from some civilians into a flat metal bowl. The Cadet Commander had given most of it to the little kids this morning, but she’d sent the rest of it over with Felina for the Force Captain and her friends.

The little “mrrop” noise that Melog made before neatly licking it all up sounded appreciative.

The woman came back just then. Melog licked Felina’s face and, to her dismay, trotted back into the tent, leaving Felina alone with the Princess. The cadet reminded herself that this woman was no longer supposed to be the enemy. The Rebel girl Felina made friends with last night, Frosta, seemed to know her personally. Frosta said that Adora only became She Ra because she was scared for Catra.

That seemed pretty fucked up, if you asked Felina, but it wasn't her business to question who the Force Captain was bunking with.

Steeling herself, Felina walked up to the Princess who was starting to sift around in the various bags of food. "Ma'am?" she said, with as much courtesy as she could muster. "Agatha sent me over with tea and breakfast for the Force Captain. And for you and Melog. Would you like me to pour you some?"

"That's nice. Thank you." The Princess smiled and sat down on the ground. Felina carefully poured the prepared tea and handed her a steaming hot cup. "Oh. This is good!" the woman exclaimed, surprised. "Where did you find milk and honey?"

"Is that what you call it?" asked Felina. "Last night, Agatha found some farmers who brought carts of things to trade. I guess we're not far from some of the Rebel settlements. She told me to put it in the tea because it makes it better. I've never had it like that, but she said that's the way they used to make it when she was young."

"So…" the woman asked, sounding awkward. "Have you always been in Agatha's squad?"

Felina nodded, stiffly. "My folks were both infantry."

"Were?"

"My father was killed when I was little." *By a Princess,* she didn't add. "I don't remember him much. " She shrugged, trying to pretend the questions didn't bother her, but her treacherous tail lashed with agitation. "I'm assigned to Agatha's cadre when my mom is deployed. You know how it is."

The woman didn't seem like she did, because she asked, "where's your mom, now?"

"I haven't seen my mom since before Prime came. She was part of the Final Assault on the Rebels." Felina tried to keep her voice

even. “Agatha asked to be notified when she or anyone from her unit checks in." The cadet wasn't going to tell a Princess, especially not *She Ra,* that her mom was listed as missing.

“I’m sorry.” The Princess stared into her tea.

The girl clenched her teeth and shook her head. “Yeah, whatever,” she muttered to herself.

“Hey, Felina.” Catra and Melog finally came out of the tent.

“Force Captain.” Felina jumped up again to give the Force Captain her best salute. “Cadet Commander Agatha sent me over. I brought breakfast and she said I should ask if you need anything done, y’know like...like laundry.” She hadn’t been trying to overhear but the blonde woman was loud and their clothes were in almost as bad a shape as Felina’s.

Catra smiled, showing a fang. “Yeah? That’s nice of her, but I don’t usually need an aid in the field. I mean, I figured your whole squad was ready for some lazing around in the sun.”

Felina’s cheeks turned red. She’d been hoping that Catra would just accept being sent someone to do her camp chores was just her due as an officer and not question it. Unfortunately, now that she’d been asked, she had to answer. “Yes, ma’am. But, I’m on punishment," she admitted.

Catra’s eyes narrowed and her tail fluffed a little bit. “Seriously?” she growled. “What for?”

Felina shrank into herself. “We...Lee, Mike, and I...we violated your orders, Force Captain,” she whispered. “Agatha was really mad. So, when I got up this morning, she read me the riot act and said I was on punishment for the rest of the day. She said I should report to you to see if you needed anything done around camp. If you don’t, I’m supposed to report to Scorpia.”

The Princess looked at Catra in confusion. “What orders?”

“The orders that no one armed with anything less than an energy weapon should even *think* about taking on a Princess. *Especially* She Ra,” Catra supplied with an irritable sigh. She crossed her arms against her chest and she looked down at the cadet with an indecipherable frown. “She’s right, you know. I didn’t think about it last night. Where are the other two, then?”

“Lee’s got watch duty for the whole cadre and Mike’s already helping Force Captain Scorpia.”

“Why did Agatha send you to me?”

Felina hung her head and mumbled, "Because I went after She Ra.”

“I didn’t hear you, cadet. What?”

“Because I tried to take on She Ra without even a sharp stick.” Felina’s chin went up in defiance suddenly. She’d tried to make Agatha see sense, but no luck. Maybe Catra would understand. “But...but Force Captain! You were down! And that Princess just came out of nowhere! What else were we supposed to do?” she demanded. “Run away like *cowards* ?”

“That’s enough! You *know* what you were supposed to do!” Catra replied, harshly, her ears going back. “Your commander had an energy rifle. You should have gotten behind her like your squadmates did.” She paused and took a deep breath, her mouth hardening. “But you...You just *had* to go play the hero, didn't you?"

The other woman interrupted. “Catra...I’m sure that...” she began as if trying to deflect her ire. Felina’s cheeks burned now. Bad enough that the Princess was witnessing this dressing down; Felina did not need anyone thinking she was too weak to take the consequences of her actions.

Melog bumped their head against the blond woman’s knee, cutting her off. It shook its head in a clear, “mind your own business” gesture and then slunk over to stand beside Catra.

"Cadet...do you know why I gave that order?" Now, Catra's voice dropped to a silky undertone.

Felina shook her head, her eyes wide as she quailed under Catra's stern gaze.

"Because I was *tired* of watching Hordak and Shadow Weaver throw soldiers away," the Force Captain gritted. "I swore we were never going to have the kind of casualties we saw at Bright Moon."

"Yes, ma'am." It had been easy to dismiss Agatha's scoldings as just the old woman being overprotective. It was hard to do the same with Catra; everyone knew she focused on *results*.

Something sad that the girl could only interpret as *disappointment* flitted through the Force Captain's bi-colored eyes. Felina looked down at her feet and her mouth twisted as she held back tears.

Catra sighed and brushed both her hands through her short hair, then she reached toward Felina.

The cadet saw the movement in her periphery and set her teeth so she wouldn't flinch. It wouldn't be the first time one of her commanders gave her a slap on the ear and she figured she deserved it for mouthing off.

Catra completed the gesture by putting her hand on Felina's shoulder. "Look….In a couple of years, you're going to be one of the best, I can tell. We can't afford to lose you or your squadmates. Agatha knows that. I bet you scared the snot out of her."

One of the best? Felina dared to look back up.

Catra was smiling slightly, her hand still on Felina's shoulder. "So, as it happens, we have stacks of laundry to do. But first, I'm hungry. Did you get fed?"

“Agatha gave me half rations this morning...Well, she said it was half, but she gave everyone else double rations, so I got half of what they got.”

The creature standing beside her commented to Catra in a series of mews and purrs. The woman nodded at them in agreement. “All right,” she said to Felina, “Are you still hungry?” She jerked her head in the direction of the supplies Felina had set by the campfire. “You can come sit with us and eat some more.”

“Oh! Yes, ma’am!” Felina wasn’t that hungry, but there was no way she’d turn down that offer.

“You should try this tea the cadet brought.” The Princess said when Catra sat down next to her. “It’s good.”

Felina jumped to pour, handing the hot drink to Catra who sniffed it, her eyebrows knitting. “This is the tea Scorpia makes,” she said. “She told me it was an old family thing or something?”

Felina nodded. “Yes, ma’am. Agatha is Scorpia’s grandfather’s sister. She told me.”

The Princess looked startled, “Wait. Wasn’t Scorpia’s grandfather the king before Hordak came?”

Felina shrugged. “I don’t know. I guess so.”

“We should talk to Glimmer about this,” The Princess said slowly. “If Scorpia is the Fright Zone’s Princess, I think that makes Agatha the Queen of the Fright Zone.”

Chapter 10

Chapter Summary

> The first meeting of the Etherian Committee for Truth and Reconciliation begins.

"You got quiet," Catra said to Adora after sending Felina to go find Agatha. "And you hardly ate anything. Are you okay?"

Adora hadn't moved from her spot near the fire. "I'm okay," she said automatically, pouring herself another cup of Agatha's tea and adding milk. Now she sat staring at the cloudy formations the milk made in the tea and felt Catra's concerned eyes on her. Melog pressed their soothing warmth into her side; she put her hand on their head.

"You are such a shitty liar. Does it work with Sparkles and Arrow Boy?" Catra sighed and took a seat on her other side. "So, are you going to tell me what's up, or should I just guess?"

Closing her eyes, Adora wished she wasn't so adept at reading the feline girl's body language. The cadet had put on her best game face, but Adora hadn't missed the way Felina tiptoed around like she was a snake that might bite any second. "I guess it was upsetting that she was so scared of me."

"What did you expect?" Catra's voice was matter-of-fact rather than scornful, and Adora was grateful for that. "Seriously, come on, the Princesses have been the enemy her whole life." Her tone softened, and she draped the end of her tail over Adora's forearm reassuringly. "She'll get over it. They all will." When Adora didn't reply, Catra elbowed her in the side. "Hey."

Adora opened her eyes, and Catra smiled impishly. "Eat something, dummy." She held out one of the fruits Perfuma gave them. "Moping isn't going to fix anything."

Adora took a drink of her tea and a couple of bites of the fruit. "I know. I just…" The lump in her throat and the knot in her stomach made it hard to choke it down, even though it was one of her favorites. "I'm just not used to seeing people scared of me."

"Yeah, that's more my thing." Catra looked away, and her ears went back.

After a minute, Adora bumped her shoulder against Catra's. "You were good with her."

Catra shifted uncomfortably, her cheeks going red, but she smiled a little. "It's not a big deal. Anyway, finish that. I told Felina to ask Agatha if she'd meet with Scorpia, Sparkles, and us. We should figure out how we're going to approach this mess."

"Glimmer and Bow said they'd meet us here as soon as they woke up." Adora took another sip of tea. "I had no idea that Scorpia had any family left. She never mentioned it to me."

Catra shook her head. "Me neither. I wonder if they covered that in Force Captain orientation?"

"Wait…" Adora turned to stare at her, her jaw-dropping in surprise. "There's an orientation?"

Catra smirked. "So, Shadow Weaver didn't tell you about it either?"

"No." It occurred to Adora how little contact she had with anyone other than their small squad and Shadow Weaver's hand-picked instructors. Thinking about Agatha and the cadets, she said, "do you ever get the feeling that being raised by Shadow Weaver sucked even by Fright Zone standards? Shadow Weaver probably would have thrown a fit at us for *not* going after a Princess."

"The old hag gave *me* a hard enough time for not bringing you back."

Catra's mutter was low enough that Adora didn't think she was supposed to hear that. Nevertheless, she felt like it needed an answer. "Catra...I…" She just didn't have one.

"Can we not talk about it?"

Melog stood up and moved to sit next to Catra. They said something that made Catra's ears go back. "Fine. We'll talk," she replied to them with an eye roll. "Just not today, okay? I'm pretty sure we have more important things to worry about."

They probably did have more important things to worry about, but Adora wished they didn't. All she wanted to do was talk about the last three days--the last three *years.* But Catra was right. It wasn't fair to leave everything up to Glimmer.

"Look who's up." Catra nudged Adora and pointed. Mermista walked towards them from the direction of the middle of the camp.

"She looks rough."

Catra sniggered behind her hand. "I thought 'green around the gills' was just a metaphor. And she's staggering like Shadow Weaver first thing in the morning."

"How's it going, Mermista?" Adora called out, concerned. The Water Princess looked bad; dark circles underlined her eyes, and her tanned face did indeed have a greenish, sallow cast.

The woman groaned and flopped down onto her back, on the ground next to Adora. "Seahawk found some rum last night and we split the bottle. I don't remember much after that."

"According to Netossa, you were singing sea shanties," Catra said with equal parts amusement and malice.

"Oh gods," Mermista moaned, covering her face with one arm, possibly to block out the light. "I did, didn't I?"

“Do you want something to eat?” Adora asked.

Mermista shook her head, then sat up, looking alarmed. She unceremoniously threw up into the grass. “Someone, please do me a favor and just kill me now,” she begged when she was done, clutching her stomach.

“Why don’t you go back to bed?” Adora asked gently.

“Can’t,” whined Mermista. “Glimmer wants me at some stupid meeting. She told me yesterday to meet her here, and if I don’t show, she’d just come to find me.”

“Sparkles doesn’t fight fair.” Catra shook her head and poured out the last of the tea. “Here, Agatha sent it over. It’s the tea Scorpia makes. It’s supposed to be soothing.”

Mermista looked at the proffered cup as though it might explode before gingerly accepting it. “Thanks,” she muttered. “And...listen...I’m sorry about what happened yesterday. I…”

“It’s fine.” Catra interrupted quickly. “Don’t worry about it.”

Mermista stared at Catra and was silent for a minute. “Okay,” she finally said, “but if you do want to talk about...well anything…” her eyes shifted to Adora and gave her an unreadable look, “you know where to find me.” She drank her tea and gave the cup back, then she laid back down in the grass with her arm across her eyes. “Just wake me up when the others get here. Assuming I survive. Which, if I’m lucky, I won’t.”

“Yeah, you’ll live. You just won’t like it.”

“Ugh. Whatever, Cat-Princess,” Mermista groused without any real heat.

“What is that supposed to mean?” Catra whispered to Adora, looking nonplussed.

The old woman paced back and forth on the perimeter of their little campsite. Agatha told the children that she would take morning watch because her joints were stiff and her bones needed to stretch, but she didn't pretend to herself that she was doing anything but watching for one of her Senior Cadets. She checked her timekeeper every so often, not liking how long it was taking the girl to come back. A lecture or a cuff on the ear took no time, and if she'd been assigned chores, Felina would check-in before she got started.

She had seen no choice this morning but to send the girl to Catra for discipline. According to the report Agatha wrote (just in case someone asked for it), Mike and Lee had frozen from inexperience. A lie, of course, but not the first one Agatha had told in her reports. Over the years, Agatha had taken great lengths to make certain her cadets *never* got referred to Shadow Weaver. In this case, she did what had saved more than one cadet from Shadow Weaver's claws; she referred them for extra training with Scorpia. Her niece loved to train the cadets and Agatha had always made sure to tell Shadow Weaver what a harsh commander and cruel taskmaster Scorpia was.

However, Felina had violated a primary standing order *right in front* of the Force Captain in a way that allowed no interpretation. Catra's seeming restraint in front of the people who gathered to watch the children at play was a hopeful sign, but everyone knew Catra expected obedience as much as Hordak or Shadow Weaver. All Agatha could do was pray to the old Scorpion gods that Catra was as fond of the cat-child as she appeared.

Agatha's heart nearly stopped when she saw Felina racing towards her on all fours as if a battalion of clones were behind her. The girl skidded to a stop, jumping up to salute her. "Report, Felina!" the cadet commander barked, her nerves raw. The child sported no obvious injuries and Agatha relaxed marginally.

"Ma'am! Force Captain Catra sent me to tell you that she's requesting your presence at a meeting with the Princesses."

"What? Why? What else did she say?" the old woman demanded. "What were her exact words?"

Felina blinked, thinking hard. "That blonde woman...the one who turns into a Princess...she was there, and she got really excited when I told her you were related to Force Captain Scorpia."

Agatha sat down slowly on a big rock and handed her clipboard off to the cadet. That was probably the last thing she could have imagined hearing.

"They want to meet with you and Scorpia and...and Queen Glimmer?"

"The Queen of the Princesses?"

"Yes, ma'am. I think so, anyway." Felina's eyes were wide, staring at Agatha as if she'd never seen her before. "Catra's exact words were, 'tell Cadet Commander Agatha I am *requesting* a meeting with her.' She said I should tell you that they're meeting in the big tent at noon. And that Scorpia would be there too."

Agatha wondered what sort of calamity she called down on herself by admitting to the cadets who she was. Since Prime's invasion, the usual stories to comfort these children of soldiers didn't work. The erstwhile royal princess reached back in her memory, recalling the last days of the Scorpian Kingdom and telling the stories of how they survived. She couldn't regret it, not when those stories had gotten them through so many cold, hungry nights, but she dreaded the consequences now. She couldn't imagine that this meeting would yield any good outcome.

"Make me some tea, Felina," she said, hiding her distress. "Did the Force Captain assign you any duties?"

"Yes, ma'am. I'm supposed to do their laundry. I was just going to get water to start." Felina paused, and her tail and ears dropped as she went on in a slightly more subdued voice, "I kinda got yelled at for yesterday." Then her ears came back up. "But, then

she said that Mike, Lee, and I were going to be the *best* in a couple of years!"

Agatha nearly smiled from relief. At least Felina was all right. "How much laundry is there?"

"Not much."

"Finish it before noon. I want you to come with me. Go find Lee and Mike. They're coming too. Tell them to tidy themselves up. Tell Tsion and Amr that they're in charge of the little ones while we're gone."

"Yes. Ma'am."

Precisely at noon, according to her timekeeper, Agatha and the three cadets marched into the tent. The old woman instructed Mike, who was the tallest, to follow her while Felina and Lee flanked in the formation of the Royal Scorpian Guard. If they were going to pull the old titles up, she could play along. She chose these three because they had shown themselves to be the only ones of the children not overwhelmingly terrified of the Princesses.

Like the previous morning, the few people there were seated around a long table. But this time, the Horde was represented by Scorpia and Catra. She relaxed slightly at the friendly smiles they both gave her. The man wasn't there, but the other women from the prior day's group were, as was the blonde woman who turned into She Ra and the dark-haired girl who'd played with the cadets on the previous afternoon. One empty chair was placed between Scorpia and Catra. At the head of the table, a short woman with lavender and pink hair.

"Agatha?" Scorpia said, standing up, her smile huge. "Wow. Thank you *so much* for coming." She strode over and hugged Agatha then took her by the pincer to lead her to the group. "I know you've met everyone sort of, but do you want me to introduce them? Anyway, this is…" She rattled off a list of titles and names

as she pointed to each person. Agatha took none of them in but nodded curtly to each one until Scorpia got to the head of the table. “And this is Queen Glimmer.”

“Of Brightmoon?” Agatha stopped Scorpia, with a sharp gesture of her pincer.

The young woman rose, extending her hand, “Yes, I…”

“I met your mother once,” Agatha said sharply, not taking the invitation to shake the Queen’s hand. “When I was their age.” She waved her claw at her three senior cadets behind her. She was so agitated that her tail shook behind her as she spoke. “My brother sent me to Bright Moon to beg for her help when Hordak’s bots destroyed our defenses and our farmland. We had lost most of our soldiers and my people were starving.”

Scorpia's pincer came up to rest on Agatha's shoulder. "Hey, Agatha..." she said softly, trying to soothe.

Agatha shook her niece off and stepped forward, towering over Queen Glimmer. "Do you know what she told me?"

The young queen took a step back, her eyes huge and she shook her head.

“That we should acquiesce to Hordak’s demands. For the sake of our *people.”* She glared around at the other young women’s shocked faces. “ *She* advised my family to trade our lands and our Runestone for our lives.”

A lifetime of anger rose up in Agatha’s chest and she lost any semblance of caution as a red mist seemed to cover her vision. “She. Was. A. *Coward* .”

Chapter 11

Chapter Summary

Agatha gets her say. Melog lends a paw.

Silence reigned over the shocked council for about thirty seconds. Then the room exploded with denials and outrage.

And this is where it all goes to shit, thought Catra watching Glimmer. The young Queen stood perfectly still, her eyes on Agatha, and balls of lavender sparkles flared around her clenched fists. Catra had seen that expression before when she was on the receiving end of one of Glimmer's powerful blasts. Catra wasn't sure the older woman could live through a direct hit at point-blank range.

Picking up on Catra's panic, Melog became visible, leaped between Agatha and Glimmer, and snarled into Glimmer's face forcing her back. At the same time, Catra dragged her claws across the table. The shriek of nails against the wood made everyone except Glimmer and Agatha wince and cover their ears.

"Sparkles!" Catra barked. "Get a grip!"

Glimmer's purple fire fizzled, her face paler than Catra had ever seen it, and she trembled as she glared at Catra.

"So, what is it you want?" The elderly soldier demanded, not paying attention to the great cat interposed between them, still up for a fight. "You want us to lick your boots for the scraps from your table?"

Before Glimmer could respond, Catra jumped in, facing Agatha, arms outspread. "Do you honestly think that's what this is about? Do you think Scorpia would go along with that? Do you think *I'd* go along with that?"

The woman blinked down at her as if she had forgotten Catra was there. The angry color on her face drained away to a fearful pallor cementing the impression. She stepped back and cleared her throat. "My...apologies, Force Captain. I…overstepped myself." She pushed her hair back from her ashen face with a shaking pincer. Scorpia walked up from behind to put her claw on Agatha's shoulder, and Melog turned away from Glimmer to rub their face on her leg.

"Everyone, calm down," Catra hissed into the now quiet tent. She turned away from Agatha towards the princesses. "You all said you wanted to hear the truth? Are you just going to lose it the first time you hear something that doesn't play well in your story?" she demanded.

"Catra's right," murmured Perfuma. "If we ask people to speak their truth, we have to expect that we might hear...upsetting...things. We should be prepared for that."

Glimmer shut her eyes, visibly trying to wrestle her rage down to manageable proportions. She took a deep breath, opening her eyes to face the oldest member of the Scorpion Kingdom's royalty. "My mother," she hesitated over the words, "made...mistakes."

A skeptical noise from Agatha's throat met this admission.

"Agatha…" Adora stood to speak, her voice rough and thick. "I know Angella...regretted...not helping your kingdom." She swallowed, wrapping her arms over her chest. "I was the last person to see her. She...she told me…" Every word seemed to be dragged painfully from Adora's lips. "She...well, she said some things I didn't understand, but I know what she meant now. When she *sacrificed…"* Her voice broke on the last word, tears running down her face. She mopped her eyes with her sleeve and coughed before continuing, "sacrificed herself, it wasn't for me or Glimmer or even Bright Moon. It was for all of Etheria." She looked apologetically at Glimmer. "And to...make up for mistakes she made."

“My mother hated fighting. She wanted to do anything to avoid it.” Something changed in Glimmer’s face. All her fury drained out of her expression. What remained was pain, so naked and raw, Catra had to look away. “We...argued...about it...all the time.” Glimmer walked back to her seat and sat down. Adora moved to stand behind her, putting her hand on the Queen's shoulder. "I’m sorry," Glimmer said heavily, looking down at the tabletop and reaching up to squeeze Adora’s hand.

“ *What?* ” Agatha gritted as though she didn’t credit her ears.

Glimmer raised her eyes, her expression determined. "I am sorry Bright Moon abandoned you. I am sorry for what happened. I know nothing we do here can make up for it, but I just need you to know I'm not my mother."

Agatha swayed dangerously on her feet and raised her pincer to her chest as if in pain. Hastily, Scorpia took her by the arm and guided her to sit at the table.

“Hey, Mike?” Scorpia called out without turning around. “Go pour Agatha some tea. I left the pot brewing in the cook tent. It’s the next tent over.”

“Yes, Force Captain.”

Glancing around at the faces of the committee, Scorpia amended her order. “You know what? I think we could all use some. Why don’t you bring a whole tray?”

Mike saluted and left the tent with Lee on his heels.

“Are you...all right?” Perfuma asked Agatha gently when it seemed that the veteran had recovered a little.

“Yes, of course,” Agatha grunted. It was clearly a lie. She was pale and sweating, her claws still trembling. But, she squared her shoulders and addressed the gathered Princesses in a firm voice. “You still haven’t told me what you want with me.”

At first, no one answered. "Well," Scorpia finally said, looking around at the others, "we do need to talk about what to do with Hordak and figure out who's going to run the place now that he's gone." She rubbed the back of her neck with her pincer.

"I suppose they'll want to appoint someone, will they?" Agatha waved dismissively at the Princesses.

"Um…" Scorpia shifted, her cheeks turning red, and she looked at Perfuma, who gave her a bright smile and a thumbs up. "They sort of figured that maybe you...I mean we...I mean, since we're the last of the family left, and I'm connected to the Garnet now, and maybe you and I could…" She trailed off, looking worried.

Perfuma picked up where Scorpia left off. "We hoped we could restore the lost Scorpion Kingdom. And if you're the former king's sister, well, that makes you the Queen," she nervously twisted her hands together and added, "although you can call yourself any title you want."

Agatha looked around at all of them, her eyes narrow and suspicious. "You're serious?"

Glimmer held her eyes. "Yes. And that's why we asked you to come here. We can't let old mistakes tear us apart again. You should have your land and your Runestone restored."

"What did Hordak think he could even do with the Black Garnet, anyway?" Mermista suddenly broke in. "That always confused me. Like, Runestones don't even work for anyone but the royal families. Right?"

"Well, actually," Entrapta's voice sang from the corner of the tent. Without looking up from the device, she was fiddling with, she said, "Hordak knew that the Garnet was some kind of power source, but he couldn't get it to work. The Runestones are pretty much big magical batteries. The First Ones created them to harness the planet's native magic. Each is keyed to a particular genetic signature of their respective ruling families. I'm not sure

how Scorpia's family lost their connection. I figured it was when Scorpia's grandfather died. But I didn't know there was a member of that generation alive until today. Shadow Weaver was able to make it work for her, but I'm not sure how. I only used it as a conduit, not as a battery."

" *Were* you connected to the Black Garnet?" Spinnerella asked Agatha.

"Yes." The woman's voice was flat, devoid of emotion.

That one word seemed to be all she was willing to say. Spinnerella waited for a second, then continued with her soft questioning. "Was the connection lost when your brother was killed? Or did something else happen?"

The big woman seemed to shrink as if she wanted to disappear into her chair. Closing her eyes, she wrapped her arms around herself and shuddered. "Shadow Weaver *happened,* " she muttered.

Catra flinched. "Of course," she hissed to no one in particular, her hackles and tail fluffed up.

"She never got control completely. I made sure of that." Agatha shrugged; a jerky defensive motion. Opening her eyes, she wouldn't look at any of their faces. Instead, she uncrossed her arms and stared at her claws. "I never let any of my nieces near the damned thing, so they never had to feel what Shadow Weaver did to it."

Glimmer and Perfuma shared uneasy looks with Scorpia and Adora.

"Where is Shadow Weaver, anyway?" Frosta piped up suddenly.

Catra jumped. So focused was she on Agatha's story that it took a second for her to understand the question. Glimmer's eyes darted first to Catra, and then she turned to look over her shoulder at

Adora. Catra met Adora's eyes in surprise over Glimmer's head. "Didn't you tell anyone?"

Adora's eyes glistened as she shook her head. "I...no."

Well, it was a lot to process, Catra supposed. The others looked at Adora expectantly. She looked down at the floor and gave no sign of answering, so Catra took a deep breath. "Shadow Weaver is dead."

Scorpia cleared her throat, glancing uncertainly at Adora and then Catra. "Um, okay. Are you sure? I mean, she's a sorceress...she could have…"

"No. We…" Catra indicated Adora with a tilt of her chin, "saw her die." Her voice did not break at the words, but she was grateful for Melog's warm bulk suddenly pressing against her. "Trust me. She's not coming back." For some reason, Catra's eyes burned. She coughed to swallow the lump in her throat and sat down. Adora left Glimmer to sit back in the chair next to Catra, reaching out for her hand.

The cadets came back with a tray full of steaming cups of tea. Felina hurried to help the other two serve. Everyone seemed glad of the momentary break as the three of them passed out tea, milk, and honey.

"Agatha?" Catra heard Felina whisper under cover of giving her commander her tea. "Are you okay? Should I go find your remedy?"

"I'm all right, girl. The tea's enough. Don't fuss." Agatha returned with gruff affection, patting her hand. Catra's stomach clenched, and drops of water appeared on the hand that held her tea as she stared down into her cup, pretending she didn't hear.

Adora squeezed her free hand, and Catra took some deep, slow breaths, trying to get a grip on her runaway emotions.

"The Old One is in pain," Melog chirruped suddenly at Catra, indicating Agatha.

Grateful for the distraction, Catra bent down to talk to her friend. "Yeah. It sounds like she's another Shadow Weaver casualty," she said softly into their ear, remembering the times she'd heard the sorceress raging at the Garnet.

"T*he bond she has to the stone is weak and corrupted. It hurts her. I could try to heal it, but I fear my magic would be too wild. I believe Etheria's Protector,"* they flicked an ear towards Adora, *"can help her."*

Catra nodded, filing the thought away for later. Agatha would not thank her for bringing it up in front of everyone, and she'd have to ask Adora how the whole healing thing worked, but Melog seemed pretty certain.

"The Old One is proud," Melog agreed. *"Perhaps the Queen should offer to have the Protector heal the Runestone. As a gesture of reparation. Tell the Old One that the Dark One left it damaged."*

"Yeah, but isn't the Garnet fixed now?" Catra thought the magic that the Failsafe had liberated should have healed the thing.

"The Runestone itself feels intact, yes, but the Old One was injured long ago and never properly healed. Her magic bleeds. *"*

" Yeah, I doubt she'll want to talk about that."

"Frame the problem as a flaw in the Stone. You can say that it does not affect her kin," Melog flicked their ear towards Scorpia this time, *"in the same way because she made her bond so recently."*

That sounded like a good idea--Agatha wouldn't have to admit to weakness. She could pull Sparkles and Adora aside later to…

"*Not later."* Melog suddenly interrupted her thought, their mane dark and jagged. "*She suffers, and we have the means to end it.*

Now.”

This was only the second time since she’d known Melog that they were so insistent. Slowly she sat up, trying to think of how to phrase it. “Hey, folks? Before we talk about Hordak or whatever, I need to tell you that Melog says that Shadow Weaver damaged the Black Garnet,” she said to the room at large. “They say that it will eventually be a problem for Scorpia if we leave it like that.” Not really a lie, and she had everyone’s attention. Perfuma and Frosta especially leaned forward with concern. “Melog says She Ra can heal it through Agatha’s connection.”

Glimmer nodded but said, “We can certainly get to that, but first we should…”

Catra cut her off. “No, they say it’s important to do it now. “ She flicked her eyes towards Agatha and hoped Sparkles was quick on the uptake. “Do you remember what Shadow Weaver did with the Black Garnet when she captured you? Do you remember how it affected you? That weird thing that you did?”

Glimmer looked confused for a second, but then her eyebrows knitted with worry. “Scorpia’s going to start glitching?”

Catra was glad they’d come up with a word for it. She’d only seen it once, and that was from far away, but she knew it was a result of being zapped by Shadow Weaver. “I’m not sure. But Melog feels like it’s important that it gets fixed right now.” She looked pointedly at Agatha again. “They say She Ra can heal the stone through Agatha’s bond with it.”

“I’m not letting any *Princess* touch me,” growled the woman.

Catra knew that Agatha would very likely obey if she ordered it, but the thought of just forcing it on the old soldier made her feel physically sick.

She stood up so they could be at eye level and was suddenly struck by how much Agatha’s grim visage resembled Scorpia’s. “Agatha, I won’t order it. I’m *asking*. Let She Ra use her magic to

fix it. I can absolutely promise that you won't be harmed," she said, holding the other woman's eyes. Knowing how deep the distrust for princesses and sorcerers ran, Catra didn't even bother trying to persuade Agatha that Adora wasn't a threat. Instead, she tried a tactic Agatha would respect. "Melog will watch over you while she does it. They know magic. If She Ra tries anything to hurt you, Melog will rip her throat out themself."

The princesses made a few little noises of negation at the idea of that, but Catra knew Adora would get it.

"The Rebellion *owes* us this," Catra insisted, throwing a hand out to indicate the other women. "It was their fault Hordak gave it to Shadow Weaver in the first place. They should fix it." She added a little more bait. "I want to make sure the thing is safe for Scorpia." At the mention of Scorpia, Agatha's eyes widened, and she looked uncertain. Dropping her voice, Catra went on, "Melog says it *has* to be through you. Scorpia's bond with it is too new." She saw Agatha wavering with indecision and went in for the kill. "Please." She allowed her tail and ears to droop, knowing that Agatha had a pretty good read of her body language. "I took enough damage from that fucking stone myself. I just want to make sure it won't hurt anyone else." The tremor in her voice was entirely unfeigned.

Agatha stared at her for a long time before she sighed and said, "All right. If it will help Scorpia."

Catra turned. "So, Sparkles, Adora? What do you say? We'll call it part of the peace treaty. You know, as part of the reparations?"

"Wait. Reparations?" Mermista blurted out. "How do you figure *we* owe reparations?"

Catra opened her mouth, but Glimmer beat her to it, "What happened to Agatha...It was harm that *we* caused." Her voice was soft but certain. "Not just abandoning the Scorpion Kingdom. Shadow Weaver was trained in Mystacor. If she hadn't fooled around with it, the Stone would have been just a curiosity, I'm

betting." She met Catra's eyes and gave her a small, rueful smile.

Adora was already standing to summon her sword. She smiled at Catra, eyes shining, and then the bright golden light engulfed her. When the light show cleared, She Ra still gazed at Catra for a split second with that same expression of unbridled affection.

It was a lot to bear. Catra hastily averted her eyes to check on how the cadets were doing with all this.

To their credit, the three cadets didn't make a peep. The scent of fear wafted from Mike and Felina. Lee's scent didn't change, but that was mostly because lizardfolk didn't sweat.

Scorpia scooted her chair over so she could be closer to Agatha. "I know it's been rough," Scorpia said gently. She put her pincer on Agatha's and smiled brightly. "But really, these guys are pretty great, once you give them a chance. And you know how brilliant Catra is." She waved her other pincer in Catra and She Ra's direction. "If she says She Ra can help, well, she definitely can."

The confidence in Scorpia's voice and the unexpected praise made Catra's cheeks burn.

She Ra smiled at Catra again and asked, "So what does Melog want me to do?"

Melog shrank down to the size of a large housecat and leaped onto Agatha's lap, facing She Ra. "*Tell her that I will guide her since the Old One is so frightened. She will understand what I show her. Tell her to put her hand on me."*

"Put your hand on Melog," Catra translated. "They said they could show you."

She Ra nodded and dropped to one knee in front of Agatha. With a flash, the sword morphed into a golden bracelet and appeared on She Ra's wrist. That was good; Catra had been kind of worried that she'd need to point it at Agatha or something. The only times

that Catra had seen She Ra use her healing, Catra had literally been in the middle of it and hadn't been in any shape to take notes on how it worked.

She Ra reached out and placed her hand on Melog's back. For a long minute, nothing happened.

"Oh." She Ra made a tiny sound of comprehension. A golden glow enveloped her, then surrounded Melog and then Agatha. Catra squinted, but the light dazzle made her turn away.

The three cadets had given up their stoic, soldierly bearing. Now they just looked like the frightened children they were as they held hands, staring horrified as a *Princess* did who-knows-what to their CO. One of them made a sound that might have been a sob. Catra moved closer to them. She was terrible at comforting people, but Melog had been encouraging her to try. She put one hand on Mike's shoulder and the other on Felina's. She didn't quite know how it happened, but in a flurry of motion, the three of them wrapped their arms around Catra.

"Whoa! Hey! It's okay," she exclaimed, awkwardly trying to relax into the four-way hug. It wasn't easy since both Mike and Lee were already almost her size. She could feel them shaking. She stretched out her arms to include all of them. "It'll be all right, I promise."

The light faded, and She Ra shivered out of existence. Adora knelt in her place, looking up at Agatha. "How do you feel?" She asked softly.

"I feel...better," Agatha replied, sounding surprised, a smile playing at the corners of her lips. "Much better." Her voice sounded stronger, less tired, and she moved less stiffly. Her too-long, unkempt hair, which had been iron grey, rippled to white and her resemblance to Scorpia was much more evident now that the lines in her face that spoke of pain were smoothed away.

"Told you!" exclaimed Scorpia, hugging Agatha.

"Awww. Look! Have you ever seen anything so *cute?* " Catra heard Spinnerella whisper almost inaudibly to Netossa, sounding overcome with delight. When Catra looked, the two women were beaming at her and the cadets.

Felina heard the comment too. Her ears went up, and she jumped back, her head anxiously snapping up to look at Catra, possibly worried that she was going to get yelled at. Her sudden movement made the two boys seem to realize what they were doing. The two cadets relaxed their holds on Catra more slowly, looking sheepish as they edged away. "S-sorry, Force C-captain," Mike stuttered, sounding almost Kyle-like.

"It's fine," she told the three of them with what she hoped was an understanding smile.

"Yes, ma'am," Lee muttered in Lizardspeak, wiping his nose with his sleeve. Felina blushed, and Mike gave Catra a tiny watery smile.

On impulse, she gave the three of them a slow blink and was rewarded when they all grinned shyly and returned it. Felina had obviously told them what it meant.

"Hey, why don't you three go find some food," Catra told the cadets. "Go tell them in the cook tent that Queen Glimmer sent you over for your lunch. Tell them you're to bring back the committee's lunch after your break, ok? That gives them time to prepare it while you eat."

"Yes, ma'am." The three scampered out after saluting.

As the three left, she noticed everyone in the tent staring at her, smiling broadly. "What?" She challenged. "The best officers always feed their people first." She asserted, crossing her arms a little defensively, waiting for someone to accuse her of getting soft.

Agatha nodded, beaming at Catra. "I have always believed that."

Chapter 12

Chapter Summary

Reunions are the best.

Chapter Notes

I'm still alive. I'm currently working in a pandemic-related job during the Omicron surge. Enjoy the stress writing.

Day 10, Post VE (Victory on Etheria) Day

Spire Encampment

The road through the Whispering Woods that led in the direction of Bright Moon was busy, as was the road to the Fright Zone. They met right in the middle of the camp, at the foot of the Spire that marked the newly-drawn border between the Hordelands and the Woods. Scattered Horde soldiers continued to flood in from distant outposts, either wanting to go home or looking for friends and family.

Princess Entrapta had been repairing the comms, but she said it would be months before it was back to normal with all the damaged equipment. In the absence of reliable communication, someone had hung some message boards on the spire wall. People left written notes on them full of messages like, “Darryl! Megan and Kai are safe and well!” and, “Any members of the 34th Infantry Battalion left?” There were also many pictures of people, mostly captioned with, “Have you seen this person?”

“Felina?” Lee called to her. “You coming?”

“Huh?” Felina broke away from staring at the bulletin boards with an effort, pretending she was just curious. “Yes, I’m here.” Hissing to herself, she hurried to catch up; she couldn’t afford to be daydreaming. This was supposed to be the day they signed the treaty. There was going to be a ceremony right in front of the

Spire. They were swearing in the new government. Then the new government was signing the treaty with the Princess Alliance. Tomorrow, Queen Glimmer and the other Princesses would head back to their own lands. Today was going to be a ton of work.

Every morning this week, as Catra's formally appointed aid-in-the-field (Catra had promoted her, Mike and Lee, the minute they were no longer on punishment duty), Felina went to their campsite before dawn to start their fire, make them breakfast, and do their camp chores. Usually, she would hear the two women talking. Felina heard them making out a couple of times as she had on that first morning. She would always announce herself by talking to Melog or singing to herself so she could pretend not to; she knew a good aid kept their officer's secrets and didn't judge.

This morning when Felina got there, Catra sat on the ground with Melog, staring into the fire.

"Catra?" Felina asked timidly (it felt so strange just to call her by her name and not her rank, but the woman insisted), "Is everything okay?" Her CO looked pale in the firelight as she nibbled on a ration bar and drank tea. For a second, Felina feared she was about to get a lecture for sleeping late.

"I'm okay." The woman smiled crookedly and blinked slowly at Felina, letting her ears come forward. "I think I must have overdone it last night." The girl relaxed, relieved that she wasn't the problem. "It's been a long week."

Felina returned the blink shyly. "Yeah." It had been a long week. The negotiations had dragged on and on until they'd finally hammered out something everyone could live with.

Melog bounded over, greeting her with a trill that rose in pitch, ending with a purr. Felina thought it meant "good morning." At least they only ever said it in the morning, and it was what they always said when she arrived. She tried to say the greeting back

to them, and she must have come close because they trotted over to bump their head against her, seeming pleased.

The crooked smile became more genuine for a moment, then Catra cleared her throat. “Listen, I wanted to tell you,” she began, “I’ve….”

“Catra?!” Adora called, sounding worried.

“I’m out here,” Catra stood up and turned to smile at Adora coming out of the tent, her expression soft and happy as she held out her hand.

Whatever Catra had been about to say got lost in the flurry of morning chores and planning. They had a lot of ground to cover today.

After breakfast, Adora headed out to meet with the other princesses while it was still dark. It was two hours after dawn now. Catra, Scorpia, and Agatha were deep in conversation as Felina, Mike, and Lee trailed behind. The ceremony was going to be at noon, and they still had preparations to make.

“Are you sure, Wildcat? I mean…Are you *sure* ?” Scorpia was asking as they walked. Felina had been distracted and hadn’t heard the original question.”

“Yeah. I’m sure.” Catra said. Felina saw that her tail was straight behind her, wary and alert as they walked up to the site of the ceremony.

Princess Perfuma was already there, arranging flowers for decorations. When she saw their group, she gave the primate-type people she had gathered around her some instructions and sent them on their way. “Scorpia!” she called, giggling and clapping her hands together before racing towards them.

Watching a Princess move towards them at that speed was still harrowing, but Felina kept her claws sheathed (barely). The Princess ended the attack by leaping into Scorpia’s arms, still

giggling. Scorpia spun around, easily swinging Perfuma's weight in her arms as she carried her like a child.

"I'm so glad you're back," Princess Perfuma told Scorpia, but then she moved her eyes to smile warmly at the rest of them, making them feel like she was glad to see them too.

Agatha shook her head, "Don't be charming my niece away." Felina recognized the mock stern voice Agatha was using. The voice she used when she felt she was supposed to give you a reprimand that she disagreed with. "I'm already missing a Force Captain *and* a Council member."

"What..?" Perfuma asked, but then she followed Agatha's gaze to Catra, who looked away, pinning back her ears with one arm wrapped around herself while her tail lashed behind her. "Ohhh."

Scorpia set the blonde Princess down, and they wandered a little way off to look at the decorations. Mike hurried to catch up with Scorpia.

"Catra?" Agatha said, almost pleadingly. "Won't you at least think about it?"

Catra shook her head, a regretful little smile on her face as she crossed her arms over her chest. "I can't. Not right now. Maybe ask me in a year or two?" She inclined her head at where Scorpia was admiring Perfuma's handiwork. "Anyway, you and Scorpia won't need me."

"We do need you, Catra," Agatha said, lowering her voice and drawing closer to Catra. "I mean, I love my niece, but Scorpia's not really…well…we both know she's not really a leader."

Pain flashed across Catra's face. "Don't… don't say that," she said quietly. "People underestimate her. And they shouldn't." Catra turned her head to look at the big woman and then back at Agatha. "You don't have any idea how much I relied on Scorpia."

Agatha raised a skeptical eyebrow.

“Seriously. A lot of the changes I made were because Scorpia thought they were a good idea. When we took over for Shadow Weaver, we had soldiers refusing to fight because they were out of armor, weapons, and just about everything. Scorpia spent a ton of time tracking down what we needed to do to fix it. And I would have just drowned in the paperwork if it hadn’t been for her.” Catra’s ears drooped a little, and she looked towards Scorpia again. “It was her idea to raise the rations, you know.”

“Really?”

“Well, her and Entrapta.” Catra amended. “See, I told Entrapta to run an analysis to find the fastest ways to make our soldiers more effective in the field. When she got done, Scorpia’s idea was that we should raise the rations for everyone and make sure we were producing enough armor and everything.” A bitter smile lifted the corner of her mouth. “Who knew that feeding and equipping people properly made them more productive?”

“Imagine,” Agatha said dryly.

“Did she ever tell you about when we went to the Northern Reach?” Catra asked.

“No. I mean, she told me you both had been assigned some mission there to seek out some First One’s tech, but she never disclosed the details, obviously.”

Sighing, Catra nodded. “Yeah. Well, you should know, she saved my life up there.”

“Really? Scorpia?” Agatha sounded surprised. “She never said anything.”

“Well, that’s Scorpia, isn’t it? She never takes the credit for things, and she’s way too loyal.” Catra hunched over slightly and looked at her feet. “I’ll tell you the whole story one day when we have time. But the part you should know about it is that the mission went completely sideways. It was supposed to be a search and salvage mission, but the Rebels heard we were up there, and they

sent She-Ra, Glimmer, and some of their special fighters to disrupt it. Which they did. And then, these monsters showed up."

She stopped speaking and closed her eyes as if against bad memories. Melog trilled encouragingly, rubbing their face on her hip.

Finally, Catra looked up at Agatha and went on, her voice low and a little halting. "I… lost sight of mission objectives," she confessed. "I put all of us in serious danger. When it became obvious that I wasn't going to listen to reason, she countermanded orders and just took over. She grabbed Entrapta and me and got us out of there and back to our transport. She saved our lives. And then she saved the mission. Scorpia had already taken the thing we were looking for back to the transport for Entrapta. She was *amazing* ." Catra smiled wistfully. "Anyway, I think this council you've got together is a great idea, but I think we need someone like Scorpia in charge of it. She's the only one I can think of who can do it, honestly."

"Catra…" Scorpia said softly from right next to Felina, making her jump. Perfuma stood there too.

A group of Horde soldiers set up folding chairs that they'd brought in one of the transports for officers and VIPs to sit on. The noise they made was probably why Catra and Felina did not hear the soft footsteps in the grass and so did not realize Perfuma and Scorpia had drifted back over and now stood close enough to hear the conversation. Felina did not even know how long they'd been there.

Catra scowled, her cheeks bright red. "Don't you dare say *anything,"* she growled at the pair. "Or I will take it all back."

Perfuma's smile was understanding. "I won't say a thing," she affirmed, moving forward to hug Catra. "Thank you." Perfuma's whisper was still loud enough for Felina to hear. "Scorpia has always wanted to make her aunt proud."

“Um. Yeah.” Catra muttered. “It’s no big deal.” Her cheeks were still red as the Princess pulled away. Scorpia had tears in her eyes as she swooped both Catra and Perfuma up into a hug.

“What’d we miss?” A man’s voice asked. Felina turned around to see Bow and two men she didn’t recognize walking over.

Scorpia let go of Catra and Perfuma. “Nothing. Nothing at all,” she said, laughing.

Bow grinned at them. “Hey, everyone. These are my dads, George and Lance.” He indicated the men on either side of him. “George, Lance, these are Scorpia, Agatha, and Catra.”

The taller of the two, a dark-skinned man with long braids, stepped forward. “I’m so excited!” he gushed. “To have a front-row seat to such a historic event. It’s just breathtaking.”

The shorter man had the same design on his shirt as Bow did. Felina wondered if it was like a unit insignia or something. “I’m honored to meet you.” He half bowed towards Catra, Agatha, and Scorpia each in turn. “I never thought I’d live to see this.” His smile was a touch sad. “Peace with the Horde. After all this time.” The taller man moved towards him and reached out to take his hand.

“After all this time.” Perfuma echoed. “We’re going to have peace.” For a moment, they stood silent and motionless, wrapped in their own thoughts while the preparations continued to swirl around them.

One of her people came to ask Perfuma where to put more flowers, and the spell was broken.

“See you later!” Perfuma called to them as she, Scorpia, and Agatha strode over to take care of whatever the issue was.

“We just came to help Bow set up the recording equipment.” The tall man grinned at them, still holding the other man’s hand.

“Yeah, we’re still trying to get everything together on our side too. I didn’t think peace was going to be so much work,” Catra lamented, jokingly. Then she shifted her eyes to someone a little bit behind Felina. “Do you need us for something?”

One of the soldiers who had been arranging chairs slowly walked over. “I beg your pardon, Force Captain,” she said as she saluted. She had deeply tanned and weather-worn skin. Her hair was dark brown but just starting to gray around the temples. Felina caught a whiff of anxiety and something else she didn’t recognize in the soldier’s scent signals. The woman’s eyes were wide, and she stared at the man as if he had a second head. “I don’t want to interrupt… I’m not sure…” she trailed off. Her eyes dropped to the insignia on the man’s shirt before going back up to his face. “Permission to speak with the visitors for a moment, Force Captain?”

Catra shrugged. “Go ahead. You’re not interrupting anything.” She started reading the report in her hand, feigning disinterest and boredom. Felina could tell she was faking it because of how her tail twitched at the end. She was listening as intently as Felina was.

“Did…did you just say your name was George?” the woman asked pleadingly, her face pale under her tan.

“Yes,” George replied, looking as baffled as Felina felt.

“Where do you come from?” she demanded, suddenly aggressive.

Lance took a step closer to George and put his arm around the shorter man’s shoulders while Bow moved to stand at the other side, looking wary. “Why do you want to know?” Bow asked.

“It’s okay, Bow,” George said. He patted Lance’s hand before unwrapping himself from the protective embrace and stepping towards the soldier. “I lived in the Arid Planes before…:

“Before Hordak annexed it?” the woman’s shaking voice finished for him. “That..that symbol,” she pointed at it, “it was your family

crest, right?"

"How..?" Lance began, but George held up a hand, and he fell silent.

"Yes. It was." George told her.

She reached a shaking hand into her shirt, pulling out the fine chain of a necklace she had hidden under her uniform. The pendant on end was gold, but it had the same shape as George and Bow's insignia. "George," she croaked. "It's me. It's Jenny."

"Jenny…" He whispered. "But, you're dead."

"So are you."

Neither one of them moved; they just stared at each other.

"What about Mom and the others?" George finally asked in a strangled whisper.

The woman closed her eyes and shook her head. "I thought I was the only one left." She opened her eyes and stepped forward, her hand reaching out to touch his shoulder. It seemed she needed to touch him to make sure he was really there.

"Uh, George?" Bow asked quietly. "Who is this?"

The man started as if he had forgotten everyone was there. "This is…this is your Aunt Jenny."

The woman's eyes moved to Bow's face. "Aunt? I'm an aunt?" Her gaze dropped to his shirt. "You had a son?"

"Oh, we didn't just have *a* son." Lance's eyes were full of tears as he proudly informed Jenny, "Bow is just the youngest of the family! He's got thirteen older brothers."

"Thirteen…" Jenny stared longingly at the three men.

"Um…maybe we should go somewhere a little more private to talk," Lance suggested when neither Jenny nor George seemed able to break out of their shock.

"Oh, no. I can't. Not right now. I have duties." She waved vaguely behind her. "I can't just…"

"Hey, soldier?" Catra called sharply, raising her voice to be heard over the activity around them. "I've got a job for you."

Jenny sighed, "Maybe later?" she begged softly. Then she straightened up to salute Catra again. "Yes, Force Captain?"

"I need someone to herd the historians around." She sounded irritated and put upon and was still shuffling through papers as if she hadn't heard the whole exchange." There's absolutely no way I have time for it. I need someone to keep an eye on them today. Show them where they need to set up and where to eat and find a campsite. In fact, I really need you to be their liaison. I don't need them getting in people's way and causing problems." She handed the papers off to Felina. "Let your CO know you'll be tied up with it all day. Maybe tomorrow too. Tell them to call me if they have a problem with it."

"Yes, Force Captain," Jenny said heavily. "Where do I find them?"

Catra winked at Felina. "We're expecting two of them." She looked at Bow. "What did you say their names were?"

Bow grinned. "Well, one of them is named George."

"Yeah. Them."

"Force Captain?" Jenny asked, apparently not able to believe her ears.

"Are you questioning orders?" Catra asked, almost teasingly. Her tone went back to being businesslike. "Bow's your counterpart from the Alliance. He'll tell you what they need."

“Yes, Force Captain!” Jenny’s salute was sharp, and she turned on her heel to face the men. *“Historian?”* she squawked. “Really?”

“It’s a long story,” George said as she led them away.

Chapter 13

Chapter Summary

Felina and Adora talk

Day 10 after VE day.

Spire Encampment

The Signing of the Spire Accords

"Are you okay?" Felina heard Catra ask Adora softly. The Force Captain's aid sat directly behind Catra on the raised platform built for the treaty signing. Mike and Lee sat beside her, the three of them ready to fetch whatever their officers (or any of the Princesses) might need.

"Headache," Adora muttered. "It's just nerves."

"Nerves? Seriously?" Catra chuckled and shook her head.

"I wish I didn't have to make a speech."

"I've heard you make lots of speeches. You even had time to practice this one. You'll be fine." Catra turned her head a little. "Hey, Felina," she whispered. "Pass Adora some of that water that's back there."

All the eyes were directed at Queen Glimmer as she addressed the gathering. The row of Princesses and Horde representatives sat behind the long table they would use to sign the treaty.

Felina slipped off her chair and poured a glass of water from one of the jugs on the small table at the back put there for that purpose and hurried to take it to her.

“Thanks, Felina,” Adora whispered, taking a few gulping swallows.

Just in time. The Queen said, “I give you She Ra!”

“That’s your cue.” Catra poked Adora in the ribs.

“Yep,” grunted the Princess. She stood up, looked down at Catra, and smiled. A golden glow enveloped Adora, so bright it made Felina turn her head. Some folks in the audience cheered, some gasped, some growled, and some were silent, staring at the giantess with haunted, fearful eyes. As she paced to the front to take her place beside Queen Glimmer, the crowd’s noise died down.

“Three years ago,” She Ra began, speaking into the tense silence. “I found the Sword of Protection.”

Felina promptly tuned her out; the girl wasn’t interested in what She Ra had to say. Adora used to be part of the Horde, but she defected when she found some magic trinket. Well, okay, maybe the sword wasn’t just a trinket, but Felina couldn’t wrap her head around why the woman would betray everyone she'd ever known. Why didn’t she bring it home?

Agatha kept saying how awful Shadow Weaver was. She told people that maybe Adora didn’t run away from the Horde but just ran away from Shadow Weaver. That still didn’t help Felina understand; why didn’t she try to change things as a Force Captain, like Catra did? From what Agatha said, Adora had been raised to inherit the old woman’s position, but Catra got it instead because Adora ran away. The same evil witch raised Catra, but she stayed because Catra actually *cared* about her own people.

“We have all lost family and friends to this war. And…” She Ra paused, taking a deep breath. “I am sorry.” Her voice ended on a high-pitched little squeak, and she couldn’t seem to continue. Her left hand lifted in a “hold on a minute” gesture and covered her eyes with her right, then she took two loud tremulous breaths and raised her head again.

Oh, wow. Dramatic much? The girl sneered to herself. The woman would make a great actor in one of the pantomimes that the older cadets put on in the evenings.

"We have *all* been deceived. There was never any true reason for blood spilling on either side. We were set against each other by forces not in our control."

Felina was not interested in her excuses. The first clear memory in her life was her mother's face when they brought the news that her father had died. And, okay, it didn't seem like anyone here was *personally* responsible for that, but he certainly wouldn't be dead if it wasn't for the Princesses.

Instead of listening to the speeches, she continued to work on the drawing in her lap. As long as Catra or Agatha didn't look behind them, she'd be able to get away with it (and it's not like they'd reprimand her in the middle of the ceremony, anyway). Since Mike was busily scribing the meeting (he had the best handwriting), she'd look like she was doing the same.

Finally, the woman returned to her seat. It was Catra's turn next. Felina didn't listen much to her either, mostly because she'd heard Catra practicing. Lots of stuff about healing and forgiveness and joining with other Etherians.

"With that in mind, I am stepping down from my position as Force Captain and Second," Catra said. That made Felina's ears twitch, and she looked up, suddenly alert. "I have accepted the position of Ambassador to the Princesses. A civilian position. I have been a soldier all my life. Etheria will always need soldiers to defend her, but until that time comes, I would like to learn to be something else as well. I would like *all* of us to learn to be something else as well." The words echoed the speech she made the day of her stupid trial. Felina thought that had been talk, though. Now it sounded like she was *going away.*

"But, I leave you in good pincers. If I was the right person to lead our war, Scorpia is the best person to lead us into peace." She

paused a beat; then, she saluted the crowd. As one, every Horde soldier in the crowd and quite a few from the Alliance stood to return the salute.

They all held it until Catra lowered her arm and Scorpia stepped up to the podium, saying, "Oh, wow. At ease, everyone."

Felina hastily looked down as Catra came back to her seat. It was fine though, Catra didn't spare her a glance, having eyes only for Adora.

Two drops of water fell onto Felina's paper. She purposely dropped her pencil so she could bend over to pick it up and wipe the inexplicable moisture from her face.

At last, the ceremony finished. The treaty was signed, and people shook hands and hugged each other, laughing and crying.

Catra stood up, stretched, and grinned at them. "Dismissed," she told Felina, Mike, and Lee. "Go find something to eat, and I bet Frosta will be looking for someone to play iceball with."

"You coming?" Lee asked. Frosta (okay, she was a Princess, but she was nice and a lot of fun to hang out with) was already craning her head, looking for them.

"You go on. I'll catch up," Felina muttered. She looked down at the sketchpad in her hand and headed out in the other direction. Her drawing was almost finished, and she wanted to get it up on The Wall before she did anything else.

She found a quiet little nook right next to The Wall and spent the next hour putting the last touches on it, wishing she had a picture, so she didn't need to go off of memory. Of course, if she *had* a picture, she wouldn't have to draw it. The one picture she used to have was lost during Prime's invasion.

A shadow blocked her light. She looked up to see if she could get away with telling whoever it was to move.

“Hey, Felina.” Adora chirped, her cheerful voice grating on Felina’s nerves. She smiled at the girl as she had all week. As if she wanted to make friends. As if she expected Felina to fawn over her the way everyone else did.

Grudgingly, Felina got to her feet and saluted. It wasn’t any of her business, and she would never criticize Catra for bunking with Adora out loud, but she certainly thought it was a bad idea. Adora was obviously a terrible influence.

The woman’s cheeks turned a little red as she returned the salute. “You don’t need to do that.” She sounded embarrassed.

Good, thought Felina, *she should be embarrassed.* All she said out loud was, “Yes, ma’am.”

For once, the woman was alone without her little entourage of followers. Catra was nowhere in sight either. “Did you need me for something, ma’am?” Felina asked, proud that her voice came out perfectly civil and respectful. She always got high marks from her instructors for her good attitude.

Clearly, Adora bought it because she smiled broadly. “No, I was just taking a break from all the excitement. It’s exhausting.”

“Yes, ma’am.”

Adora looked down at Felina’s sketchpad that lay in the grass. “Oh, wow!” she said, bending to pick it up. “This is really good!”

Nobody asked you. Felina thought, stepping on the urge to snatch it out of the woman’s hands. She plastered on the best fake smile she could and consciously kept her ears from pinning back. “Thank you, ma’am.” She couldn’t stop her tail from lashing, but the woman didn’t notice.

“Who is it?” Adora asked cluelessly, giving it back.

“No one special,” Felina shrugged. Adora was the last person Felina wanted to talk about this with. It wasn’t like she was lying

either. The great She Ra wouldn't give a shit about a common Horde soldier. "If you don't need me, ma'am, can I go?"

"Of course." Felina's tone might have been a little terse because a small frown appeared between Adora's eyebrows as she said it. "Where are you going? Can I walk with you?" The woman asked cheerily.

Felina knew if she opened her mouth, the only thing that would come out was a hiss. Reluctantly she nodded, trying to keep her ears up. She didn't say anything as she walked, and fortunately, neither did Adora.

The Wall seemed to collect more pictures, drawings, and notes every time Felina looked at it. Between early this morning and this afternoon, someone had added several new panels of bulletin boards. Even so, there was very little blank space again.

"I really hope Entrapta can get the comms working again soon," Adora said quietly. "It will be good when we can find out people's status."

"Mmm," Felina grunted. Before she did anything, she took a quick look at the new messages on the board, as she'd been doing three times a day for the last five days. Not seeing what she was looking for, she fished around in her pocket for the tack she'd found in one of their transport's lockers. She ripped the page out of the sketchpad with slightly shaking hands and tacked it to the board. She put her mom's name and unit number on the bottom, along with, "MIA: anyone with info, please check in with Agatha." That done, the girl put her hand on the paper, wishing Adora would go away so she wouldn't see Felina act like an absolute infant.

"Felina," Adora said slowly, watching her. "Who is that?"

Hand still on the paper, Felina hung her head, trying to get a grip on herself. Tears dripped from her eyes onto the ground. The girl's breath hitched, and a little sob emerged.

So many people had been streaming in for days that Felina had been convinced her mom would have at least checked in by now. She had waited until today to put up the drawing, hoping her mom would roll up in a transport.

Agatha had given special instructions to notify her when any of her cadet's families checked in. Mike's dad showed up yesterday, and both Lee's mom and older sister had checked in to say they were on their way home. Fuck, even that historian person's long-lost sister had appeared out of nowhere.

"Felina?" A hand rested on Felina's shoulder, and the girl looked up to see Adora frowning down at her. "Are you okay?"

It was too much.

"STOP IT!" Felina shrieked, knocking Adora's hand away. "No, I'm not okay! Stop pretending you care!" She turned to face the woman. "You don't get to talk to me about this! You think that you can make everything right with pretty speeches and act like you are so much better than us! When are they going to put you on trial for war crimes? You're worse than a deserter! You are a *traitor* . I've seen what you do to people. I saw the transports bringing people back after Bright Moon. If it weren't for you and that stupid sword, Prime would never have found Etheria. But nobody's going to say anything about that. Oh no, anything the great She Ra does is perfectly fine."

The woman's shimmering eyes were huge as she pulled back. "Felina, I'm…."

"Shut up!" Felina bellowed. "Fuck you!" Felina had never sworn out loud like that before, and she had certainly never yelled at an adult. It felt good, so she kept going. "My mom was in one of those tanks you trashed. She was in the infirmary for *months*. She's lucky she could walk again. She…she…I haven't heard from her since before Prime came! She's *gone,* and you think you can talk to me about her?" You stay the *fuck* away from me!" Her claws were out again; she couldn't have sheathed them if she

wanted to. Her ears were pinned back, and her fluffed-up tail stuck rigidly out behind her as she stood panting.

“Cadet!” Catra's voice cut in sharply before Felina could catch her breath enough to yell again. "That's enough."

To Felina's utter mortification, a small crowd gathered to watch her meltdown at Adora, including Queen Glimmer, Scorpia, Agatha, and Catra.

“Felina?” Agatha asked in her quiet, stern voice. "What on Etheria is going on?"

Horrified, the girl put both hands over her mouth. The women were staring at her. Felina took three stumbling steps backward, and then she did the only thing she could think of.

She turned and ran.

Chapter 14

Chapter Summary

Adora makes a realization.

Felina misses her mom.

Day 10 AHP (After Horde Prime).

Spire Encampment

Shortly After The Signing of the Spire Accords

Before Adora could even take a step to chase after the girl, a hand fell on her shoulder.

“Don’t,” Catra said, quietly. “She’s not going to listen. Melog will keep an eye on her.” The great cat disappeared, probably to avoid spooking Felina even more.

Biting her lip, Adora nodded. Catra was right. The magical cat could easily catch up to the fleeing girl and keep her safe until she calmed down.

Agatha sighed heavily. “I’m sorry, Adora. Please, don’t think too badly of Felina. She’s usually so dependable."

“It’s not her fault,” Adora said softly. “I’ve been trying to make friends with her all week. I felt bad for scaring her.”

“Well, she’s not scared of you now,” Catra remarked with a dry little chuckle.

“What battle was her mother injured in?” Adora asked as she looked towards where Felina had disappeared into the crowd, dodging people and obstacles.

“Dryll Pass,” Agatha replied.

It took Adora a minute to remember when she'd ever fought at Dryll pass. Finally, it came to her, Just before they lost Salineas. A stupid little skirmish with one of Catra's skeleton crews. Glimmer said it was recon, but She Ra ran into a group of Horde soldiers who were ready for her. When Adora realized that Glimmer had used her as bait again, she was so angry. Trashing a few tanks (they *were* using energy weapons against her) felt good at the time.

Whenever they experienced casualties and losses on the Alliance side, Adora always comforted herself that all Rebel fighters were volunteers who had some idea what they were getting into. The Horde soldiers had no choice. The inescapable fact was that soldiers had been injured or killed in those battles.

She winced and chided herself for her cowardice; "had been killed" sounded like a force of nature did it. *She Ra* killed and injured soldiers. Moreover, She Ra injured or killed *people* --not just anonymous soldiers. People with husbands, wives, mothers, fathers, and children of their own.

Catra's warm hand crept into her cold one. "You couldn't have done anything differently," she asserted, quietly. "It's not like they would have stopped shooting at you if you'd asked."

Glimmer came to take her hand on the other side. "Adora, I'm the one who ordered you there. And I'm the one who sent you alone so that you had no choice but to… " The Queen's breath caught in a little sob and she wiped her face with the heel of her free hand.

"I should have realized I was pushing too hard." Adora nodded towards Felina's drawing. "It didn't occur to me that she was putting up an MIA notice." To be fair, the drawing of the woman looked nothing like Felina. She had short straight hair and dark eyes that reminded Adora of Castaspella. Felina definitely hadn't inherited either her ears or tail from her. The name given on the drawing was Sara.

Agatha nodded. “Yes, she has her father’s looks.” Contemplatively, Agatha moved her gaze to Catra and continued, “I’m fairly certain that you were the reason they had their reproductive application approved.”

“Seriously?” Catra asked.

“Oh, yes. They’d put it in several times over the years, but each time Shadow Weaver rejected it on the basis of inferior genetics. It was only after Shadow Weaver adopted you as her ward that feline types were given permission to reproduce.” Agatha said.

“Huh. That explains why there’s so few of us.” Catra grunted.

“So few who are *your* age,” Agatha clarified. “After Shadow Weaver took you in, she started approving magicat applications. Even if the other applicant was a different type. There are quite a few children of magicat descent among the younger cadets, although you can't always tell at first glance.”

“Wait. Are you kidding?” Taken by surprise, Catra and Adora exchanged startled looks; the more they learned about Shadow Weaver, the more complicated she seemed.

"Hey, Specialist? How’s that transmitter coming?”

“It’s not.” Sara wished Trevor would just fucking stop asking. “I can’t pull spare parts out of my ass, you know.” She’d been having to cannibalize parts from any equipment they found abandoned.

“But the receivers are still working, right?”

Sara rolled her eyes and tried to keep her response civil. The kid really didn't deserve her ire. “Yes, Trevor, just like they've been working all week.” Because their receiver worked, they’d been getting the daily updates, so they knew that the war was over. They just had no way of checking in.

Sara couldn’t fault Trevor for being anxious, but Sara was way more anxious than Trevor could even understand. She had no idea if her daughter was alive or dead. She wanted to be home so bad she could taste it. Unfortunately, until they found a working (or at least a fixable) vehicle, they had a long hard walk ahead of them back to the Fright Zone. Even if they did get the transmitter working, it wasn't like anyone would make a special trip out to retrieve a comms specialist and two low level infantry.

Taking the device out of her backpack as she bent to sit on the warm sand under the scant shadow of an anemic-looking, thorny tree, to check the reception. “We need three bars of signal to get the feed.”

Derrick tossed his jacket down to sit on and settled down next to her. Trevor threw his backpack down to use as a backrest on the other side.

“I still can’t believe we’re making peace with the Princesses,” Trevor said. He pulled off his sweaty shirt and wiped his brow with it. Derrick dug through the big backpack he carried and tossed out the afternoon’s food and water ration. The young man grabbed up his food, cracking the seal, and swallowing it in about three eager bites before he went on. "I mean, I figured they'd never want to sit down and behave like civilized people."

Derrick tossed hers over as Sara searched for the signal, worrying that they didn’t have enough. Four bars popped up; maybe they boosted the transmitter. Entrapta was back, so it was likely.

“So do you think the Princesses…?” Trevor began.

“Quiet, it’s starting,” Derrick growled.

The first part of the ceremony was the swearing-in of the new government. Scorpia came forward and raised her claw, repeating her oath of office after Queen Glimmer.

“Hey, wait a minute. Is that *Agatha?”* Trevor pointed to the little screen as the next person came to the Queen to raise her claw.

The youngster had lost his parents as a baby and he grew up in Agatha's cadre.

"Yes. Yes, it is." Sara said. "That…that's crazy." She couldn't deny that Agatha would make a great leader (she always wondered why Agatha wasn't a Force Captain), but to go from cadet commander to something they were calling First Counselor was hard to take in. Seven other counselors were sworn-in too. All of them were people who had reputations for being good, solid officers. Two of them were officers that Shadow Weaver had put away because according to the rumor mill, she thought they were a little *too* good.

"Hey!" Darryl said suddenly. "Look!" He pointed his claw at the tiny screen.

"What?" Sara asked.

"Look. Those three back there? The officer's aids?"

Sara nodded.

"See the one sitting behind Catra? That one." Derrick tapped the screen with his claw. "Doesn't that look like..?"

"No." Sara tried to squelch the useless hope rising in her heart. "No, it can't be." It would hurt far too much if she were wrong.

Trevor leaned forward. "Seriously. I think he's right. That's her hair."

Sara hit the record button, hoping the record function still worked. For the next five minutes, she squinted at the screen, looking not at whoever was speaking at the front, but at the girl sitting behind Catra.

The girl stood up and walked to a back table to pour a glass of water. When she returned, she leaned over to carefully hand it to the woman sitting in the front row next to the Force Captain.

Apparently by chance, as she straightened up she looked directly at the camera.

“It is her! It is!” Sara shrieked, jumping up. “She’s alive!” The girl looked thinner than she should and her clothes were ragged (but it seemed like everyone there was equally scruffy), but Sara could see her deep green eyes, wavy black hair, and silver furred ears. The silver furred hand holding the glass was striped on the back with the sweet black swirls that Felina inherited from her father. Her silver and black tail swayed behind her in concentration.

Trevor and Darryl both threw their arms around Sara, as she jumped and shrieked and laughed. If she shed a few tears, both of them were good enough to pretend they didn’t see.

It took some time to calm down after that. Sara was glad she pressed the record button, otherwise, they would have missed half of it as they celebrated that Felina lived. It was during their second watch that they saw the blonde woman transform into She Ra right in the middle of the ceremony.

The flash of light, even on the tiny screen, made Sara's heart skip. The magical monstrosity stood *so close* to Sara’s precious kitten.

Sara’s breath came too fast. The memory of the last time she saw those lights unspooled in Sara’s mind. For a moment, all the soldier knew was the tearing of metal and that horrible sense of flight. The pain in her head. Her mangled leg was still pinned under the instrument panel. The smoke choked her as she panicked, wondering if the whole tank was going to burst into flame or if She Ra was going to come back to finish her off.

“Whoa! Sara! Hey, it’s okay!” Two hands on her shoulders and a booming voice called her out of the smoky darkness. “C’mon, Sara. Breathe with me.” Derrick was there that day; he pulled her out of the smoldering wreck. Now he pulled her out of those terrible memories. “In. One, two, three, four.” Grey eyes met hers. He had saved her life before. “Hold it One, two, three, four." Now

he taught her to breathe again. "Blow it out, one, two, three, four. Hold. One, two, three, four.”

After two cycles of this, Sara felt calmer. Gratefully, she leaned against Derrick's solid shoulder for a moment before wiping her face with her hand.

Trevor picked the trackerpad up and eyed it closely. “It’s okay. Felina looks fine. And look, Agatha and Catra sitting right there. I don’t think even She Ra could get past the two of them.”

Easy for the kid to say, he’d never fought a princess.

“You all right?”

“Yeah. Yeah.” Sara patted Derrick’s hand. “I’m okay. It was just a shock.”

The big man nodded soberly.

Trevor hit play. Sara was completely unable to watch while She Ra was on the screen. She paced behind her squadmates until Derrick said, "Okay, she's gone. Looks like Catra's up next." With Catra at the podium, Sara was able to get a good long look at her daughter who was studiously writing. Sara’s chest filled with pride. She captured a screenshot where Felina had again looked randomly at the camera, her face very grave as she took notes for her officer.

It was a long time until Felina’s heart stopped pounding. She’d run clear across the camp and the only thing that checked her flight was the open field of grass that separated the Spire encampment from the Whispering Wood. The flat turf yawned in front of her, making her dizzy. She felt like if she wasn’t careful, she’d fall up into the sky. She couldn’t imagine venturing into all of that open space alone, so now she crouched behind some randomly parked transport.

Felina wanted to die.

She was in so much trouble. Forget punishment duty, she was going to be demoted and then sent back to school with the youngest cadets until she could learn to behave like a normal person. And then she'd probably be cleaning latrines for the rest of her natural life. She couldn't believe she yelled at Catra's girlfriend like that. She couldn't believe she swore at *anyone* like that. In front of Catra and Agatha.

She was in so much trouble. And what would her mom say if she came back?

No, not "if". Never say "if."

When her mom came back, she was going to be so disappointed.

Felina wanted to *die.*

A trill with a falling purr at the end interrupted her thoughts. That was Melog's afternoon greeting. Just like the day she'd hidden in the hollow under the beams, Melog appeared out of nowhere in the space next to Felina.

The magical creature regarded her calmly, and then gently bumped their head into hers. They rubbed their jaw along her shoulder, leaving a line of their own scent. A tickly, effervescent smell that made her feel like she'd sneeze if she got too much of it up her nose.

"Are they really mad?" she asked.

The creature shook their head, laying down in the cool shadow with Felina.

"I miss her so much," the girl murmured. She didn't know why she said that. The heat of the day and her runaway emotions were taking their toll. All she wanted to do was close her eyes for just a few minutes. She flopped onto her back next to Melog.

The slow rumble of the great cat's purr had her asleep in seconds, dreaming of her mother. The picture was so clear, so sharp, and

real. Felina remembered things she hadn’t thought of since she was a tiny kitten. She remembered every sensation related to Sara; what she looked like, what she sounded and smelled like. The feel of her arms when they hugged.

In the dream, a glowing multi-hued cord stretched from Felina's chest into some misty distance. The threads of the cord were made of love, longing and memories. It stretched from her heart, binding daughter to mother. Distance had no power over love. If someone followed that long luminous rope they could find her mother and lead her home.

Chapter 15

10 Days after Victory on Etheria

Shortly after the signing of the Spire Accords.

Somewhere on Etheria

Felina was alive. The thought sang through every step Sara took. Nothing else mattered. Not the pain in her shitty knee, not Trevor's complaints about dwindling rations, not the heat of the day or the length of their walk.

"How far is it to the next town?" Trevor asked. "Do we have anything left for food?"

Derrick shook his head. "We're pretty much out of cash, but I bet we can get some work for a couple of days."

Sara limped along behind the other two, only half listening and glad to be ignored for the moment. All her attention turned inward as thoughts of her daughter flowed through her mind. Felina was alive and well. And promoted to officer's aid. Promoted to *Force Captain Catra's* aid. Sara's heart wanted to burst with pride and love. Never mind rations, at the next town, she was going to find the wires to get her transmitter working if she had to sleep with the town's metalsmith to do it.

That was why when Derrick stopped suddenly, she nearly walked right into him.

"Shh," he hissed, pointing at his ear.

Sara and Trevor froze in their tracks, holding their breath. Derrick sniffed the air with his bull's nostrils and turned his ears this way and that. After a second, he blew his breath out through his nose as though to clear it. "Sorry, I guess I'm getting jumpy." He

pointed at his ear and then his mouth with one hand. He made a little cutting gesture towards his throat with his other hand when he pointed at his mouth. Sara got it. He *did* hear something, but he didn't want to say it out loud in case the something was intelligent enough to understand.

"Yeah, well, all this green stuff is weird," Trevor grunted. "It's already got me jumpy enough." In the last hour, the trees had become more frequent, and undergrowth grew thick along the side of the road.

"Uh-huh," Derrick answered absently, still turning his ears, trying to catch the slightest sounds.

When the kid opened his mouth to talk again, Sara grabbed his shoulder. When he looked at her, she pressed her finger over her lips.

They started walking again in silence; Sara reeled her thoughts in, bringing herself back to the here and now. She would not be any good to her daughter if she got herself killed by not paying attention.

After about a little while, she saw movement in the short prickly bushes that crowded close to the road. She gave a low whistle, a signal for the other two to stop. When they looked at her, she caught Derrick's eye and indicated the undergrowth with her chin. He nodded his understanding. The bushes moved ever so slightly again, and even Trevor saw this time. Something *big* in all that vegetation stalked them.

Melog had been gone a couple of hours, but Catra didn't feel like anything was wrong, just that they were busy. Probably talking Felina out of whatever metaphorical tree she'd trapped herself in.

Adora had disappeared, too, telling Catra she needed a break from all the people. Catra understood; Adora had always needed approval. So many people here looked at her with anger and

distrust that it wore on her. The blow-up with Felina had just brought the bad feelings into sharper focus.

The camp celebrations became louder and more boisterous as the day went on. The past ten days had been similar--taking care of business in the morning and early afternoon and spending the evening in celebration. Today was the last day of this. Catra, Melog, and Adora planned to head off to Bright Moon with Sparkles tomorrow.

"Hey, Catra?" Bow slid in beside her on the bench where she sat, watching something she *thought* was a sword fighting demonstration. There was a lot of synchronized movement, maybe it was some kind of local dance that included swords? It was hard to say.

"Hey, Bow." She winced as one of the blades whizzed by the head of one of the participants, who deftly moved to avoid it rather than blocking. The opponent did not go on the offensive. Instead, they spun their sword in a series of intricate hand-over-hand maneuvers that the others in the circle mimicked. Okay, so it was a dance.

That settled, Catra turned more of her attention to Bow. "How's it going?"

Beaming, he grabbed her hand and squeezed it. "Thank you so much for what you did this morning."

Feeling her cheeks heat, Catra deflected. "It's no big deal," she muttered.

"Jenny saw me a few days ago," Bow went on. "I guess She was sort of stalking me. She was afraid to talk to me because she thought there was no way this could be what she thought it was." He indicated the heart on his shirt. "But when she saw George and heard his name, she felt confident enough to take a chance." His face became sad. "I guess one of the reasons George never wanted me to be a soldier was that his village had been

destroyed, but it was in the area annexed by Hordak. He suspected the Horde had captured them since he never found any bodies. He never wanted to be in the position of having to fight what could have been his friends and family."

"I can understand that." Catra squeezed Bow's hand back and then withdrew it. "Hey. Don't mention that part to Adora right now, okay? She's having a hard time today."

"What do you mean?" Bow asked, suddenly concerned.

Not wanting to get into the whole thing with Felina, Catra sighed and scratched at the back of her neck. "She's just… I guess a lot of things are starting to hit her hard. I don't know."

The archer nodded thoughtfully. "Adora needs time to process, now that it's safe. We all do." He paused as if thinking his words over. "George told me that if any of us want to talk to someone who gets it, he's always available."

"That's nice. I think Adora could use that," Catra told Bow, telling herself the little spike of pain in her heart was not envy.

"He meant you too."

"Me?" Catra scoffed, surprised. "Don't be an idiot. I'm fine."

"I know. But it's okay if you're not."

Before Catra could make an answer to that, she felt a nudge at her elbow. "I have found her," Melog announced, fading into visibility at Catra's side. "You will come with me and also the Queen. They will not understand otherwise, and they are too many for my magic to bring them so far."

"Wait. What?" Catra was glad to have a reason to divert from this conversation, but she had no idea what Melog was talking about.

"I have found the Kitten's mother," Melog told her more quietly.

"You mean Felina's mom?" Catra asked, "Is that where you've been all afternoon?"

"We will bring them home." Not for the first time, Catra wondered what Melog had been before Prime destroyed their kind. They seemed very comfortable ordering people around. "She has two companions she will not willingly leave, so we must bring them as well. For that, we need the Queen. My magic will not yet bring so many so far."

"Well, let's go find Sparkles before she gets too drunk."

The trio of soldiers hurried along as fast as their weary limbs would allow. The road offered minimal cover or protection from either four-footed or two-footed predators. In a very short time, it would be dark. Their best bet was to continue until they could find either a defensible campsite or a town.

"What do you think it is?" Trevor whispered to Sara. "Do you think it's still out there?"

"I don't know, Trevor," Sara hissed back. The pace they set was killing her knee, but there wasn't any help for it. Derrick kept glancing back at her worriedly, and she wished he'd just quit.

The afternoon had already been a long one. They were on their own out here. Not another soul had passed them either way on the road for two days. They didn't see anything shake the bushes again, but if something was stalking them, they wouldn't, assuming the thing was at all proficient at hunting.

Derrick held up a hand for them to stop, looking off to the right side of the road. He made a sign for them to wait and disappeared while Sara held her breath. He reappeared and beckoned for them to follow.

"We'll stop here," Derrick grunted when they got close enough. "I don't know about you two, but I'm wrecked. This is as good a place as we're going to find."

A little path led through the thorns that grew closely on either side. It looked like a frequently used campsite, a fire ring against the rock wall that protected one side. A little spring emerged from the rock, chuckling down into a shallow pool and then running away into the shrubs. The thick thorny vegetation surrounded them on two sides, leaving only one side to be watched. It would be tough for anything two-footed to approach without being noticed, and a fire would keep away anything four-footed.

Sara sat on a rock with a groan, grateful for the rest.

The respite was short-lived.

"So where are they?" someone asked, their voice carrying down the slope from the road.

"Melog says they're around here somewhere," replied a different voice. "They said they can only approximate their location. They're definitely around here somewhere."

Fuck, fuck, *fuck*. Whoever was following them had lost them when they'd left the road. Trevor looked to Sara, his eyes full of fear. Once more, she pressed her finger to her lips, then pointed at the brush. Quickly and quietly, the three flopped down onto their bellies and crawled into the brush, ignoring the inch-long spikes that caught at their skin and clothes.

Now that she was underneath them, Sara saw that the bushes going up the slope had a thorn-free tunnel of about eight inches of clearance from the ground. If someone elbow-crawled, they could get up there to see without impaling themselves or, worse, shaking the bushes. It looked deliberate; someone had taken a machete and hacked it out so that they could keep an eye on the road without being seen.

Since Sara was the smallest, she usually did anything that needed crawling or stealth. She looked toward Derrick and made a sign that she would have a look. He gave her a thumbs up. Slowly and

silently, she wormed her way upslope until her face was even with the feet of whoever-it-was standing on the road.

One of the intruders had the open-toed, open-heeled boots that many feline and canine types wore to protect the delicate arch of their feet while leaving their claws free to use for running and fighting. They looked like they *could* be Horde-made. The other wore close-toed white boots that were definitely not.

The owner of the clawed feet sniffed the air. Shit, Sara had no idea if she was upwind. She should have checked. The specialist, of all people, should have thought about how acute the noses of felines or canines were.

The feet turned towards her. Sara held her breath and gripped her staff, trying to plan her next move. She couldn't think of a single reason for them to be anything but highway robbers. They had nothing to steal, but brigands wouldn't know that.

"Looks like there's a campsite." The other feet walked a little way up the road to the spot where the gap in the bushes led to the site.

The clawed feet stopped right in front of Sara. Their owner crouched on all fours, putting their cheek against the ground, still sniffing. Gold and blue eyes locked with Sara's as she cowered on the ground.

"Oh, hey," the woman said. Her voice was amiable for a brigand. "There you are. You're Sara, right?"

Shocked to her core, the best Sara could manage was a squeak. "Uh-huh."

Unfortunately, she was experiencing some sort of breakdown. The person crouched in front of her looked exactly like the former Force Captain, now Ambassador Catra.

"Great!" When Sara didn't move, the hallucination spoke with more concern. "Are you okay?" It held out a hand, claws

sheathed. "There's two more of you, right? We came to get you."

Hesitantly, Sara reached forward to grab the hand. It was warm, callused, and *definitely* not a hallucination.

Adora had been crying for long enough. Long enough for her eyes to swell and her nose to run. Long enough for the shaft of light coming in through the tent flap to move across the floor, marking early afternoon turning to late afternoon. Long enough that if she didn't pull it together, Catra was going to come looking for her and find Adora a ridiculous mess.

"Stop," she muttered to herself. "Just stop." She couldn't face anyone like this, couldn't let them know that she was falling to pieces.

A burst of adrenaline had her jumping up to pace, then frustration and impotent anger rose in a great red tide that obscured her vision and drove her out of the tent. She needed to get somewhere she could punch this out.

Felina woke to someone flicking her feet. "Mmph. Mike. Quit," she muttered. That was his signature way of waking her up.

"Come on, Felina." Lee rumbled. "Wake up."

The events of the past few hours came back to her in a flood. "Oh, no," she groaned sitting up. "How much trouble am I in?"

The two looked at each other, seemingly mystified. "In trouble for what?" Lee asked, tilting his head.

"I kind of lost my shit," Felina whimpered, grabbing her knees while she wrapped her tail tightly around herself. "I-I-I yelled at Catra's girlfriend. Right in front of Agatha and Catra."

Lee and Mike's jaws dropped in horror. "Oh. Shit," Lee swore. He dropped down to sit on the ground. “What the fuck, Felina? Are

you out of your mind?”

“I just…I was putting up an MIA notice for my mom.” Felina hunched her shoulders. “And Adora…she wanted to know who it was. And I kind of lost it.” Both Lee and Mike knew about what happened to her mom. “Did Catra seem really mad?”

“I couldn’t tell,” admitted Lee. He thought for a second. “She didn’t seem pissed off, but she said she needed you as soon as possible. Maybe that’s okay? Maybe Catra will just assign you to some chores. She really likes you.”

“That was before I yelled at her girlfriend.”

“Did you get food yet?” Lee asked after a second.

“Not hungry,” Felina mumbled.

Mike produced a ration bar out of his pocket and threw it at her. “Eat that,” he growled. “It’s stupid to skip meals when you don’t have to.”

Usually, Mike didn’t speak unless he felt strongly about something. Chastened, Felina unwrapped the bar and took a bite. "Thanks,” she mumbled, her mouth full. She passed the bar to Lee, as was their habit. Lee took a bite and passed it to Mike who took a bite and passed it back. The three of them had been eating like this for weeks and the ritual had become weirdly comforting. They always fed the younger cadets first and then, when the kids had enough, they’d share out the remainder for themselves. Today the boys only took tiny bites, leaving most of the bar for her.

“Come on.” Lee stood up and held out his hand. “Catra wants you to meet her at her tent.”

The girl grabbed it and hauled herself to her feet, feeling like she was going to her execution. One of the things Agatha said the day that Felina went after She Ra was that Felina’s lack of impulse control was going to get her killed one day. Well, it looked like the new First Counselor wasn't wrong.

The boys walked her about halfway there, diverting when they came to the iceball game Frosta and the older cadets were playing. “We promised we’d go back after we found you,” Lee said apologetically.

Mike gave her a one-armed hug and Lee squeezed her shoulder. “It’ll be fine,” Lee said. “Catra didn’t seem mad when she asked us to find you. Actually, she seemed more worried than mad.”

In some ways, that might be worse. If Catra started to think Felina was *fragile* the girl would never get over the embarrassment.

“I’ll let you know what happens,” Felina told them. “Assuming I see you again and she doesn’t just roast me on a spit like a tunnel rat.” She waved at the kids playing iceball.

Frosta caught the ball and held it, signaling a time out so she could walk over. “I’ll see you in the morning before we leave?” she asked.

“If I can.” Felina wrapped her arm and tail around herself, looking down at her toes. “I have to figure out how much trouble I’m in first.”

“Trouble?” Frosta narrowed her eyes. “Catra just said she wanted to talk to you. And that you’d probably be busy the rest of the night.”

Pushing her hair back with her hand, Felina mumbled, “I kind of yelled at Adora earlier. I bet they’re both really pissed. If Agatha was still my CO, she would have already had me cleaning the latrines with a toothbrush.”

“I think it'll be okay. Look at it this way: if they banish you, you can come home with me tomorrow.” They had already been making plans for Frosta to request permission for Felina, Mike, and Lee to come to visit the Kingdom of Snows. That thought made Felina smile a little even as she waved and headed up the little hill towards the main camp.

It was starting to get dark, and people were lighting fires against the night chill. Queen Glimmer and Catra sat beside a burning campfire and the girl wanted to kick herself for sleeping so long. She should have been over to do that. Technically, Catra had given them all the night off, but after Felina's freak-out, it would have been a good idea.

The Queen stood when she spotted Felina's approach. "I'll go let them know," she told Catra and disappeared.

At least the Queen wouldn't be around to witness Felina's reprimand. Her stomach knotted with stress, the girl walked around the campfire to salute Catra.

"Ambassador Catra!" She hoped her crisp salute hid her shaking hands. "You sent for me?"

"At ease, Felina," Catra told her, gently.

"Yes, ma'am." The girl couldn't take the tension for another second. She took a deep breath. "Catra, I'm so sorry. I…"

"It's okay. We're all keyed up. And this whole peace thing?" Her CO waved her hand dismissively. "It is not going to be easy. Just don't…well, at least *try* not to do it again."

"No ma'am," Felina agreed, breathing a little sigh of relief. It would be great if the whole incident got passed off as a result of being too keyed up. "Should…should I apologize to her? For yelling at her?"

"For yelling at her?" Catra's eyes narrowed and the end of her tail twitched. "But not what you said?"

Caught, Felina felt her cheeks heat up and her eyes dropped to the ground. "I…don't like to lie."

"Okay. I guess that's fair." Although Felina didn't dare look at her face, Catra's tone was thoughtful. "You probably should do that

when she gets back." An edge of humor came into her voice. "Apologize for yelling at her, I mean."

Was Catra joking? If Felina hadn't been so wound up with nerves, she might have laughed. As it was, she replied to her CO with a soft little squeak. "Yes, ma'am."

"You didn't mention to me that your mom was MIA," Catra continued after a long silence, her voice soft.

Felina shrugged. "A lot of people are MIA." She was well aware that her circumstances were not special. "I just… I guess I was hoping that she'd check in by today."

The girl raised her eyes and chanced a look at Catra's face. The woman didn't look angry; just tired and maybe a little sad. She didn't speak, instead of staring broodingly at Felina who didn't dare move under the intensity of Catra's attention.

Finally, Catra said, "Look, you're not in any trouble. I've said lots worse to Adora, she can cope. And, it's really okay if you don't like her. Nobody's expecting everyone to be instant friends." she hesitated. "But remember, they've lost a lot of people too. To the Princesses, *we're* the bad guys."

Felina couldn't keep in a little snort of disbelief, and then she cringed because *of course* Catra heard it.

Instead of calling her on it, Catra shifted her eyes to look over Felina's shoulder.

With so much extraneous noise around, Felina couldn't tell if it were Adora or not, so she braced herself, readying an apology for the Princess, rehearsing it in her head so it wouldn't sound fake. She resisted the urge to turn and look since she hadn't yet been dismissed.

While they were talking, a soft breeze had sprung up, blowing from behind her and it suddenly carried a scent that made Felina's fur fluff up.

It isn't. It can't be. The mature and rational part of her mind frantically tried to stuff down the wild hope that felt like it was going to burst out her chest. *I'm imagining it. There's no way. There are a lot of people here. It's just someone with a similar scent.* Even though scents were more identifiable than faces, she knew it just couldn't be

The rest of her mind seized hope with hands that itched with the urge to knead against something soft. A purr rose involuntarily from her chest, but she stifled it into a questioning *Mrrph?*

The scent seemed to hit Catra's nose at the same time because she smiled gently. "Look." She indicated something behind Felina with a tilt of her chin. "Turn around," she urged when Felina couldn't make herself move.

Felina turned.

"Felina!" Her mom came up the little rise, limping slightly, leaning on a staff. There were others with her, but Felina didn't register any of them. Sara's white and gray shirt clung to her and her straight black hair was dusty. The woman smelled like sweat, grease, tears, love, and hope.

It was the best scent in the world.

"Mom?" Felina whispered, immobilized between her discipline as a soldier and her urge to run to her mother as the child she was.

"Well, go give her a hug or whatever," Catra said, gently giving her a shove on the shoulder.

The girl closed the distance between herself and her mother, racing on all fours. She threw herself at Sara who caught her easily, rolled to the ground to kill the momentum of the affection missile (as Sara used to call it). Felina was heavier than the last time she did this-they tumbled downslope causing several startled passersby to jump aside before they stopped. For a moment, Felina's mother lay on her back, laughing as her daughter, her cheeks blazing, bounced back to her feet.

“Mom? I didn’t hurt you, did I?”

Sara laughed harder, shaking her head. “I’m fine!’ She held out her hand. Felina caught it and hauled her to her feet.

Mother and daughter stared at each other, drinking in the sight. Felina saw more creases in Sara’s face and the woman was thinner than she’d ever been, but everybody was like that. At last, it seemed Sara couldn’t stand the distance and wrapped her arms around Felina, pulling her child to her.

“How long have you been here?” Felina whispered.

“I just arrived.” Sara’s laughter had died down, but she seemed teetering on a knife-edge of hysterics. She took a few breaths. “Catra came and found us. Brought us home.”

Chapter 16

Chapter Summary

Adora makes some new friends

CW: mentioned past child abuse

Spire Encampment

Day 10 post VE day

Spire Accords Celebration

The Spire Encampment grew larger and more like a permanent town every day and Horde citizens now far outnumbered the people from the Whispering Wood and beyond. Spire was becoming a major nexus for the (former?) soldiers journeying home.

Perfuma had asked Adora this morning if she was happy to be able to be with her own people.

"I… don't feel like I know them anymore." Adora had replied truthfully. What she *didn't* say was that she didn't think she'd ever known them. All week, Adora had been discovering how isolated she had been as a child, even from the rest of the Horde. From the time she was a tiny baby, everything in Adora's life revolved around her guardian's ambitions for her. The truth was that day in Thaymore was the first time she could remember meeting anyone outside of Shadow Weaver's sphere of influence. Before she met Bow and Glimmer, she had never eaten anything but ration bars, never played with any children that Shadow Weaver didn't introduce her to, and never spoke to an adult who was not on Shadow Weaver's approved list.

Tonight, Adora listened carefully to the conversations she passed as she made her way back to find Catra. And everywhere Adora went, Catra's name was on people's lips.

At the base of the Spire, a crowd gathered around a big central bonfire, talking in groups or just relaxing. One grizzled veteran told his war stories to a rapt audience of youngsters. "We had no armor, no reinforcements. So, we straight up refused to fight--it would have been suicide. We were trying to figure out what to do, you know? We were thinking we'd have to desert. I mean, you remember what the creepy old bitch was like. And then these transports roll up with brand new equipment, some relief troops, and new orders. That was when Catra started using the bots to fight princesses instead of just throwing us at them, you know?”

A woman in the shadows spoke in a low voice to someone Adora couldn't see. "I wanted to give up. Just let myself be eaten by the Light. But every time he thought of her, it made me remember things.”

The person she faced replied in the same way. Adora had to strain to hear them. "Yes. Me too. He wanted to stop thinking about her, so he stopped thinking about *me.* About a lot of us I guess. Do you remember Scorpia? She was right in front of him and she disobeyed. He couldn’t figure it out because he wouldn’t let himself think of Little Sister."

Adora wondered if Spinnerella would talk to her about that.

"Oh, yeah. Catra was always a scrapper." That voice made Adora pause and do a double-take; Octavia sat with Mermista and Sea Hawk on some logs, passing a bottle around. "But, she was just a little fuzzball at the time. So, I decided it would be fun to yank on her tail. That was a mistake. She came up right into my face, all claws and teeth. I was lucky it was *only* one eye." Octavia laughed. "If I had caught her that day, I probably would have killed her."

“You should let Geek Princess have a look at it.” Mermista slurred, “I bet she could make you a new one. She loves problems like that.”

Adora moved on before either Mermista or Sea Hawk could spot her.

Another group basked in the warmth of the fire. Lounging on the ground, propped up by a backpack was a short haired woman. Adora wouldn't have paid any attention, except she spotted Felina's distinctive form lying with her head in the woman's lap, snoring softly while the woman absently petted her ears.

"So, I'm under these bushes," the woman was telling her companions, "trying to get a look at what I figure are highway robbers, and I can see someone's feet. I can tell it's probably a feline and I'm scared out of my mind because I know that whoever it is is going to be able to scent us. I can't even let Derrick," she waved her hand to indicate a burly man who sat on the low rock next to her, "and Trevor know because they'll hear me the minute I move. I'm hoping Derrick can at least hear them talking, so maybe they can get the hell out. And then, she walks over and just casually bends down and asks if I'm Sara."

"No. Way." One of the other soldiers said.

The woman nodded her head vigorously, "I know, right? I thought I was having some sort of breakdown." She took a sip from her cup. "And then, this is the craziest part. She hauls me out of the thorns and tells me she's there to give us a ride, but there isn't any vehicle that I can see. And the woman she's with comes wandering back and introduces herself as Queen fucking Glimmer of Bright Moon!"

A mutter of astonishment went around the circle. Adora drifted even closer and sat down on a convenient log, just close enough to hear the story without impinging on the group. It sounded like Glimmer and Catra had a busy afternoon and Adora wanted to hear more.

"Were you scared?" someone asked.

Sara laughed. "I was ready to piss myself. Especially after that big cat friend of hers reappeared. Apparently, that creature of hers is intelligent and a freaking sorcerer. It found us because Felina *asked* it to. So, once we convinced Trevor and Derrick to come out of hiding, the Queen, no-kidding, *teleports* us here."

"What was that like?"

"Really weird. Catra says she always worries she left some vital organ behind, but at least I didn't have to walk back on my shitty knee." She indicated the leg she had stretched out in front of her. Her pant leg was rolled up and even in the dim light of the fire, Adora could see deep, wide scars and hollow spots where muscle was gone. A metal knee brace and a compressed fighting staff sat beside Sara.

"Oh wow, that's just crazy," chortled one of the women.

"Hey, you over there. You want to join us?" The ox-like man next to Sara had spotted Adora sitting off to the side, listening to the story.

"Um, if I'm not intruding."

"Naw, it's fine," Sara said, her voice cheerful.

The others in the group murmured their assent; they were so friendly and casual, Adora knew she hadn't been recognized. That made sense. These were all low-level infantry or infantry specialists by their uniforms and insignia. None of them except Felina had ever met Adora in person. When she'd gone out this afternoon, she purposely left her signature jacket in the tent. She only wore one of her compression tops over her pants, so she looked pretty much like every other Horde citizen here. Of the people who were gathered around the fire, only Felina would be likely to have good enough night vision to see her clearly.

She moved to perch on one of the rocks facing the fire, on the other side of the big man.

“You want a drink?” One of the young men asked. They picked up an empty cup and waved it at her, indicating the little cask they had set up on a rock.

“Yes, that would be great, if you don’t mind.” She had no idea what they were drinking, and she usually didn’t drink alcohol, but right now, it seemed like an excellent idea. It seemed to work for Seahawk and Mermista, at least. The only thing that had helped Adora feel better after her extended crying jag was punching trees until her knuckles and fingers were bloody, misshapen, and swollen. A quick transformation healed the damage, but her hands still had the deep boneache she always got from speed-healing fractures. It didn’t matter, they’d be fine by tomorrow.

The thought made Adora’s heart turn over in her chest. Her hands would be fine by tomorrow, but what about Sara’s knee? What about all these other people that she’d maimed or killed?

Carefully, she accepted the cup, cradling it between the palms of both hands because her fingers wouldn’t work right yet. A sip of the drink burned her mouth and throat as she swallowed, making her sputter. “What is this?” she gasped.

Everyone around the circle laughed, but not unkindly. “Some local rotgut,” Sara said. “It’s better on the second swallow.”

The second sip did go down easier than the first. “You’re right.” A warm glow kindled from the burn spread over her. It made her stomach tingle pleasantly, and her shoulders relaxed. Timidly, Adora smiled at the soldiers. She couldn’t remember ever having to introduce herself to a group of strangers. Bow always did the introductions, and before Bow, Shadow Weaver had always picked who she could meet.

The big man grinned at her. “Atta girl,” he said approvingly. “You just get in?”

“No, I’ve been here all week.” Adora wasn’t trying to lie to them or anything, she just wanted to avoid the inevitable reactions She Ra

had been getting. “I was at the battle here,” she finished softly.

“Yeah?” A murmur went around the circle. “I heard that was some serious shit. Tell us about it?”

“Uh. I-uh…I was….” Adora didn’t know how to answer that without outing herself. While her brain scrambled, she finished her drink to buy time. “Can I have another one of these?” she asked Derrick.

A grim look of understanding crossed Derrick’s face. “Yeah, sure, no problem.” He handed her the refilled cup, then he leaned forward and spoke firmly. “Listen, you don’t have to talk about it if you don’t want to.”

Adora gave him a grateful smile and shook her head. “It’s just… too soon.”

Sara and Derrick nodded.

“Hey, Trevor,” Sara said, a little frown on her face. “Give her a break. She just sat down.”

Derrick cleared his throat. “So anyway, how did you guys get here?” he asked the three other people sitting with them.

They launched into the story of how they’d survived Prime’s invasion and been able to return. Adora didn’t pay attention, instead she watched Sara pet the sleeping child on her lap. After a while, she went to take another sip of her drink and was surprised to see it empty.

“You want another?” Derrick asked jovially, apparently seeing Adora’s puzzled reaction to her empty cup.

“Hm? Yes, please.” She extended the cup back to him, still cradling it in her palms.

He frowned at something but took the cup back to refill it. When she reached for it with both her hands again, his eyes narrowed.

“What happened to your hands?” His voice was quiet, as if he didn’t want the others to hear. “Have you seen the medics for those yet?”

Adora looked down at them; they weren’t swollen or anything. They just wouldn’t bend very far, nor would they straighten completely. Not without hurting a lot. “They’ll be okay.” She shrugged. “It’s nothing permanent. They just hurt. Anyway, this stuff is helping.” Warmth flowed through her body, soothing her heart as well as the aches she still felt from the events of the last month.

He smiled sadly and patted her shoulder. “Atta girl.”

“How did that happen?” Adora indicated Sara’s leg. In the Horde, asking about battle scars was just small talk.

“I got that from She Ra,” Sara said matter-of-factly. “She flipped my tank. My leg got caught under the console. They had to rebuild the knee.” She seemed to consider it, “They did a pretty good job, but it doesn’t work at all without the brace, and it still hurts like a bitch at the end of the day.” She grinned a little and held up her glass as if to give a toast. “And this is why we drink.”

“Oh. I’m so sorry,” was all Adora could think to say. She wanted to apologize properly to Sara, but she couldn’t make herself say the words. Instead, she took a big swig of the sharp-smelling alcohol in her hand.

The woman shrugged, “Yeah, it’s okay. Not your fault.”

At that, Adora gasped and sucked her mouthful of liquor down the wrong way, setting off an epic coughing fit as she tried to clear the burning liquid from her airway, gagging and choking. Derrik helpfully pounded her back until she was able to croak, “I’m okay!” as tears ran down her face.

Unfortunately, all her noise woke Felina. The girl sleepily opened one eye to look at her. After a second, it registered. She squeaked with alarm and then jumped to her feet to salute. “Adora! Ma’am!”

Fuck. And things had been going so well.

Wearily, the tired ex-war leader stood to return the salute only because she knew if she didn't, Felina would just stand there at attention. "As you were, Felina," she told the girl softly. Standing up gave her strange vertigo, so she sat back down quickly.

The adults froze. "Did-did you say you were *Adora* ?" Half the group scrambled to their feet while the other half looked baffled.

"No, please, As you were," Adora waved them off, feeling her cheeks get hot. "Really." She took another drink. This mouthful didn't burn as much, and she swallowed it quickly.

"I don't understand," Sara said, confused at the sudden change in mood. "Who's Adora?"

It was Felina who answered in a small voice. "She's…well, you know how they said She Ra was a normal person most of the time? Well, that's Adora; she *turns* into She Ra. That light show she does? That's how she transforms."

"What?!" Moving faster than Adora would have believed, Sara bent her left leg until her heel was almost under her butt, leaned forward, grabbed her staff, popped it open, and in one well-practiced move, used it to haul herself to a stand without putting any weight on her bad leg.

Silhouetted against the bonfire behind her, Sara seemed to have flaming wings as she angled herself defensively between Adora and her child. Weakened by her half-ruined leg, she nonetheless gave every sign that she was ready for a fight. No one looked at Adora with so much hate and fear since the early days after her defection when she still sported the Horde's colors around Bright Moon. That hadn't been directed at Adora herself, but what she represented; but Sara's fury was personal, and her fear warranted. Adora wasn't sure what to do to defuse her, and the others in the circle looked at each other nervously.

“I”m sorry,” was all Adora could think to say, her voice cracking. She held her cup close to her face to keep her hands in sight. Tears poured down her cheeks, and her nose ran. “I am so, so sorry,” she sobbed, not even caring that she was ugly-crying in front of strangers. “I don’t know how to fix it.”

The woman’s breath came in short gasps, and her stance was rigid. Derrick (he really was built like an ox: he had an ox-like head with large curving horns and a broad nose to go with his huge muscles) walked up beside Sara and put his hand on her shoulder. “Sara, it’s okay,” he rumbled. “Relax. Peace treaty? Remember?”

“Oh,” she said. “Right.” It didn’t seem like she’d taken the words in; her stance didn’t relax at all.

Unmoving on her rock, letting tears run freely down her face, Adora thought that maybe she’d let Sara get a couple of good hits in with her staff before she disarmed her. It might make her feel better.

“Ma’am?” Felina interrupted their staring contest, timidly coming up on the other side with one arm wrapped around herself as her tail lashed slowly behind her.

Sara and Adora broke off staring at each other to look at the girl, who straightened up, clasped her hands behind her, and cleared her throat. “Permission to speak, ma’am?” This was directed at Adora.

“Yes, of course.”

“I, um, guess I owe you an apology,” Felina told Adora. “I am very sorry for yelling at you. And swearing at you. It was inappropriate.” The girl’s eyes flicked worriedly towards her mother.

Sara shook her head as if to clear it. “Wait. What do you mean you *yelled* at her this morning? Why were you even talking to her? She’s a *princess.* ”

"I was appointed Catra's aid," Felina told her mother, "but I've been looking after both of them all week. When she assigned me, Catra said I should look after Adora as well. As-as a courtesy, since she was Catra's counterpart with the Alliance."

That didn't seem to calm Sara down at all. "And you *swore* at a VIP?" she demanded, grabbing Felina's arm. "Are you out of your mind?"

"S'okay, really." Adora hastened to say, her stomach tied up in a cold knot even around the warmth of the liquor. "It's not that big of a deal. Don't…" The way Sara grabbed Felina's arm made Adora think of things she always tried to bury: the sound of yowling, the smell of burning hair. *Don't hurt her anymore. Please, Shadow Weaver. Please don't hurt her.*

Trying to dismiss the intrusive imagery, reaching for some calm, Adora took a big breath. "And…and anyway, I'm pretty sure Catra already took care of it. Assigning you punishment duty, I mean." The words came out of her mouth slurred and slow.

Felina nodded, looking relieved as Sara relaxed her hold, and some of the fear left the woman's eyes. "Yes, ma'am," the girl said, "and I was supposed to apologize to you as soon as I saw you."

"Well, good job," Adora said, trying to sound chipper. "I'll let you get on with your night, then." Adora threw the rest of the drink down her throat in one big gulp. Not finishing it would be a waste, but she didn't want to hang around and disturb them any more than she already had.

As she stood up to leave, the ground seemed uncooperatively unsteady. "Ooh," she said, trying to regain her balance as she staggered sideways.

"Uhh…Adora?" Felina asked, "are you all right?"

She put one hand on the rock. "I'm fine. I'm always fine!" For some reason, that struck Adora as funny, and she giggled. "I have

to be fine! I'm She Ra!"

Sara asked Derrick. "How much has she had?"

"Uh. Two cups? Maybe she had some before she came?"

"I've never seen her drink before," Felina said quietly. "So I doubt it."

"I saw you pour her three," Trevor said helpfully.

"I don't drink," asserted Adora. "I can't. I'm s'posed to save the universe. Y'know?" She pantomimed using her sword and made swishing sword noises.

"Oh, good," Sara said, sounding like she meant the opposite. "So, she never drank alcohol before, and she gets started with this stuff? Then you just kept pouring as she kept drinking? Now she's completely hammered. I'm surrounded by idiots!"

"You've been talking to Catra," Adora accused, pointing her finger at her. "You should sit down. You keep swaying."

"Oo-okay," Derrick said, gently taking her arm, and the little cup out of her hands."Why don't you come back and have a seat with us."

"But…but…" Adora really hadn't meant to upset everyone. She wished she could stay, these guys were really nice. But it wasn't fair to them. She fucked up so bad, she didn't need to keep bothering them. "I should go. You guys were having fun until I got here." But the man wouldn't let go of her arm and guided her to sit down on the rock he'd abandoned. "I ruined everything," she finished mournfully, wiping her eyes with her sleeve."

"No, that's okay." His deep voice was very soothing. "It's all good." He turned to the others. "Do we have anything left to eat?"

"I'll go see what they have in the cook tent," Felina said. "I'll tell them it's for Adora, they'll know what she likes." The girl ran off

like a shot.

"Fuck this," groused Trevor.

Adora laughed at him and said conversationally, "Shadow Weaver never let us swear. She said it was unbecoming to a Horde officer. But you're not an officer, so I guess it's all right." She looked down at her hands. "Shadow Weaver would never have let me drink. She didn't even like me to hang out with people unless I was training, either. She said I would lose my edge. I was special. I couldn't waste my time socializing."

Something about that thought made Adora tear up. "She drank a lot. She was sooo scarey when she drank. She…" Inexplicably, tears started to run down Adora's face again. "She said I was special." A hiccuping sob emerged from her throat. "I hate being special." She clenched her fist and pounded it on the rock she sat on. The pain was barely noticeable through the alcohol haze.

Being special meant she was not allowed to fail. Being special meant she can't choose her own fate. Being special meant spending time with Shadow Weaver and her insistent hands that slid over Adora's body, touching her in places she'd rather not think about.

"Okay, Adora. Shhh. You're fine now. You're with us." Sara gently took her bloody fist in her hand and patted her shoulder. "We'll take care of you." Derrick handed her a canteen. Sara had a cloth in her hand, and she poured out a little water onto it before putting the canteen in Adora's good hand. "Here. Drink this," she told Adora gruffly. "It's just water."

With the wet cloth, Sara gently wiped the fresh blood from Adora's fist. "Thank you." Adora drained the whole canteen. She peered up at Sara. "I'm so sorry," she told the woman again. A thought occurred to her, "She Ra's got healing magic! I could fix it!"

The woman patted her arm. “Uh-huh. Sure thing, sweetie. We’ll talk about it in the morning.” She lowered herself carefully to the ground with the help of her staff.

“All right. If you’re sure.” Adora decided where Sara was sitting looked more comfortable than her rock, and she slid down to join her. “Can I sit with you?”

The woman smiled a little and said, “It’s fine.”

“Why is this our problem?” a young man’s voice asked irritably. “Can’t we just dump her with some rebels and let them deal with her?”

“Because, Trevor,” Sara snapped, “I’d really like to avoid jeopardizing the whole peace treaty because we accidentally poisoned She Ra with dubiously sourced moonshine. I really don’t want her to go wandering around alone in this state.”

“You guys are the best!.” Adora sniffed and wiped her nose with her sleeve. “I don’t even understand why we were fighting.” The war made less sense now than it ever had.

“Don’t ask us,” Trevor grunted. “We were just infantry.”

Sara peered at her in the darkness and asked, “How old are you, Adora?”

“About twenty, I think. I don’t know. I never knew my parents. Light Hope stole me from my home when I was a baby, and Shadow Weaver stole me from Light Hope.”

“That’s too bad,” Sara replied, subdued. “I’m sorry.”

“I think I need to nap,” Adora said, “I’m tired.” She closed her eyes and sagged sideways until gentle arms guided her to lay her head on something soft.

Sara brushed the blonde girl's hair out of her eyes. "It was a lot easier to hate her when I didn't know she was just a kid." Her legs were starting to go to sleep under the weight of Adora's head in her lap. "Poor thing's a wreck."

"Why was she going on about Shadow Weaver?" Trevor asked. The other group that had joined them had cleared off when Sara confronted Adora.

"Didn't you listen to the speech she gave?" Derrick folded his arms and looked down at the girl thoughtfully. "She Ra was Shadow Weaver's missing ward. The one who defected."

"Hey, Trevor?" Sara fixed him with her best glare. "Don't go repeating that drunken rambling about Shadow Weaver. I do not want to hear that nonsense in tomorrow's scuttlebutt, got it?" The last thing the poor kid needed was rumors about being molested by Shadow fucking Weaver. Sara was pretty sure that last bit wasn't something Adora actually meant to say out loud.

Sara stroked Adora's hair, enjoying the peace for another couple of minutes. "We better find one of her friends. I guess Felina can tell us where she's bunking when she gets back." Moving slowly, Sara picked up the sleeping girl's head and slid her legs out from underneath, and slid her backpack into place as a pillow. She grabbed her knee brace and pulled it on, Able to use both legs now, she stood.

"Oh, wow, thanks for babysitting." A voice called out. Sara looked up to see Felina's green and Catra's gold and blue eyes shining out of the darkness. "I've been looking all over for her. I was just about to get Melog to go find her."

"Catra?" mumbled Adora. She lifted her head and squinted. "Hey!"

"Hey, Adora."

Epiphanies

Chapter Summary

Sara and Derrick make a decision.

Adora is hungover

Referenced child-abuse/non-con

Chapter Notes

Day 11 after Victory on Etheria

Day 1 ASA (After Spire Accords)

Spire Encampment

"That's my girlfriend," Adora informed Sara, Derrick, and Trevor. Her smile grew wider and more wicked than Catra had ever seen it. "Isn't she *cute*?" She giggled, then snorted on the inhale.

Beside Catra, Felina stiffened, her scent thick with fresh anger. A sideways glance showed the teenager was a fantastic actress. Right now her face was neutrally respectful, her tail wrapped around her leg to keep it from lashing, and her ears were upright. No one could tell by looking that she was seething.

The girl had been doing that all week, but Catra had not bothered to consider where it came from or where it was directed, figuring the poor kid probably had all kinds of things to be angry about. She didn't realize Felina had a particular grudge against Adora. The cadet going after She Ra single-handed made a lot more sense now.

The three adult soldiers peered nervously at Hordak's former Second in the dim light of the fire, trying to decipher how she felt about Adora's apparent disrespect. Their eyes were wide and Sara bit her lip.

Derrick had no better night vision than Sara or Trevor, but he could pick up on Felina's angry scent. Catra heard him sniff. She and Felina stood close together, a little upwind of him. The way their scents mingled in the night breeze, Catra knew he was concerned that all that anger was coming from her.

She stepped forward, away from the girl, to help him better interpret the signals and it put her closer to the firelight so all three adults could see by her expression that she wasn't the one ready to tear someone a new asshole.

The big man's shoulders relaxed. He reached down to offer the blonde woman a hand. "Yep. She sure is," he said amiably. "That's part of what makes her so dangerous."

"I know, right?" Adora's scent was sharp with alcohol. She beamed as she unsteadily pulled herself up. Letting go of him, she chortled as she tottered sideways. Sara caught her by the elbow.

"How much have you had?" It wasn't that Catra disapproved; she had thought for…well, pretty much forever that Adora should let her hair down once in a while(literally and figuratively) but this was… sudden.

"Just three," Adora slurred, holding up two fingers. "And they were tiny." She held her forefinger and thumb up to illustrate. "Like Entrapta-sized tiny."

"You know there's a reason they put that stuff in tiny cups," Catra said dryly.

"Oh wait! I should do introductions!" Adora exclaimed as if she'd just remembered something. "Catra! This is Sara." She patted the shorter woman's shoulder. "And Derrick, and…" She stared at Trevor, apparently working to remember his name and coming up empty. "Kyle," she asserted, then grinned."I never get to introduce people. Bow usually does it. "

She turned to Sara who was still half holding her up. "The eddy.. eta.. etti… The manners books at Brightmoon said I should introduce people to Glimmer, not the other way around because she's the Queen," she rambled. "And Catra," Adora waved in her girlfriend's direction. "She's like the queen of the Fright Zone so I guess it works the same." Then the blonde woman's smile turned soft and sweet. "I love her so much," she gushed. With that she lurched into Catra's arms, clinging as if for dear life.

"Whoa." Catra staggered under the taller woman's weight. She shoved herself back a little to keep from being strangled "Adora. Quit. Get off."

"Oh. Okay." The words sounded disappointed. Adora pulled away and stood on her own feet, visibly swaying. "Sorry." Her eyes filled with tears and she twisted her fingers together, looking anxious.

Catra huffed, feeling her cheeks heat up. It would get difficult to keep up her badass image if people saw her being soft with her girlfriend. "No. I just meant…" She glanced at the others, then at Adora's crestfallen face, and made a decision.

 "You're heavy." She offered her hand to Adora, gratified when the blonde woman's sadness evaporated and she lit up with joy and took it. "Come here." She pulled Adora to her and wrapped one arm around her waist so they stood side by side. Adora made a little noise of delight and buried her face in Catra's hair.

"I better get this idiot to bed," Catra grunted. Adora chose that moment to go from snuggling to asleep on Catra's shoulder and slowly sagged groundward. "Oh, for… " The taller woman really was heavy.

"Got her." Sara smoothly moved to grab Adora's other arm, stopping her slide. "Where is she bunking?"

Catra's hesitated. She thought Felina would have told her mom at least. Catra and Adora weren't exactly keeping the change in their

relationship a secret, but it still felt somehow momentous to talk about it out loud. “My tent.”

"Oh, okay. Huh.” Sara muttered, before saying more loudly, “All right, ma’am. I'll help you get her there." She looked at her squadmates, then back at Catra. "Will you need anything else from us tonight, Ambassador?"

"No. Just help me with her and you can get back to your night. " Another time Catra might have refused the help, but right now she was ready to pass out from sheer weariness.

"Hey, Trevor? You and Felina pitch the tents."

Both youngsters saluted. "Yes, ma'am."

"Do you need any help?" rumbled Derrick at Sara.

“No, I think we’re fine. I'll only be a few minutes."

After about five minutes of dragging Adora along, Sara hesitantly asked, "Ambassador, permission to speak?"

Catra sighed internally, wondering how she could get people to stop doing that. "Go ahead," she said out loud.

"You should have a look at her hands. They're injured. "

Catra glanced down at Adora’s left hand which rested limply on her chest. It had fresh cuts and bruises over the knuckles.

"Oh, hey. How'd that happen?" Catra asked Sara.

The unconscious woman between them stirred and interrupted. "I fell," she muttered, sounding a little soberer. She put her feet under her, digging in her heels so they had to stop. She pulled her arms from around the two other women. "No big deal. I kind of fell a couple of times. I… " She mumbled. “I’m just not used to that stuff.”

There was more to it than that. “You fell? Seriously? If you fell, it would be the palms of your hands all scraped up.”

“It doesn’t matter. I’ll transform and they’ll be fine,” Adora assured them as she looked at Sara, her eyes were wide and worried.

“That’s not really an answer.” Catra wondered what the two could have been up to that Adora was trying to cover it. "So, spill."

Now Adora looked...guilty? "I... um...ah..."

Sara cleared her throat, putting an end to Adora's attempt at coherent speech. “I beg your pardon, Ambassador. She, uh, got into an altercation with a rock.”

“You were hitting rocks?" Catra asked. "With your bare hands? Why would you do that?”

“It seemed like a good idea at the time?” Adora admitted sheepishly. Definitely less drunk now, she still swayed a little as she sent another beseeching look in Sara’s direction, her tone was almost pleading. "You really don't need to tell her about that whole thing. It’s not… not a big deal.”

“Oh, come on,” Catra scoffed, intrigued and disturbed in equal measure. “Now you have to tell me. I promise I won’t give you a hard time about it.”

“I… I… uh… see… I, ” Adora stammered out.

“Sara, you tell me what happened.”

The specialist frowned, biting her lip, seeming to need a second to organize her thoughts. Probably she was worried about what would happen if Catra didn’t like the answer. “It was just one of those ‘hold my beer and watch this,’ moments,” she finally supplied. “She wondered if she could crack the boulder if she didn’t transform. She couldn’t. I cleaned her up, but I think she maybe broke a few little bones in her hand.”

Catra cackled. “You idiot,” she said fondly.

“You said you weren’t going to give me a hard time,” Adora whined.

“Okay. Sorry. Come here.” Catra reached out for Adora’s hand. “Think you can walk on your own or should we just keep dragging you?”

“I can walk.” Adora being so petulant shouldn’t be so cute. She seemed to be sobering up fast; that was probably due to She Ra. In fact, Catra was surprised that she could get drunk at all. After a minute, the blonde uncrossed her arms and took Catra’s proffered hand with her uninjured one.

“I got her from here, Sara,” Catra told the woman. “We’re not far, you head on back to your squad.”

“Yes, ma’am.” Sara saluted. She wore that worried frown even as she walked away.

“You should have seen her,” Sara told Derrick. “She looked at me with those big blue eyes and I couldn’t tell what part she wanted me to keep quiet about. It was a complete minefield. So, I just went with it being drunken hijinks.

The kids had gone to bed and the two senior squad members lay on the ground next to the fire, staring up at all the crazy points of light that now adorned the night sky. The first time the two of them saw them, they’d thought the end of the world had come. It had, but that wasn’t the stars’ fault. And maybe this new world would be a better one.

“I feel like I should have said something, but she woke up at the wrong moment.”

“I wouldn’t worry about it too much,” Derrick said, soothingly, intertwining his hand with hers. “I think we’re all entitled to our own drunk meltdowns right now. Anyway, it’s not our business.”

“You heard what she said about Shadow Weaver.” Sara turned over to her side and propped her head on her hand. “And weren’t you the one who told me when she got there her hands were so bad she couldn’t close her fingers? I feel like someone close to her should know.”

“She said she’d be fine, Sara.” The big gunner turned over to face her. “You don’t need to go into mom-mode with every orphan you meet. She’s a grown woman and a Princess to boot. Plus, it looks like Catra's looking out for her. Definitely not our problem.” He smiled to take the sting out of his words. “If you want kids to take care of, I hear there’s a refugee camp about twenty-five klicks from here that has a lot of kids whose folks are missing.

“What? You want me to request a transfer? Tired of me already?” She returned the teasing smile.

“Well, maybe we could both ask to get assigned there, y’know,” he hesitated, “together? As… I mean, well... we could get Officially Sanctioned?” He moved closer, so he could rest his hand on her hip. “Maybe we could even put in an application to make a new soldier. I mean, if you wanted.”

“I… “ The worrying behavior of the Princess suddenly forgotten, Sara took a minute to process what Derrick was trying to say. “You want us to be Official?”

“Yes.”

“When would you want to do it?” Sara asked, softly.

“Maybe Trevor or Felina could ask someone tomorrow?”

Sara coughed to clear the lump from her throat. “That would… That would be great.”

The sky was beginning to brighten when small distressed sounds woke Adora up; Catra was having another nightmare. The lines of

her face contorted in fear. Her hands twitched so that her claws slid in and out of their sheathes. Tiny mews escaped from her mouth.

On the floor, Melog appeared to be sharing her dream. The translucent creature's paws seemed to run in unison with Catra's hands and feet.

Every night this week Catra had at least one nightmare. Not that Adora was any better. All around camp sleeping people muttered, sleep fought or woke themselves up with their own cries. It was to be expected, Perfuma said, everyone was trying to deal with some level of trauma and grief.

Not wanting to disturb Catra's sleep, if she could help it, Adora ran her hand through Catra's hair. "It's okay," she whispered, "We're home. We're safe." That seemed to be enough: Catra ceased her restless movement, turning onto her side and finally lying slack.

At least one of them should get some sleep. Adora felt like shit. The way her mouth tasted, something had crawled in and died and her head hurt. Why was that? She tried to remember last night, but it was a blur.

Oh. Right.

Lying back against her bedding, Adora cringed as she realized she had very little memory of last night beyond when Felina had told everyone who she was.

Thinking hard, she lay still, wincing as the memories came back in a mixed-up jumble of seemingly unrelated vignettes. Derrick pouring her drinks. Sara jumping up to stand on one leg, getting between her and Felina. What she said about Shadow Weaver.

The words came back in an ugly rush. "Shadow Weaver always called me special. I hated it so much. She'd tell me we were going to run the Horde together. It was my destiny. It was what I

wanted. And then she'd kiss me and slide her hand under my clothes. I asked her to stop. She never did."

Oh. Fuck.

Did she really say that? Did she really tell them that? Why would she tell them that? That wasn't real. That was just something she dreamed up; just a picture in her mind. She didn't really remember anything like that. She'd just had some bad wine and it put ideas in her head. It made her talk too much. She'd always been paranoid and she always talked too much. She needed to keep her mouth shut about those ridiculous ideas.

Her headache became more acute; an inescapable pounding that beat in time with her pulse and made the nausea worse.

She closed her eyes tight and snuggled around her girlfriend, spooning up behind her. If she lay here with her eyes shut, maybe she could just sleep until she felt better.

She drifted into an uneasy doze. She wasn't really dreaming, just thinking. PIctures appeared and faded behind her eyelids as she floated on the edge of sleep.

So many memories.

Yeah. All of them bad.

Images of times spent with Shadow Weaver flitted through her mind. Sometimes Adora disobeyed and her guardian became harsh with her. The phantom pain of remembered red lightning burned through her. The Black Garnet devoured her memories and then turned the fire on itself until it too disappeared into a void of icy darkness. A golden stranger came out of the dark. It held a box. The lid opened.

Adora's stomach turned over. Her dry mouth filled with thin saliva. She bolted out of bed in her nightclothes to puke on the ground outside, her fingers digging into the dirt as she clung to the ground.

Snot and tears dripped from the end of her nose and she was grateful her hair was still tied back with a hair tie; that way she didn't have to worry about gross hair when she got back to her bunk after a night like this.

Nights like this?

What? No. Where did that come from?

Another spasm of vomiting hit her, distracting her from the thought. What was it again? By the time her guts finished emptying themselves, what she was trying to remember was forgotten again.

A hand rested lightly on her back. "Are you okay?"

"I'm okay," Adora whispered. "I just drank too much." She rested on her hands and knees with her head hanging down for a few seconds until she was pretty sure she wouldn't throw up again.

"Sorry, if I'm late." Felina was here at her usual time, but she always seemed to think she should have breakfast started before either of them even stirred.

"You're not late." Adora turned to look at the girl. Now she saw how stiffly Felina held her tail, how her ears twitched back the tiniest bit when Adora spoke to her.

Felina nodded briskly. "I'll get you some tea when the water boils, ma'am."

If yesterday hadn't happened, Adora would have taken the teenager's tone for "cautiously friendly" but now it sounded borderline condescending. As if she was a dangerous animal that one needed to speak to soothingly or risk getting a hand bitten off.

The ground was damp and cold under her bare knees; Adora moved to sit on the log near the fire holding her head in her hands. The girl bustled around, handing Adora tea after a few

minutes. She pulled cooking equipment and ingredients out of her bag.

“Where’d you learn to cook?” Adora had been wondering about it all week. The girl seemed to cook as least as well as Glimmer.

“Agatha and my mom taught me,” the girl replied, her voice stiff, but civil. “You can get all kinds of stuff from the black market and rats are easy to forage. They have to be cooked right or they'll make you sick. "

“Rats?” Adora sputtered. “You can’t be serious.”

The girl shrugged, a disdainful curl of her lip dismissing the suggestion that she was joking. “Before Catra took over, the standard ration for low-level infantry wasn’t enough for a lot of people. We had to make it up somehow. As long as an officer didn’t catch us, it was fine. And even some of the officers would let it slide.”

Thinking that over, Adora stared into her teacup. She and her squad never went hungry. Not unless Shadow Weaver wanted them to. Moreover, her squad always enjoyed advantages others didn’t. They had the best instructors, the best tutors, and the best equipment.

And it was always for Adora’s benefit.

Even in the confines of their squad, Adora was accorded special privileges. She was always the team captain. Always the one who made the plans. Always the one who got the credit. But it was Lonnie who always helped her with hand-to-hand moves. Catra tutored her in math and tactics classes when she needed it. Rogelio and Catra competed with her in weapons combat. Even poor fucking Kyle, so frequently the butt of their pranks, would help Adora out with her reading and writing assignments.

At no point could she remember trying to help the others to pass their classes. Shadow Weaver told her the others needed to see to

their own work without her help. The woman had made it seem like it would be cheating. It seemed natural, Adora never questioned it.

Adora fooled herself for years. She had always told herself that her high marks in every class were because of her own hard work, but that was a lie, wasn't it? No wonder Catra acted the way she did that day in Thaymore.

Only now, when Adora met ordinary members of the Horde, did she realize that people like Sara or Derrick would never have a chance to move up beyond a certain rank. For all her talk of merit and hard work, Shadow Weaver would never allow it.

In Shadow Weaver and Hordak's minds, soldiers were not really people. It didn't matter the casualty rate, how many were crippled, or how many were killed. They were merely cogs in a machine; replaceable, expendable.

A New Dawn

Chapter Summary

First hangovers are difficult. Hangover anxiety is definitely a Thing.

Chapter Notes

Day 11 after VE day
The day after the signing of the Spire accords
The town of Spire
Dawn

"Hey, Lance? We really have to nail down how we're going to date these chronicles. You've done it several different ways.

"Sorry, George. I'm trying to decide what looks best. I'll fix it when I have the time."

The sound of someone throwing up just outside the tent made Catra try to struggle out of deep sleep. It was hard this morning, like clawing her way through mud. She heard the sounds and thought someone should do something, but she couldn't make her sleep-drunk mind function enough to figure out what. She turned over and found the bed much less crowded than usual.

Shit. Where was Adora?

Registering the fact that her girlfriend was no longer beside her gave the former soldier the adrenalin she needed to come all the way awake.

"Are you okay?" Felina asked from outside.

"I'm okay. I just drank too much." Adora sounded terrible, but Catra relaxed a little. With Felina out there checking up on Adora, it meant Catra could take a minute to get dressed.

She listened to them talk as she found her clothes. No one would ever know that Felina disliked Adora. The girl was as pleasant and helpful as a certain blonde Catra could name at the same age. The only time any of her true feelings came through was when Adora reacted with shocked disgust about people eating rats.

Catra scoffed. She could not believe Adora didn't know that.

Melog still lounged on their bed, licking their paw and wiping their face with it. "Why *would* she know that?"

"Are you eavesdropping in my head?" Catra asked the alien cat. "Is that what you're doing for entertainment?" It wasn't that she was offended, exactly. It was just weird

"No. That was a particularly loud thought." Unconcerned, they moved on to grooming their ears.

Like a lot of what Melog said, the question about Adora made her stop and think. Why would Adora have known that? She never mixed with cadets who weren't on Shadow Weaver's approved list. The only reason Catra knew was that she would frequently sneak out and meet up with other bored misfits. Adora only ever came once or twice.

No, strike that; Adora never came with her because she always did it when Adora was having extra training or whatever.

Even Catra had no idea how common it was for the regular soldiers to forage to supplement their meals until Entrapta did her needs analysis. Hordak and Shadow Weaver had the whole army on rations that were just enough to keep a soldier on their feet, assuming they weren't very big, they had a desk job, or bigger, hungrier folks didn't steal it. It wasn't nearly enough food for soldiers in the field who were fighting. So they either foraged, bought food on the black market, or else they stole from the towns and villages the Horde occupied--which only created more reasons for people to become insurgents.

It was Scorpia who told Entrapta to figure out how much they could afford to feed their soldiers while maintaining a reserve supply and then increase the rations accordingly. Catra signed off on it mostly to make Scorpia happy.

And maybe Catra signed off on it because, in her weaker moments, she remembered how Adora always seemed hungry and how often she shared her rations with Adora.

Catra paused at the entrance to the tent when she saw Adora sitting on the log near the fire. She grabbed a blanket and dropped it around Adora's shoulders. It was a little cold to be sitting in just her chemise and shorts.

Sitting on the log next to her, Catra gently bumped the other woman's shoulder with her own. "How're you feeling?" she asked Adora, who clutched at the blanket and hunched over a steaming cup of tea. "Is the tea helping?"

"A little." Adora nodded, squinting at Catra in the bright morning light, her pale face lined with pain. The dark circles under her eyes and the hangdog look killed any temptation Catra may have had to give her a hard time. Maybe later.

Leaning her head down on Catra's shoulder, Adora vowed, "I'm never drinking again,"

Catra put her hand on Adora's, "Do you want to go back to Brightmoon with Sparkles? Melog and I can probably find our way there by ourselves," she asked quietly.

"Ugh. No." Adora wrapped her hand around Catra's. "I can't imagine what teleporting would feel like with my stomach like this." She took another sip of the tea. "And, anyway," she went on in a softer voice, "I sort of… I sort of wanted to be the one to take you there."

"Well, really, it'll be Melog taking us both."

Adora nodded. "I'll be happy to get home."

Home.

Catra had agreed to come back to Brightmoon with Adora, but she wondered if it would ever feel like home to her. The one time she'd been there, she'd only seen it from the outside, and she'd been trying to lay siege to the place. She never imagined going there as an invited guest, let alone going as the duly appointed Ambassador from the Etherian Horde.

Yesterday that prospect had been exciting. Today it seemed a little daunting.

"Ah… Catra? Breakfast is ready." Felina came over with two plates filled with scrambled eggs and some kind of small game the girl had fried in the same pan.

"That's not a rat, is it?" muttered Adora and turned a little greener.

"You have a problem with fried rat?" Catra asked before her aid could answer. Catra wasn't going to give Adora a hard time about drinking too much rotgut, but she absolutely would give her a hard time about turning her nose up at perfectly good meat--especially since she was the one with the obsession with "real food." Probably it was a rabbit, but Catra *had* seen rats that size before.

"I… I'll be back," Adora said faintly, standing up to head back into the tent. "I don't think I can eat right now. I'm sorry. I'll just lie down for a bit."

Catra shook her head, but she held back her snickering until Adora was out of sight.

"Actually, it is…" Felina began, looking worried.

"No, don't tell me." Catra grinned at her. "I honestly don't care." To illustrate her point, she scooped a hefty bite onto her fork and put it in her mouth. "This is good," she said, around the mouthful.

The meat and the eggs were as good as any Bow had ever cooked for them. “You want her share?”

“No, thank you. I already ate.” Felina smiled a little. “I had breakfast with my mom and her squad.”

“Oh, cool.” Catra glanced at Adora’s plate that she’d left on the log, then picked it up and scraped the food onto her own plate. Wisely, Felina made the hungover woman a small portion, so Catra was happy to eat the extra herself. “More for me, then.”

Since they had gotten back to Etheria, Catra felt like she was hungrier than usual. It was probably a body fat thing. She had never had a lot of *cushion* to her, and she lost a lot of weight while she was in space. Now, if she didn’t eat as soon as she felt hungry, she would get dizzy to the point of faintness or nausea. To remedy the problem, she took every opportunity she could to eat big meals and always had a ration bar or something in her pocket.

While Catra ate, Felina cleaned and packed the cooking stuff away; then, she stood at ease with her hands behind her back. Just like every morning, Catra said, “have a seat, Felina. You’re making me nervous standing there like that.”

 “Yes, ma’am.” The young soldier sat down on the other log.

“Anyway, we need to talk about your next assignment.” Catra ate a few more bites, thinking through how to tell the girl what her new orders were going to be. “So, you know I’m heading to Brightmoon?”

The girl nodded, her green eyes wide and nervous.

“Agatha wanted to assign you there." Agatha had suggested it, and Felina made herself very useful, but Catra did not want to be responsible for the girl when she herself was not yet used to Brightmoon. She hadn’t figured out how to break the news. Fortunately, now there were other things to think about. "But, with what happened yesterday, I’ve had to reconsider.”

Silver and black ears drooped with dismay, and Felina wrapped her tail around herself. She swallowed, then nodded. “Yes, ma’am. Of course, ma’am.” The girl’s eyes flicked towards the tent and back. “I understand.” Tears were quickly blinked out of her eyes, and she bit her lip.

Catra hurried on, realizing she’d given the kid the wrong idea. “Oh, no. Not because of that. That's not what I mean. I just…I thought it wouldn’t be fair to Sara.”

“Ma’am?” Felina’s ears came back up.

“You and your mom haven’t seen each other in a long time. I thought maybe you might want to get an assignment near her. You can catch up with each other.” Catra peered at the girl to gauge her reaction, hoping that she hadn’t misjudged their relationship. “I mean… if that’s what you want.”

New tears formed in the corners of the girl's eyes, but her smile was broad as she nodded. “Yes, ma’am! That would be great!” Her tail lifted and swayed happily.

A weight dropped from Catra’s shoulders at the girl’s reaction. “I know that Scorpia’s prioritizing people getting to see their families. She's planning to get everyone on a leave rotation. She’s talking about giving everyone two days off a week."

“Yes, ma’am!” Felina’s eyes shone at the prospect..

A low, pained moan drifted from the tent. Catra glanced toward it. “I think it’ll be a while before Adora gets up again," she said wryly. "I better go make sure she's okay. Why don’t you head back to tell your mom? Come back at lunchtime and help us strike camp.”

Felina jumped up to salute. Catra stood to return it. Melog appeared beside them both, butting their head against Felina, leaving her smelling strongly of magical alien cat.

After the girl headed off, Catra took a moment to finish up the rat or whatever-it-was before she refilled Adora’s cup with tea.

"So, how're you feeling?" Catra called softly as she came in. Adora was almost completely hidden, curled up in their bedroll with blankets pulled over her head.

“Terrible.” Adora peeked out from her cocoon, the blanket covering her face from the nose down. “Stop laughing at me,” she grunted.

“I’m not.” Mindful of the hot liquid she carried, Catra knelt down beside Adora.

“What are you smiling for, then?”

“What? I can’t smile at my girlfriend?” Catra’s grin only grew wider; she couldn’t help it. The petulant frown and the sad query made Catra’s heart fill with something warm and soft.

Adora huffed and slowly sat up, letting the blanket slide down to her lap. "I'm dying a slow death, and you're laughing at me."

"Okay, maybe I'm laughing a little," Catra admitted, only because she couldn’t explain the sudden feeling of lightness in her chest. It tickled and bubbled and felt like it could spill out into giggles any second. "But only a little, and only because you're so cute." She handed Adora the tea.

"Not cute," Adora grumbled as she took the cup, her pout doing nothing to make her less cute. It made Catra want to lean in and nibble on her protruding lower lip, Perhaps when Adora felt better. For now, Catra contented herself with pushing a lock of hair that had escaped Adora’s ponytail behind her ear.

"Yes, you are." Putting her other hand in her pocket, Catra pulled out a ration bar. "Here, you want to try one of these? They work for me when my stomach is too upset for anything else. "

"Thanks." Adora took the proffered bar and took a tiny bite from the corner.

"Would it help if you transformed?" Catra reached up and tugged on Adora's ponytail, pulling out the elastic so she could play with her girlfriend's hair.

"Probably not." The blonde sighed and rubbed her eyes. "I'd feel great as She Ra, but the minute I transformed back, I'd feel like dirt again. The speed healing thing always makes me want to sleep. I'd be no better off."

"Okay." Catra hesitated, then asked, "I was going to talk to Scorpia before we left, but I can stay here if you need me to."

"No, you go on," Adora said. "I'll sleep for a couple more hours, and then I'll be good to go. I know a lot of people probably want to say bye to you."

Catra rolled her eyes. It wasn't like Brightmoon was all that far. At least it wasn't when the Whispering Woods wasn't actively trying to prevent you from reaching it. Scorpia kept talking like it was on the other side of the galaxy. "So, you still want to leave after lunch?"

Adora nodded. "I guess." She didn't sound enthused. "If you think that Melog can do it, I'd like to get there this evening. Glimmer said that the staff has been able to put everything pretty much to rights in the last few days."

The Queen had made it her habit to teleport to Brightmoon every day to check on the cleanup and redecorating efforts, but she was determined to stay at the Spire encampment until the new treaty had been signed and ratified.

Adora peered at Catra. "Are you sure you're still okay with coming? You don't have to. You can…"

"Adora." Catra reached forward and put a finger on the other woman's lips to make her stop talking. "Stop it. I said I wanted to

come, all right? I'm not usually big on telling people comforting lies." Catra withdrew her hand and went back to playing with Adora's hair. "I really want Darla's systems upgraded before I get on her again." Entrapta had definitely made it clear how necessary those upgrades were. "You know, so we don't die."

"Look who's all so fucking sensible and mature," Adora muttered with un-Adoralike bitterness.

That abruptly flattened the effervescence in Catra's chest, and she stopped petting through the blonde hair. "Do you… do you not want me to come?" Maybe she had changed her mind? Maybe all of that "Are you *sure* ?" stuff had been Adora looking for ways to let her down easy.

"Huh?"

"You sound… I don't know… mad about something?" Melog kept telling her to *ask* when she didn't understand someone's emotions. Most of their advice had panned out so far, but some of it was just so counter to everything she'd ever been told.

The other woman's cheeks darkened like she'd been caught out, and she looked away, pain and guilt flashing across her face.

Catra's heart stopped as she prepared for the next words to destroy her.

The other woman shook her head, loose hair swaying around her face."I'm not changing my mind." After a minute, her blue-gray eyes sought Catra's, and she smiled faintly. You're stuck with me."

Catra started breathing again. "So, what's the matter?"

"I just… I guess I'm kind of… scared to go back to Brightmoon."

That didn't make any sense. "Why are you scared?"

"It's stupid."

“Yeah, okay. But still, what’s scary about Brightmoon?”

Adora bent her knees so she could rest her arms and chin on them. “Never mind.”

Not knowing what to say to that, Catra scooted around until she could press her side against Adora’s and wrap one arm around her shoulders. When they were kids, Adora would sometimes shut down like this, and no amount of questioning could get her to talk.

As she had last night, Adora turned towards Catra, burying her face in the crook of her girlfriend’s neck.

Catra put her arms around Adora and maneuvered them both until they were lying full length on the bedding, pressed tummy to tummy and breast to breast, Adora’s face still hidden in Catra’s shoulder and her arms reaching to wrap around Catra’s waist. Unbidden, Catra’s purr rumbled up from her chest.

Adora’s shoulders shook, and she sniffled.

“You okay?” Catra whispered, her purr stuttering out.

“I’m just hung over,” Adora muttered thickly. “My head hurts, I still feel sick, and we have to pack up, and everything just feels like a huge fucking deal.”

“If you’re not feeling up to it, I’ll get Felina to go round up a couple people and get them to strike camp and pack for us. Assistants are really useful to have it turns out.” Catra never thought to request herself an aid, although according to Scorpia, most officers had one. Scorpia never requested one because Catra didn’t have one. Catra didn’t request one because she didn’t know she *could* . “Most of this stuff can just be tossed anyway. There’s not much we need to take home, is there?”

“No, not really.”

“Do you think you could go back to sleep?”

Adora nodded into Catra's neck. "Will you stay here for a few minutes?" The other woman asked in the voice of someone seeking a huge favor.

Yes, Catra could definitely do this for a few minutes. A few days or weeks, even. It would be even better if they had a proper bed. The biggest reason the new ambassador was looking forward to getting to Brightmoon was that it had things like *hot* showers and a lock on the door. The camp wasn't the greatest place to be feeling out the physical part of her and Adora's relationship. No time of the day was truly quiet, and with people tripping over themselves to get a moment with Catra or Adora, they had less privacy than they would in a bunkroom. At least when Catra lived in the officer's barracks, she had a door with a lock.

Apparently, Adora was suffering from hangover anxiety. Before Catra could answer her, she stiffened. "Never mind," she said. "I know you're supposed to meet with Scorpia and everything. I'm sorry, I just… You don't have to coddle me." She made a tiny hiccuping sound (Catra was pretty sure it was a suppressed sob) and started to pull away. "I know you have more important things going on."

Catra tightened her arms around the bigger woman's muscular shoulders, not letting her go. "Shh. It's okay. We have time. She's supposed to look for me here when she wakes up. She'll probably be a while" The effervescent feeling was back in her chest, tickly and warm. It made her grin and bury her nose in Adora's hair. "You weren't the only one who got hammered last night. Last I saw, Perfuma was introducing her to some mind-altering fungus. And if you want, I can just tell her you're sick."

"She Ra doesn't get sick," Adora mumbled. "I can't get sick. People need me."

"Shut up, dork." Catra rubbed Adora's back and smiled fondly. "Go to sleep. The world's not going to end if you take a nap, I promise."

In a whisper so faint that only Catra would be able to hear it, Adora said, "I haven't been able to sleep right in so long."

"What do you mean?" Catra would have pulled back to look at Adora's face, but the other woman wouldn't loosen her hold.

After a second, Adora sighed into Catra's neck. "I'm not scared when you're here," she confessed in that barely audible tone. "Will you… will you keep watch while I sleep?"

"Of course, dummy. I'm right here."

Leaders

Chapter Summary

Adora thinks.
Catra and Scorpia talk.

"Catra?" Scorpia called from just outside the tent. "Are you awake?"

"Let go," Catra whispered, pulling at Adora's arm wrapped around her waist. "Yep, I'm here," she called loudly, "Gimme a sec."

As Catra attempted to sit up, Adora tightened her hold briefly but relaxed enough for Catra to wriggle free. "Don't go far?" she asked, opening one eye to look pleadingly at her girlfriend.

Smiling faintly, Catra smoothed Adora's hair. "Yeah. I'll be right outside. I promise. I won't even go out of earshot."

"Okay." The last thing Adora wanted was for Catra to go anywhere, but she also didn't want to seem downright pathetic. She frowned. "You're still laughing at me," Adora accused, trying to make sense of Catra's expression. It wasn't the mean smirk that Catra sported when she genuinely tried to mock Adora, but it *was* smug.

Melog made a little *mrowp* noise, and the other woman's eyes softened further. "Not really. I just…" She trailed off and then smoothed Adora's hair again. Her smile widened to bare her sharp canines, and she looked off to the side. "I just kind of like taking care of you." Her cheeks blazed red as she realized the double meaning of what she just said.

That made Adora's cheeks heat a little too.

"Anyway," Catra hurried on, "I'll be just outside. Okay? Promise."

Adora nodded and pulled the bedding over her head to block the light.

"Hey, Scorpia, " Adora heard Catra call as she exited the tent.

"Catra!" Scopia stopped; her tone changed to one of concern. "You okay?"

"I'm tired. " Catra huffed a little and then went on. "I just…I don't know. "

Their voices faded as they moved away from the tent--Catra always forgot that "earshot" was different for Adora, but she could still hear her girlfriend's voice even if she couldn't hear exactly what she said. True to her word, she must only be at the far edge of the fire pit.

Adora curled up into a fetal position under her blanket, feeling anxious and nauseous. She was never drinking again. Or maybe that was premature. Perhaps she should track down Sea Hawk and find a supply of decent alcohol. Most of her misery had nothing to do with drinking and everything to do with *her* and the unpleasant truths she grappled with.

This week Adora and the rest of the Alliance had learned a *lot* of unpleasant truths. As they'd ironed out the Spire Accords, the Princesses finally discovered how Catra had managed to take and hold so much territory. Why so many towns, villages, and settlements just seemed to fall without even token resistance.

It had started in Dryl, in the towns that owed their allegiance to Entrapta already. Under Catra's orders, a commander rolled up to a town with a small contingent to find the local person in charge and let them know that Dryl was now a Horde protectorate. In exchange for transferring allegiance, they were given a promise of law and order, protection against outside hazards, and help with specific needs. Farming communities needed help with things like protecting stock animals from predators. Industrial sites benefitted from the expertise of Horde tech specialists. Taxes were to be

assessed, but they weren’t any more burdensome than the taxes the community already paid to Entrapta. They did the same thing in the Crimson Waste and then in every village and town near the borders of Horde-controlled territory.

Safe streets, policed by well-fed soldiers, with little incentive to steal from or mistreat the locals (and threats of severe disciplinary action for doing so) persuaded most people just to accept Horde rule. In the run-up to the invasion of Salineas, many outlying coastal communities came under Horde occupation without a single shot fired.

As Catra pointed out repeatedly, this strategy wasn’t altruistic but practical. Most of the time, people didn’t give a fuck who was their ruler as long as they could live their lives. This strategy allowed the Horde to leave skeleton crews holding far-flung outposts to lead the Princesses on wild goose chases so Catra could concentrate her forces to take Salineas. By the time Catra got to the Sea Gate, she'd had them chasing their tails, culminating in that disastrous night where they’d been distracted by their failure to retake Dryl and Double Trouble’s antics. If Glimmer hadn’t tried to use the Heart and open the door for Prime’s invasion, the Horde, under Catra’s leadership, would have won.

A chill settled on Adora’s soul as she considered that. Everyone looked to She Ra for leadership, but Shadow Weaver trained her to be a weapon, not a leader. For so many years, Adora believed Shadow Weaver. Worse, she believed *in* Shadow Weaver. She believed all the old woman’s bullshit because it *worked* for her. Life was much more comfortable when she just needed to follow orders. Light Hope must have been delighted when the new She Ra came already primed for her role.

When they were teenagers, Catra invited Adora on her explorations throughout the Fright Zone. As much as she loved Catra’s wild stories of meeting cadets from lower-ranked cadres, she never wanted to join her. Not because she was afraid of getting in trouble, but because Adora wasn’t even *curious* about them. Their purpose was to fight. Hers was to command.

Inexcusably, even before Adora defected, she thought of the low-ranked Horde soldiers as little more than bots.

Ironically, it was only after she broke the Sword, when She Ra was beyond reach, that she understood the realities of battle because Adora had never been in a real battle. As Shadow Weaver kept reminding her until Micah made her stop, without the Sword of Protection, she was just another Rebel fighter.

Knowing she let everyone down, Adora pitched in wherever she could. During the evacuation of Bright Moon, she helped transport the wounded. She wasn't She Ra anymore, but she was still strong enough to grab the end of a stretcher.

What she saw had appalled her. Cringing, Adora recalled that before she broke the Sword, it never came into her head that maybe she should help with the casualties in the aftermath of a battle, even after she figured out how to use her healing powers. Even after Bow got hurt.

At Dryl Pass, She Ra flipped that tank like a toy, leaving it a smoking wreck. Had Sara screamed for help? Adora could imagine Derrick and Trevor's terror. She could imagine them tearing the thing apart to get to Sara before she succumbed to smoke inhalation or the fire detonated any spare ordinance in the vehicle. Had there even been a battlefield medic left in that skeleton crew? How long did they have to wait until an evac vehicle reached them?

Adora had no idea. Eager to get home so she could return to squabbling with Glimmer, She Ra never even looked back.

"So, this is it." Scorpia sat down on the log and rubbed the back of her neck. "I can't believe you're going."

"I'm going to Bright Moon. I'm not dying," Catra scoffed as she joined her. "I'll send you reports all the time. I'll even stop by for dinner once in a while if you want."

That made Scorpia light up with a smile. “Perfuma wants to do a game night with Spinerella and Netossa. You want to come?” But then she tilted her head to one side, drawing her eyebrows together and pursing her lips like she thought she said something wrong, and started backpedaling. “Oh, but you can just come over any time if you don’t want to learn board games. I know how awkward you feel because you--I mean, how awkward it can feel if you’ve never done anything like that.”

Catra blinked. That was an odd thing for Scorpia to say. True, but odd. “It’s okay. I’m sure a game night won’t kill me.”

The big woman went silent, but she fidgeted with her claws as though working up the courage to say something. “Listen, Perfuma suggested that maybe we might want to talk about what happened to us. About… about the chip, I mean,” she blurted.

The sudden change in topic caught Catra entirely off guard, and she sucked in a noisy breath as her heart started hammering. “No,” she gritted. “I do not want to talk about it.”

Rather than offended, Scorpia seemed relieved. “Oh. Okay. That’s fine. I’m fine with not talking about it.”

“So, why bring it up?” Catra asked, narrowing her eyes at the current leader of the Horde.

“Perfuma thought you… Well, she just said you might want to talk. About things.” Scorpia held her pincers up in surrender, “But, it can totally wait.”

Becoming visible, Melog bumped their head against Catra’s knee. “This one cares for you, Granddaughter.”

Well, she shouldn't. Catra never treated Scorpia right, and the big woman just accepted it, continuing to be her kind and supportive self. Sometimes, Catra wondered if she pushed Scorpia just to get her to push back.

Making a conscious effort to smooth down her hackles, Catra put her hand on Melog's head before answering. "I'm sorry. " That word was becoming second nature. "I just can't. Not yet."

Scorpia's dark eyes were sad and understanding. "No problem." She seemed to cast about for something else to say for a second. "Thanks for what you said to Agatha yesterday," she finally settled on.

"Hey, it was all true." Catra shrugged, resting her elbows on her thighs and looking down at her hands clasped between her knees.

The big woman copied Catra's posture, resting her pincers. She took a deep breath. "I'm sorry."

Catra sat up, and swiveled around to stare at Scorpia. "What are *you* apologizing for?"

"Just… a lot of things, I guess. I know I wasn't a great soldier and maybe not even a good friend and… "

"Stop," Catra growled. "You are not doing this." The last thing she wanted was for Scorpia to apologize to her. She had not planned for the conversation to get suddenly emotional and awkward.

"This one fears to disappoint her people in her new role," Melog put in. "And it has brought all her doubts of herself to the surface. She seeks reassurance. Your good opinion is very important to her." It was really helpful that no one but Catra could understand Melog.

"Scorpia." Catra put her hand on the other woman's claw. "You have *nothing* to be sorry for." She thought for a second about how to explain. "Okay, you're right. You were never a great soldier." Scorpia's face started to crumple, so Catra hastened on. "You were a good one, sure. But, the things you're great at *aren't* warfare. You care about everyone. You listen to people and try to understand them." Catra hesitated, wondering how honest she should be here. Melog poked her with their nose, a clear encouragement. "Everyone likes you." She scratched her nose just

to give herself a reason to look away as she admitted, "I was always kind of jealous of that."

That seemed to arrest Scorpia's spiral. She stared with wide eyes. "Catra…"

"No. Shut up." If Catra didn't say this now, she never would. "Let me finish. This isn't easy for me."

"Oh. Okay. Shutting up now. Go."

"The only reason you were never a great soldier is that you were never *meant* to be a soldier. And here's the thing, a soldier isn't what we need right now. What we need is *you* ."

Scorpia's lip quivered, and she sniffed.

"I meant what I said yesterday," Catra affirmed, patting the chitin under her hand. "We have so much to rebuild and so much work ahead of us. People need a leader with your positive attitude. They need someone loyal to them, who cares about them. Hordak and Shadow Weaver never cared about anyone. All that stuff folks are giving me credit for and saying how great it is. That's all stuff I signed off on to make you happy. So really, it was all you. I know you'll do great as a Princess." Catra braced herself.

"Thank you." Tears ran down Scorpia's face, but she made no move to swoop down on Catra. "That's just so… " she didn't finish, losing her words to a sob and covering her face with her claws.

Melog sauntered around to put their head in Scorpia's lap. "Oh. Don't cry. Come here." Catra wrapped her arms around the weeping Scorpian Princess as far as she could, and wiped away the tears with the end of her tail.

Official

Chapter Summary

Plans are put into motion.

"So, uh, did Catra tell you what your new assignment is?" Sara asked as soon as Felina returned from looking after Catra's (and Adora's) breakfast. She sat on the ground, repairing her comm unit with spare parts someone had in their transport. Although she tried to keep the words casual and off-hand, the slight hitch to her mother's voice told Felina that Sara was worried.

"Well, Agatha recommended me to Catra to go with her to Bright Moon," the girl began.

Sara's head snapped up, her face paling, her hands starting to shake so that she had to put the electronics down. "Bright Moon?" she gasped, her voice a squeak.

Derrick froze, and Trevor's eyes were wide as they broke off from their conversation at the name of that dreaded place.

"Are you fucking kidding me?" Derrick swore. "Are they out of their minds?" The ox-like man went to go sit next to Sara, taking her hand.

"No, wait." Felina held up her hand, cutting them off. "Let me finish." The girl had suspected that Catra was merely trying to let her down easy, but the stark fear on her mom's face told her this was what Catra *meant* when she said it wouldn't be fair to Sara.

"Okay," Sara whispered, visibly bracing herself by wrapping both hands around Derrick's while he put his free hand around her shoulders. Both of them looked more scared than Felina had ever seen.

Felina couldn't blame them. *She* knew that she would be safe in the no-longer-enemy-territory of Bright Moon, but the three of

them had only just returned. They had not sat at campfires with Alliance fighters trading recipes nor joined in the casual games people played in the evenings. They had not seen the Princesses and the Horde representatives negotiating reparations from both sides (the negotiations had been open for anyone to watch). They had not seen Catra teasing Queen Glimmer or Scorpia flirting with Princess Perfuma. Nor had they seen Agatha yell at everyone as though they were cadets to get them to quiet down.

Felina hurried to give her the good news. Perhaps she should not have led with it. “So, yeah. As I said, Agatha recommended me, but Catra said it wouldn’t be fair to you if I went to Bright Moon.”

Confused, Sara glanced at Derrick and Trevor, who looked equally baffled. “I don’t understand. Why does it matter what I want?” Her eyebrows came together in a worried frown. “I didn’t screw anything up for you last night, did I?”

“No, no. Nothing like that. She just said that she and Scorpia want to prioritize people seeing their families and that my next assignment should be close to you,” Felina finished in a rush.

An elated smile slowly bloomed on Sara’s face. “Really?” she asked, as though making sure she heard right.

Felina nodded happily. “She also said that Scorpia wants to get everyone on a leave rotation. They’re talking two days off a week!”

“Seriously?” Trevor exclaimed. “Two days. Out of every seven? Seriously?”

“Seriously.”

“That’s amazing!” The young soldier stood up to high-five Felina.

Derrick squeezed Sara’s shoulders, and his smile was as bright as hers. “In that case, I, uh, guess we should talk to you two about something,” he said in his slow, rich voice. “About some changes in the squad.”

“Have you got new assignments?” Felina asked, surprised. “I didn’t think assignments would happen until at least next week.

“Not yet,” Sara told them. “And we wanted to do this before they gave us new assignments,” She and Derrick exchanged an excited, almost nervous look. “We wanted to get Official Sanction.”

“That’s assuming you two are okay with that,” Derrick jumped in hastily, watching their faces. “Trevor? Will you request it? I want to do it today if we can find an officer who has a minute.”

“That’s awesome, you guys!” crowed Trevor. “I would love to! Who do you want me to ask? I saw Grizzlor this morning. I could ask him.”

Sara bit her lip, staring at Felina. “Sweety? Are you okay with it?” she asked.

Okay? Felina blinked the wetness from her eyes, touched that they would ask her. She didn’t actually have any say since she wasn’t in her mom’s squad, but clearly, Sara wanted Felina’s approval as much as Trevor’s.

The girl was more than okay with her mom and Derrick being together. The ox-like man had been a fixture in Felina’s life for as long as she could remember. He had been in the same squad as her parents when her father had been alive. After they lost her father, he had always been good to Felina. When she was little, he whittled toy soldiers for her, and he always had a chunk of ration bar he saved for her when Felina stayed with her mom.

Felina knew they started bunking together sometime before her mom got hurt. She also knew how he had torn the tank apart to get her mom out, heedless of his own injuries. He treated her for fifteen hours in the field until they were evacced. He had shown up at the infirmary every day that he wasn’t deployed to the field. Once Sara had been discharged to rehab with her brace, he’d shown up just as often to help her learn to walk again. When she

was well enough to be redeployed, he'd unreservedly requested Sara back in his squad.

Too overcome to speak, the girl went over to hug her mom and (hopefully) soon-to-be dad.

Felina's comlink chirped, interrupting the moment. She tapped the receive switch, feeling self-conscious as the other three noted the comlink that Catra had given her was the type reserved for officers. "This is Felina."

"Hey, Felina," Catra's voice said, "I need some people to help me strike camp. Two or three should work. It won't take more than a few minutes."

"Yes, ma'am. My mom's squad is free. Will they do?"

"Perfect." A pause. "Oh, hold on a minute. " Catra muted the line for a second as if someone on the other end were speaking to her. The line unmuted. "Why don't guys bring up lunch for all of us? We can sit and eat first."

"Yes, ma'am!"

"Great. Come up at noon." The call ended.

The three adults (well, two adults; Trevor was only two years older than Felina, and she still had a hard time thinking of him that way) stared open-mouthed at being invited to eat with the ambassador.

A wonderful idea occurred to the girl. "You know, you could ask Catra to make you Official." Traditionally, requests to be made Official were heard at lunchtime, although anytime you could get an officer to stay still for ten minutes was allowable. A sanctioning ceremony presided over by a high-status Force Captain always was worth bragging rights. Bonus points if they were in a formal uniform.

“Oh, no. We couldn’t bother her with this.” Sara’s cheeks darkened in embarrassment. “She’s probably got a million other things to do. I’ve never heard of her making anyone Official.”

“Yeah,” Trevor said. “There is no way I am going to Catra with this. I mean, come on. Why would she even want to hear a request? Especially from someone like me.”

“Uh, well… She did invite you to eat with them,” Felina said, her tail twitching nervously. “I know I’m not *technically* in your squad, but I could do it.” She smiled shyly. “And I know her friend Melog really likes me.”

“Yeah, lucky for us,” Trevor put in seriously. “Otherwise, we’d still be walking.”

“Do you think she would?” Derrick asked slowly.

Felina nodded. “I think so. She’s been really great.”

Derrick and Sara looked at each other, and then Sara said gently, “Trevor? You rank here. It’s really up to you. You could ask Catra, or if you want to ask Grizzlor or someone for us, we’re happy with that.”

The young man laughed. “Are you kidding? If Felina thinks she can get *Catra* to make you Official, I am not getting in the way!”

Looking up from the report she read (she had promised to help Scorpia with some project logistics), Catra made room for Adora to sit beside her on the log, pleased to see Adora dressed and upright. The extra two or three hours of sleep made her look much less like one of Shadow Weaver’s undead Princess stories. "How are you feeling?"

A sheepish smile curved Adora’s lips. “A lot better. Sorry.” The taller woman’s hip and leg pressed into Catra’s. The dark-haired woman went to scoot over, but Adora’s arm went around her waist. “Is this okay?” she asked softly.

Carefully, Catra put the papers and her tracker pad down on top of her leather bag. “Yeah.” She slipped her arm around Adora’s neck and turned a little to press their foreheads together. After a second, she asked. “Can I kiss you?”

“Oh, ick. I’m gross.” Adora giggled. “I thought you had a supersensitive nose or something.”

“You’re not much worse than usual,” Catra teased, wrapping her tail around Adora’s wrist. “I’m pretty much used to it.”

Adora giggled again. “Um. Okay, then.” Her blue-grey eyes softened, and her smile made Catra’s heart skip. The blonde’s hand came up to pet Catra’s ears.

Purring, Catra leaned in, just brushing Adora’s lips with her own. When they parted, Adora dropped her hand to Catra’s cheek. “Love you,” she whispered.

Catra backed up a little to look into her girlfriend’s face. Adora’s eyes glowed blue, and a golden light gathered around her hair. “Hey, Adora?” Catra said with a smirk. “Did you know your eyes are doing the She Ra thing?”

“That’s your fault, not mine,” Adora muttered, looking off to the side, her smile a little embarrassed. The gathering magic did not dissipate.

A warm, giddy wave of affection washed over Catra. Adora told her that, since the Heart, sometimes she transformed spontaneously because she was overwhelmed with emotion. Especially love.

“*My* fault?” Grinning, Catra pressed her hand to her chest in mock indignation. “What? I’m just sitting here.” She unwrapped her tail from Adora’s wrist and caressed the side of the taller woman’s face with it. “I’m not doing anything,” she said softly, leaning in again for a deeper kiss, this time closing her eyes and running her tongue over Adora’s lips.

The other woman opened her mouth, allowing Catra's gentle exploration, making a little noise of appreciation. And then, as Catra had hoped, she was suddenly kissing a *much* taller woman. Satisfied, she ended the kiss so that she could stare up into She Ra's bottomless blue eyes. "Okay. *That* was my fault."

She Ra giggled and covered her mouth with her hand, her cheeks darkening as she looked away. Catra always loved the sound of Adora's laughter, and the shy smile on She Ra's face was adorably out-of-place.

Abruptly, She Ra stopped laughing. She stared at something over Catra's shoulder, and her flush deepened beyond shy. In fact, she looked almost ashamed.

Catra turned to see what She Ra was looking at. "Can I help you with something?" she growled. Two young soldiers had stopped in the middle of the path beside the campsite and gawked at them.

"No, ma'am. Sorry, ma'am," one of them squeaked, taking a step back and pulling her companion with her.

"I'm sure you have something you need to do?" Catra gritted.

"Yes, ma'am." They saluted Catra, but their eyes rested warily on She Ra.

"Dismissed." Catra didn't stand; she gave them a sketchy half salute, and they took the opportunity to hurry away. Whether they were more terrified of Catra or She Ra was anyone's guess.

"I hope that stops soon." Adora sat on the log. With She Ra gone, she seemed small and pensive. "I'm so tired of people being scared of me."

"Don't worry," grunted Catra, taking Adora's hand. "We're heading to Brightmoon, and you can bask in their adulation."

"Adulation?" Adora tilted her head, and the corner of her mouth quirked up. "That's not really a word."

“Yes, it is.”

“What does it mean, then?” The blonde crossed her arms over her chest.

Catra smirked. “It means flattery. Applause. Worship.”

For some reason, Adora’s brows knitted, and she shifted uncomfortably.

"What?" Catra tilted her head.

“That’s almost as bad.” The woman looked away, settling her elbows on her thighs and her chin on her hands, withdrawing into herself.

Catra put her arm around Adora’s waist and her chin on the blonde’s shoulder. “It’ll be okay,” she whispered into her ear. “As long as we’re together.”

Sara, Derrick, and Trevor followed Felina while she briefly stopped at Frosta’s campsite. They opted to hang back, standing a little way down the road, while Felina said goodbye to the girl. Mike and Lee were already there, seeing the Ice Princess off.

“So, I’ll talk to Scorpia about you guys coming for a visit in a few weeks?” Frosta asked. “And don’t be afraid to call me. I’ll probably be bored stupid in about three days,” she told them. She hugged each of them in turn and then skidded away on the track of ice she made for herself.

“Who was that again?” Trevor asked, dumbfounded as he watched her glide away.

“That was Princess Frosta,” Felina told him.

“Where does she come from?”

“Kingdom of Snows.” Derrick supplied quietly.

“Wait. You guys fought there once, didn’t you?”

Sara sighed before she spoke. “A long time ago, Trevor. She would have been a baby.” She glanced at Derrick, who took her hand. “Story for another time,” she finished gently.

“So, you’re like friends with a Princess?” Trevor demanded, causing Felina to explain about iceball. The story had them all staring at her, their mouths open.

Since today was a general rest day, rations and cold food ingredients were available in the cook tent today, overseen by a forbiddingly tall lizard-type. She was only there to ensure no one ran off with more than their fair share. She nodded approvingly at Felina as she collected food for Catra, Adora, and herself.

“Hey, you three!” she growled. “You just come in from the field?”

The three soldiers froze, then Trevor guiltily put the red fruit he’d taken back into the box where he found them. “Yes, ma’am,” he said.

The lizard woman rolled her eyes. “Don’t ma’am me, son. I work for a living.”

“Yes, Specialist. Sorry, Specialist.

She pointed at a sign. “So, you can take double rations if you want. Here are the ration equivalents if you want to take something to cook later.”

“Oh. That’s fantastic,” Trevor exclaimed. “Thanks!” While Sara and Derrick studied the chart, he grabbed the red fruit and a few other things. Efficiently the three loaded up their bags.

On the long walk to Catra’s camp, Trevor peppered Felina with questions about how she became Catra’s aid. She told him about how Catra and Melog found her hiding in the rubble of the Fright Zone and Agatha’s decision to follow Catra to Spire. She avoided mentioning that she’d tried to take on She Ra single-handedly. Her

mom was already weird enough about everything else Felina told her.

They topped the little rise that shielded this part of the camp from the main part. Two soldiers hurried in the opposite direction, both looking like they'd seen an evil spirit from the Whispering Woods. "You might want to take the other path," one of them advised. He looked worriedly behind him. "You don't want to interrupt anything."

Trevor, Derrick, and Sara glanced at each other and then at Felina, clearly concerned about it.

"It's fine," Felina assured them. "They're expecting us." She strode forward, trying to project more confidence than she felt.

As they rounded the corner, Felina was relieved to see Catra sitting on her log, talking to Adora, who looked much better than she had this morning. Both of them smiled when they saw them coming. Melog sat up and purred their afternoon greeting.

Felina stopped, just outside the perimeter of the circle of logs around the fire pit, suddenly unsure. She knew how she pictured it in her head, but now they were here, she felt tongue-tied. Trevor standing beside her, nudged her and gave her a clear, "well, go ahead," nod.

Sara, who stood behind her, whispered, "It's fine if you don't want to ask, sweetheart."

Derrick echoed the sentiment with a gentle pat on Felina's shoulder. "We can get someone else."

Catra raised one eyebrow, obviously having heard. "Ask me what?"

"Well, you see, ma'am," Felina said to Catra. "We," she indicated herself and Trevor, "have a formal request to make." She set her bags down on the rock by the firepit that served as a makeshift table. "If-um- if you'll hear it?"

“Of course.”

The tension left Felina’s shoulders then. It wasn’t that she’d been worried. Not really. But Catra *was* busy. They were supposed to be helping her strike camp, not adding to her duties. Felina understood why Trevor didn’t want to do it, even though it was considered an honor. This was much more intimidating than she thought it would be.

She walked forward and dropped to one knee with her elbow on her thigh and her head bowed in the traditional pose.

Both women gasped. Felina couldn’t tell why since she couldn’t see their faces well.

Adora cleared her throat. “ Oh. Oh, that’s… um. Can- can we talk to Scorpia about that?” she murmured.

“Mm-hmm. Yeah, definitely,” Catra agreed quietly. Out loud, she said, “Felina, uh, get up.” She coughed and then said with a little more certainty, “I mean, you may rise.”

Coming to her feet, Felina half-bowed for the requisite five seconds. She rose, standing at attention.

“So, what is your request?” Catra asked.

“Ambassador Catra, I have come on behalf of Specialist Sara and Chief Gunner Derrick. They are requesting permanent assignment to the same quarters and commands."

Catra sat up straighter, a smile playing on the edge of her lips as she said formally, “Felina. I would be happy to hear their request and approve their commitment.” Her smile widened, “Assuming they can convince me. Do any soldiers they fight with have objections?”

“No, ma’am!” Trevor and Felina yelled in unison.

Derrick and Sara came forward as Felina moved to the side to stand with Trevor. They bowed to her, and for good measure, it seemed, they bowed to Adora.

“Derrick.” Catra rose to her feet, her hands behind her back. “What surety do you give me that this union is beneficial to the goals of the Horde?”

“We are stronger together,” Derrick said in his slow, rich voice. “I’ll share my last blanket and my last ration. I’ll fight beside her until death takes me or until the end of the world.”

“Sara?” Catra asked, “Do you confirm this?”

“Ambassador, I confirm this,” Sara’s vow rang out. “We are stronger together. I’ll share my last blanket and my last ration. I’ll fight beside him until death takes me.” She sniffed hard. “And until the end of the world.”

“So, I’ve heard your request,” Catra said slowly. “And I approve.” She grinned. “Did the rest of you hear? Will you swear as witnesses?”

“Heard and witnessed!” Trevor, Felina, and Adora exclaimed, applauding.

Catra searched around herself, looking through her ever-present stack of documents for a blank page.

“I got it!” Felina entered the tent and brought out a blank paper notepad, a good pen, and an empty file folder.

“Thanks!” Catra took the paper from her and sat to draw up and sign the note that allowed them to be entered into the records as an Officially Sanctioned pair and gave it to Derrick, who promptly burst into tears.

Sara patted his hand and took it from him, admiring Catra’s signature at the bottom. Felina handed her the empty file folder, and she carefully tucked it away in her backpack.

Modifications

Chapter Summary

Adora wants to fix things.

The last day had been a lot for Sara. Being picked up from the road by Catra and then spending the night drinking with the-girl-who-became-She Ra would have been enough to have her reeling. This morning she nearly had a heart attack when Felina mentioned being stationed at Bright fucking Moon like it was the most normal thing in the world. And then the girl pulled out an *officer's* communicator badge (Sara hoped it meant what she thought it meant. No one from their section had ever been chosen for officer's training before). And then Felina told them she was friends with a Princess? It was *a lot.*

It seemed to be a lot for Felina as well. When they arrived at Catra's camp, Sara saw her daughter's hackles go up and her tail lash. She almost expected Felina to change her mind, but then the girl pulled herself together. Sara was so proud she could burst.

Their Official Sanction certificate was safely stowed until they could get to a terminal and put it in the records. After that, Sara planned to get the certificate framed. Otherwise, no one would believe that *Catra* officiated their union.

It took a couple of minutes for everyone to calm down enough to think about the work they needed to do. Derrick squeezed Sara's hand and whispered. "Why don't you get lunch fixed? The kids and I can handle the tear-down." He always noticed when Sara started to limp and wanted her to find a job that allowed her to sit.

"So, do we want to eat first or pack first?" the blonde-girl-who-became-She-Ra (Sara could *not* remember her actual name) asked. She bit her lip and jiggled her knee as she sat.

“Pack first,” Catra replied. “There isn’t much,” She told her aid. “Felina. You and Trevor start packing up. We’ll be along in a minute.”

“Yes, ma’am.” Felina saluted and led Trevor into the tent.

Catra waited until the youngsters were out of sight. “So, we wanted to have a word with you two for a minute,” she said. The grin she flashed made Sara relax a little.

“Yes, ma’am.” Derrick and Sara said in unison, although neither moved. No way were they going to sit before the former Second.

The ambassador flopped down onto the ground right next to the blonde sitting on the log, casually leaning against her thigh. The great cat creature appeared from nowhere and settled with its head on Catra’s lap.

Sara lowered herself to sit on the ground with her back against one of the logs so that she could straighten her leg. Derrick sat beside her.

The two women glanced at each other as if they didn’t know where to start. Melog trilled, and Catra nodded to it and then looked at Sara. “So, yeah. Adora and I wanted a chance to talk to you before we left.”

“If that’s okay with you,” Adora put in (Sara was very glad Catra supplied the name). “If- if you don’t want to talk to me, I understand.” She chewed her lips and waited.

For a beat, neither Sara nor Derrick realized she was asking their permission. Then Sara stuttered, "Oh. Y-yeah, whatever you… I mean, yes, ma'am. Of course."

“I just… I wanted to….” The blonde girl looked away for a minute. Her mouth firmed, and she sat up straighter, clenching her fists on her thighs, visibly steeling herself. “I wanted to tell you that I’m sorry.”

“I… what?”

“I’m sorry for what happened, I’m sorry you got hurt.” Adora winced. The knuckles of her fists were white. She sniffed, wiped her nose with her sleeve, and said in a high-pitched, barely audible voice, “I am sorry that *I* hurt you.”

“Hey, it’s okay,” Sara said softly, her heart hammering. “We ambushed you." She swallowed hard. "We all had our orders, right?”

“I *gave* those orders,” Catra said softly, pulling her knees up to rest her chin on them and wrapping her tail around herself, exactly like Felina did when she was unhappy and those mismatched eyes had the stare of someone who has seen far too much. Rumor had it that she’d taken on Horde Prime alone to rescue Bright Moon’s queen. The word was that she had been chipped and tortured for her trouble.

"What else were you supposed to do?" Derrick asked, his voice becoming stern, which was as close to angry as he ever allowed himself to get outside of combat. “It was a solid plan, and it worked. It was a war. People get hurt. Don't you forget that Sara and me fought against the first Alliance."

Both girls looked a little blank at that. They were too young to know what it was like.

"Hordak and Shadow Weaver never cared what happened to us. " He waved his hand to encompass the whole camp. "You and Scorpia were the best thing that ever happened to the Horde. Don't apologize for it."

Catra smiled, her cheeks reddening. “Thanks for saying that,” she said a little thickly. “It means a lot.”

Tears trickled from Adora’s eyes, and she brushed them away. “I just… .” She took a deep breath. “I’m not expecting you to… forgive me or anything. That’s not what this is about.”

She met Sara's eyes again, her face hopeful. "I wanted to see if I could do something to help you. Remember I told you that She Ra has healing magic? I thought maybe I could try to fix your knee."

The young woman didn't move, but at the word "magic," Adora's gray eyes glowed bright electric blue, and her ponytail seemed to blow around, although Sara could not detect a breeze.

The soldier's vision tunneled. For an instant, the specialist didn't see the sad, screwed-up kid she met last night. Instead, she saw She Ra in all her terrifying glory.

She blinked, scrubbed her eyes with her fingertips, and looked again. She Ra was *not* here, and Adora bit her lip while she waited for Sara to reply.

*Do **not** have a panic attack,* Sara told herself, but her chest hurt, her face felt tight, and she wanted to curl up and sob.

Later, she promised herself. She'd do it later. Later, when no one would see her. Later, when she could afford to cry until she was out of tears. Later, when she could afford to be weak.

Now, she concentrated on bringing herself back from the terrible edge that threatened to crumble beneath the weight of her fear. She sucked in a long breath.

Adora's red boots, she noted silently, *and her red jacket. A golden wing pin. That's three things I can see. Catra's yellow eye has streaks of copper, and her blue eye is the color of that warm water bay on the coast of Salineas. That's five,* she told herself.

She let her breath out.

A Plumarian they met after Prime's invasion taught them this. They and some others had to hide from a bombardment in a cave. A few people melted down afterward, panicked from the shelling and claustrophobia even after it was over. It could get her through this conversation.

She could hear the wind, birdsong, people walking by, and the kids talking in the tent.

Little needles of electricity stung her nerves where the implanted electrodes in her leg met the sensors in her knee brace. Sweat trickled down her neck. Derrick held her hand.

She could smell campfires and damp earth.

She licked her lips, tasting salt.

Melog (amazing how she could remember Catra's alien friend's name) stood and shook themselves out, coming over to her and resting their head on her thigh, looking up at her, purring. Their purr reminded Sara of Felina's father - solid, soothing, and strong. Their weight on her leg kept her in the present, and her chest loosened. She could think again.

"But, we get it if that's not something you're comfortable with," Catra added. Her ears had gone up, her tail puffed up a little, and she regarded Sara cautiously, clearly smelling her fear. "I promise, it's okay to say you're not interested."

The blonde looked glum and nodded her agreement.

"Why me?" Sara asked softly, slowly pulling little bits of grass up from beside her. "There are a lot of people that She Ra hurt. Can your magic fix them, too?"

So many of her friends had permanent injuries. It didn't feel right for her to be singled out just because Adora wanted to absolve herself from guilt. "Can you come to the Fright Zone and fix every person that a Princess wrecked?"

Adora opened her mouth and then closed it, looking away. "I don't know." Her chin firmed with determination, and she met Sara's gaze. "I know I have to try."

Again that icy blue flash in Adora's eyes. It had not been Sara's imagination.

Lifting their head, Melog turned towards Adora, ears back, mane turning purple and jagged. They rumbled a soft, almost-growl at her. Sara put her hand on their mane, hoping to soothe them. It seemed to work, they put their head back down, and their mane smoothed out to blue. The thought drifted through her mind that the creature would not allow their family, however distant, to come to harm if they could prevent it.

“They used to say Shadow Weaver got sick if she used too much magic. If you were to try to fix all those people, what would that do to you?” Sara wondered out loud.

“I kind of had the same question, actually,” Catra said with a sardonic twist of her lip, nudging Adora’s leg with her elbow as if she’d already brought this up. “We don’t even know if it works on old injuries like that. Melog says they can’t tell because it’s physical, not magical.”

“It doesn’t matter. It’s fine the way it is,” Sara firmly told the two young women. “I don’t need magic.”

“But, you said… You told me it still hurts,” Adora protested weakly. “I feel like I could help.”

“I just need to fix my brace. I couldn't maintain it properly, that’s all.” There was no way Sara would let a Princess use fucking magic on her - not without a fight. “I just need some parts for it and to get the sand out. I’ll get it to work fine.”

“What’s the problem with your leg, anyway?” Catra asked curiously. "Felina said it was a pretty bad injury?"

Derrick made a noise in his throat. "You could say that," he growled. "I still don't know how she's even walking, let alone being on the move all day. At first, medics said she’d never get approved to go back to field duty. She and a couple of the medics came up with a solution. I have no idea how they managed it."

Sara looked down at her hand where she still was pulling up bits of grass, not wanting to meet anyone’s eye. The medic’s original

prognosis (that Derrick never heard) was that Sara would never be able to regain enough function in her legs to be assigned to *any* duty. She had thought the absence of pain (or any feeling, really) in her legs and feet had been a good sign when Derrick dragged her out of that tank. It turned out it meant nerve damage.

Fortunately for her, some of the medics had been experimenting. They invited her to collaborate when they discovered she was a good comms/electronics specialist. It took them a little while, but they had modified the unauthorized design schematics to help her and a few other volunteers. At the time, they rationalized that it was for the war effort, but no one was willing to ask for permission in case it was denied.

Sara hesitated, unsure how much trouble she was letting herself in for. "I saw one of Entrapta's blueprints that got… um- dropped in the hall."

Catra's eyes narrowed, and one eyebrow went up. "Dropped? In the hall?"

The electronics specialist and the medics paid ten days' rations, two electrical power supplies, and a reel of niobium wire for a copy of those blueprints. Looking up to meet Catra's eyes, she blandly affirmed, "Yes, ma'am."

The corner of the ambassador's mouth quirked up. "So, what did you do with the blueprints you 'found'?"

"We... I mean, *I* made some… Aaah… modifications to the brace they issued me. "

No one was sure why Entrapta would be so interested in armor that doubled as an assistive device. Still, the schematics were clear enough: a combination of magic and technology that potentially restored function to a broken body without losing agility or strength.

"Modifications?"

“Yes. I had to swap out some materials, and we… *I* used one of the power sources the design… um… specified.” Sara winced. Now, she admitted that she’d liberated a mini-bot’s special power source on top of illegally obtaining documents. "But, I never got it to work quite right.” Suddenly she was acutely aware of the everpresent pins and needles feeling in her feet that she could normally ignore.

Derrick scooted over to her and put his arm around her. She looked up at him and gave him a little smile and patted his hand reassuringly- if she got some time in the cooler for misuse of documents or something, at least they (probably) wouldn’t reassign her to a different squad when she got out, now that they were Official. She could also hopefully avoid mentioning the medics' unauthorized surgery and getting them in trouble.

Melog rubbed their face on her thigh and then chirped at Catra.

“Huh. Do you think it would help if Entrapta looked at it?”

Sara looked up to see Catra with her hand paused over her communicator, apparently ready to call the ruler of Dryl. “Entrapta?” Sara sputtered. “You-you want to have Entrapta look at it?”

“Is that okay with you?”

Today was definitely *a lot.*

They were waiting for her to say something, Sara realized abruptly. It would be smarter to refuse; Entrapta would see exactly what they’d done to make it work. There would be no hiding the fact that the power supply was embedded in Sara’s sacrum and that the brace was the only visible component in a network of fine wires and magical tech that held Sara together.

But for the chance to actually *talk* to Entrapta, Sara would risk it. “Yes. Yes! More than fine, it would be amazing! Thank you!"

“Entrapta?”

“Hi, Catra!” called the voice on the other end.

“Where are you?”

“I'm over at Scorpia's. Why?”

“I’ve got a soldier here who’s been modifying one of your designs, but it's giving her trouble. Can you look at it?”

“One of my designs? Really?” The voice sounded excited rather than angry. ”Which one? No. Never mind! I’ll be right over!”

“Here you go, ma’am.” Trevor held out a full plate of food to Adora. “Felina says she was able to get some vegetables and cooked them with some gray rations she cut up. Sorry, the cook tent didn’t have any meat today. Felina says you don’t care for foraged meat.”

“Thank you.” Adora looked over his shoulder at Felina’s far-too-neutral face and wondered if she would now have the reputation of being picky about her food. She felt her cheeks warm.

Trying not to dwell on it, she took a bite. “Oh, this *is* good,” she muttered, surprised that rations of any type could be made to taste like actual food. The bland bar’s texture changed with the cooking, and the addition of spices that must have been available in the cook tent took it beyond merely edible into the realm of tasty. “Felina’s a really good cook,” Adora said, smiling as well as she could at Trevor.

He grinned. “I’ll tell her you said so, ma’am.”

Adora nodded, not enlightening him that Felina probably heard the whole exchange.

It took only a few minutes for Trevor and Felina to pack up their stuff. Afterward, Catra said to Derrick and Sara, “It’s probably going to be a while before you two can requisition new quarters. Why don’t you take our tent? We won’t need it.”

Right now, Entrapta, Sara, and a hovering Derrick were in the tent so Entrapta could examine the brace and the modification of her design. Judging by a couple of happy squeals, it seemed Entrapta felt optimistic that she could fit Sara with better equipment.

Hunching over her meal, Adora tried to ignore the empty space in her gut that could not be filled with food. Sara's refusal to let She Ra try to help her was both expected and completely understandable. It didn't make it hurt any less.

Catra sat next to Adora with her own plate. "How're you doing? Ready to go home?"

Adora nodded her head. "Yes." She looked searchingly into Catra's eyes. "Are you sure you..?"

"Stop." Catra put her finger up to Adora's lips, smiling teasingly. "We had this conversation once today." She glanced around, leaned in to kiss her softly, and touched their foreheads together. "We should probably get going soon."

Felina definitely heard that. Although she didn't look at them, her tail stiffened, and her ears slanted down minutely. Adora nudged Catra, who followed her gaze.

"I see where Felina gets it from," Catra said quietly, smiling and shaking her head. " 'Dropped in the hallway.' Seriously?" Her grin turned wry. "I should have realized that as soon as those 'bots went into production, the engineers and the specialists were going to start experimenting. Entrapta's super excited about it." The smile faded as she looked back at Adora. "What's the matter?"

Not wanting to talk about it directly with Felina standing there, Adora said, "I wish I could do more."

The other woman sighed. "I know. But, look, we all have things we've done that we regret. Derrick said it. It was a war. People get hurt." She stopped and looked at Felina, whose tail was now firmly wrapped around her leg. "You can't fix everyone, and you probably shouldn't try."

“But, you talked Agatha into letting me help her, couldn’t you..?”

“ *No,”* Catra grunted. “It isn’t the same. I told you. That was some magical bullshit, and Melog insisted. Plus, Agatha's objections were a little less personal.” She put her arm around Adora’s waist and squeezed. “It doesn’t always have to be you.”

The Beginning

Chapter Summary

> Hordak finds a new project. Catra and Adora get ready to head to Bright Moon.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

“Can I help you?” Catra’s voice was cold. Both Trevor and Felina jumped, looking to see who she was addressing.

One of the clones currently in camp approached them from the road. “Catra?” he called stiffly. “Entrapta summoned me here.”

“Did she?” Catra hissed, her claws flexing in and out before she closed her eyes and seemed to stuff down her fury. “What for?” she gritted through clenched teeth.

The clone cleared his throat, feigning indifference to his own death, though his scent was sour with fear. “She told me she may have found an appropriate project to propose to the Council.” He put his hands behind his back and waited.

Belatedly Felina realized this wasn't just a random clone.

“What's he talking about?” whispered Trevor, hearing her sharp gasp. They were almost finished washing up from lunch. He handed her things to dry and pack.

“That’s Hordak,” she whispered back. “I didn’t know it was him. All of them even *smell* the same.”

“Hordak.” Trevor goggled at the clone. “Fuck me.”

Everyone who wasn’t an officer felt the same way the first time they saw him brought before the T&R Committee. That same

committee sentenced the former ruler of the Horde to thirty years of community service and remanded him to Entrapta's custody. They had not yet decided on what his first project should be.

"Entrapta is in the tent. Knock first," growled Catra.

Hordak nodded and walked past Felina and Trevor without so much as an acknowledgment as Catra watched him with narrowed eyes.

"We are never going to get out of here," she muttered, crossing her arms over her chest and sat down beside Adora again. "You don't mind if we hang out to see what they're thinking, do you?" she asked the blonde woman.

"Good plan," Adora whispered back.

"We're going to be here a minute," she said to Felina. "You two are dismissed as soon as you finish. You can wait around for Sara and Derrick if you like.

Felina smiled, knowing Cata's next words.

"But if you're going to stay, come sit with us."

Once they were done, Trevor sat cross-legged on the ground near Adora, and Felina sat on the other log. Catra kept watching the tent, and the scent of anxiety wafted from both women. The tent was too far away for them to hear anything clearly over the daytime noise of the camp. Entrapta's voice carried but the words were too faint to make out.

"Excuse me, ma'am?" Trevor said politely to Adora.

The woman pasted on that smarmy smile she had. "Yes?"

"Can I ask you something?"

"Sure," Adora chirped.

“Who’s Kyle?”

Adora looked baffled, but Catra snickered. “You don’t remember that do you? You wanted to introduce us, but you couldn’t remember his name.” She bumped Adora’s shoulder with her own. “Not that it mattered. We met earlier.”

“Ah! Stop!”

The high pitched cry from the tent had Catra, Adora, and Felina jumping to their feet, but Catra put up a hand to prevent Adora and Felina from following. “Stay put. Let me check it out.”

“Sorry!" Entrapta apologized, loud enough to be heard clearly. “Did that hurt? Oooh. I’m sorry.”

Waiting until Catra was inside, Felina drifted closer. Close enough to hear what was happening, far enough away that it wasn’t completely obvious. She felt Adora and Trevor move with her, but she didn’t care what they thought.

"Okay, let me try that again. Careful, now. Sharp or dull?" Entrapta asked.

"Sharp." That was Sara’s voice. “Dull. But radiates all the way up to my hip. Dull. Dull. Sharp. ”

"Very well," Hordak said, "what about these?"

"Sharp. Very sharp! Ow!" Sara yelped.

"Hey, be careful, " Catra growled. "That's still attached to her, you know."

"My… apologies."

"Note: the afferent signals from the right tibial, calcaneus, and peroneal nerves appear to be overactive.” Entrapta sounded as though she were recording, but then her voice changed. “Have you tried dialing down the sensors?"

"Yes, ma'am," Sara told her, sounding both tired and frustrated. "We tried that, but then I couldn't feel the foot at all.”

"The circuitry wasn't meant for a nervous system as delicate as this." That was Hordak. "But who created this? This cannot be Entrapta's work.”

“It-it’s my work,” Sara replied quietly.

"Yours?" Hordak burst out, sounding shocked.

"Mine and some others," Sara admitted.

"Why did I never hear of this?"

"Maybe because you and fucking Shadow Weaver did your best to kill anything that resembled independent thought," Catra scoffed.

"The *designs* were Entrapta’s," Sara began.

“You mean the ones that fell on the floor?” The ambassador’s dry tone was hard to interpret. Felina felt as though she was missing half the conversation because she couldn't see anyone’s expression or read their scent signals.

“Oh no," Entrapta burbled excitedly. "This looks like the design I showed to the medics. I was looking for materials for Hordak’s armor. They were so interested that I made copies and sent them some of my research.”

Catra choked. “You what?”

“Yes! They were specifically interested in the ability to compensate for the loss of biological function, using the First One’s crystal interfaces to power….”

“Stop. Stop,” Catra cut her off. “So, you’re saying that your research on First One Tech got passed to the *medics* ?”

“Yes! And some of the specialists and engineers,” she affirmed. “They were very supportive!”

“Holy shit. I spent fucking *weeks* looking,” grumbled Catra. “Fuck,” she whispered.

"Entrapta," Hordak spoke slowly as though carefully choosing his words. "This is an interesting problem, but I do not understand how mending this woman's device will impress the council at all."

"It's not just her,” Derrick rumbled. “A lot of people need this kind of help.”

"I do not understand."

“You. Don’t. Understand?!” Catra snapped, making Felina jump. “Do you even have the vaguest clue about our casualty counts? Did you ever even *look* at any of the fucking reports?”

“I…”

“Entrapta? How many people got permanently removed from regular duty in the last year before Prime invaded?”

“Hang on.” The sound of Entrapta hitting keys. “Here. This many.”

“Multiply that by the number of years you spent waging this stupid war,” Catra snarled.

“Oooooh. That would be an undercount,” Entrapta said. For the first time, she sounded almost somber. “The casualty rate went way down once Catra sent ‘bots against the Princesses,” she muttered. “For a better estimate, I need to take that variable into account.” Tapping as she plugged the numbers in. After a second, the woman gulped, “That… that’s a lot of casualties.” Her voice trailed off. “It… It’s just a rough estimate. There’s a margin for error.”

A long silence followed. Distantly, Felina noticed that Trevor had come up on one side of her and Adora on the other.

"So, what do you think?" Entrapta asked, sounding nervous.

“So many… “ Hordak breathed. “Many of them may be good candidates for this technology,” he continued sounding more matter-of-fact. “But I do not know what the criteria might be. This was meant to treat… mmm… genetic defects.”

“We won’t know unless we try. Sara and her friends did a great job of adapting it to her,” Entrapta argued. “But it’s possible that the pain is coming from an inflammatory cascade caused by the foreign implants. I bet if we studied the chips, I could figure out how to integrate them more efficiently.”

“This could be the work of a lifetime.”

“In that case, I think it’s a great idea,” Catra said briskly. “Pitch it to Scorpia and the T&R committee tomorrow. I’ll call Scorpia and give her my vote.”

Entrapta squeaked and then began to speak rapidly. “Sara? Can you explain exactly where you departed from the original and why? Also, I’d like to take some readings on your interface between electronic components and your efferent nerve impulses. And then maybe you’ll let me….”

“Whoa! Entrapta!” Catra cut her off. “Maybe Sara doesn’t want to b a fucking test subject. Calm down.”

“Sorry. I got excited.”

“Sara, what do you want?” Catra asked slowly. “Do you want to work with Entrapta? It’s fine if you don’t.”

“As a *test* subject?” Derrick croaked, sounding scandalized.

“Oh, no. Of course not,” Entrapta assured him. “Oh. Well. Not primarily,” the off-blue-haired inventor contradicted herself brightly. “Obviously, we need to test the new equipment we configure for her. But she did such a great job on these. I think it would be fun to see what we can do together.“

“It-it wasn’t just me,” Sara objected faintly.

“You know who worked with you on this. Maybe you could put together a team to help Entrapta?”

“M-ma’am?”

Filena wished she could see the look on her mom’s face. She remembered when Sara had been rehabbing her leg. For weeks she had obsessively tinkered with the brace.

Trevor nudged Felina. “Hey. What are they saying? Why is Hordak here?”

“Shh!” hissed Felina. “I think they want my mom to help with a project.”

“Yep,” Entrapta sang out. “That would be great!” Felina had missed the question.

“Okay, good,” Catra sighed. “Anyway, I have to go. Adora and I need to head out if we’re going to get there by nightfall.”

The words were a hammer blow to Felina’s chest. While the group in the tent said their goodbyes, she walked back over to the fire pit so it wouldn’t be so obvious she had been listening. She turned away from everyone and busied herself with the luggage.

“Hey, Felina?” Catra came up behind the girl as she ensured the small packs were properly secured.

She flinched, not because Catra startled her, but because of the tears that trickled down her face. Impatiently, she wiped the tears, but she couldn't hide the salt smell from Catra. “Yes, ma’am?” she asked thickly.

A hand rested on her shoulder and slowly guided her to turn around. “Are you okay?” Her former CO looked down at her with concern.

“Yes, ma’am.” Felina sniffed, trying to pull herself together. “I just…” her voice fell to a whisper. “Never mind.” The girl shrugged, trying to sound casual, but failing. “Oh… I almost forgot.” She cleared her throat and pulled the comlink off her sleeve. “I-I guess you’ll need this back.” She held it out. “I probably won’t need it for whatever my next assignment is.”

“No, you should keep it. You’ll need it if you accept your appointment to officer’s training.” Catra pointed out. “I mean, if you don’t want it, that’s fine too.“

Felina froze, looking up into her eyes. “You…you mean it? You really do want me to be an officer?” When Catra casually tossed the little badge to her, she thought it was just the only communicator her new CO could find. Usually, Felina kept it in her pocket or pinned inside her sleeve, so folks didn’t get the wrong idea and think she was impersonating an officer (or officer cadet).

“Yes. I think you’d make a great officer.” Catra put both hands on her shoulders. “I told you this. You, Mike, and Lee will be the *best* in a few years.” She smiled lopsidedly. “I already cleared it with Scorpia. But, I guess I forgot to mention it.” She shook her head ruefully. “Sorry. There’s been a lot going on. I guess I should do it all official and shit, so there’s no confusion.” she finished, as if to herself.

“Ma’am?”

“You do want to be an officer, right? You’ll spend longer as a cadet and probably get stuck taking a ton of boring classes, you know.”

Want to be an officer? Felina had wanted to be an officer since she’d been old enough to want anything. Even after she understood that Shadow Weaver would never promote someone like her to officer’s training, she’d longed for it, impossible though it seemed. Before Prime's invasion, Catra’s rise to Second had revived all those old dreams. “Yes, ma’am!”

Catra took the little insignia from Felina's still-outstretched hand. "Felina, I hereby promote you to officer cadet." Carefully, so as not to stick Felina with the sharp end, she pinned the badge to her shirt and then saluted.

Felina saluted back with a shaking hand. Melog appeared and bumped their head against the girl's leg. They made a soft chirp that she was pretty sure meant something like "good job" or "well done." They said it frequently to Catra.

"That is amazing! Congratulations!" Trevor exclaimed. "I wasn't sure if I should ask since it wasn't pinned properly." He backed up and ran his hand through his hair. "No, no! Wait. Let me be the first to do this," he said, grinning. He drew himself up to attention and saluted her crisply. "Officer Cadet Felina. Second Gunner Trevor, reporting." He held the salute, waiting.

She giggled before she returned the salute. "As you were, Second Gunner Trevor." No one had asked her about the badge this morning, although she knew they saw it. Now it was in the proper place on her uniform, and it was clear it was not just a random make-do.

"Congratulations!" Sara came up to her side, wrapping her arms around Felina's shoulders.

"Ha!" Derrick came up beside both of them. "Permission to hug the officer and pick her up off the ground?"

Felina giggled again as she nodded.

"CONGRATULATIONS!" He whooped as he picked both her and her mom up off the ground in a crushing embrace. He spun them once before he dropped them to the ground.

"Catra? We should go." Adora stood ready beside Melog with their bags. "And Felina? Congratulations. I know you'll do well."

Stiffly, Felina nodded in acknowledgment. "Thank you, ma'am."

“You take care of yourself, Adora,” Sara said.

“Come back for a drink sometime!” Trevor said, laughing.

The blonde woman grinned and gave them a friendly wave.

Studying Felina, Catra smiled to show both her fangs. “Can I give you a hug?” she asked softly.

The newly minted officer cadet nodded, grinning so hard her face hurt. Catra leaned down and wrapped her arms around the girl. About half a head shorter, Felina held her around the woman’s waist and buried her face in Catra’s shoulder. Melog leaned on both of them, and the three purred in time.

“Help Derrick take care of your mom, okay?” Catra told Felina, whispering into her ear. “Remind her that most people need to eat and sleep once in a while. If she’s going to be working with Entrapta, she’ll need it. If you think you need me, don't be afraid to call. Your commlink is approved to contact me directly." She ended the embrace by stepping back and giving the girl’s ear a scratch. “And, promise me you won’t go taking on Princesses all by yourself anymore.”

Catra’s voice was very rough. If Felina didn’t know better, she would think those bright, mismatched eyes shone with tears.

Chapter End Notes

> Felina describes Entrapta's hair as "off-blue" because like Catra she has feline colorblindness. She sees purple as kind of a drab blue-ish color.

Epilogue: Bright Moon

Chapter Summary

Adora and Catra arrive at Bright Moon.

Melog had offered to take both Catra and Adora to Bright Moon on their back, but at the last minute, Catra and Adora decided to take Scorpia up on her offer of a skiff. Adora piloted it while Catra opted to sit in the bow, chatting quietly with Melog for most of the trip.

The Whispering Woods were more cooperative than Adora had ever seen them, the road from the edge of the wood wide and clear, filled with traffic in both directions. People had been streaming back to the city since their victory. The cleanup and rebuilding had already started.

The Moonstone came into sight over the trees, and Adora felt her heart leap as if she were seeing the place for the first time. Her mood had been a little sad when they left Spire. For the whole trip, she was lost in thought as she piloted the skiff. but now her heart lifted as the familiar skyline came into sight. The palace gleamed more brightly than ever.

Best of all, this time, Catra was with her. Not as a prisoner, an enemy combatant, or commanding a hostile force but as the appointed ambassador of the newly named Etherian Horde Republic to the Princess Alliance. Adora glanced over at her girlfriend, who had been sitting with her arm around Melog but stood up as the shining tower came into view. The other woman's face was impassive, but Melog's mane roiled and turned a little darker. The creature mewed questioningly.

"I've only been here once. During the Battle of Bright Moon." Catra's voice was almost inaudible. "We took *a lot* of casualties that day."

At the word "casualties," Adora's heart seemed to seize up, a clear vision in her mind of how the Princess's magic had scattered armored soldiers and overturned tanks. Angella had allowed Catra's force to limp away without further violence, overruling Glimmer's initial impulse to give chase. "Catra… I…" During the celebration that night, Adora never thought about the fact that the injured Catra had to be dragged away by Scorpia.

Why had she never considered that before? Why had the prospect of killing and maiming *her own people* never upset her? Thaymore had made her want to defect because of the damage to the civilians, but she had never even had a moment of concern for the people she had once fought with and sworn allegiance to. People with no choice except to follow the orders they were given.

The smaller woman shook herself and reached out to take Adora's free hand. "No. Don't. I wasn't trying to… It's okay… " She threw a cautious smile at her girlfriend. "I just… I mean, it's going to be weird, right? No matter what we do." She glanced at the great cat beside her. "Melog was asking. That's all."

Adora squeezed Catra's hand.

"When were you here last?" Catra asked softly.

"At the beginning of Prime's invasion," Adora replied. She had been carrying one end of a stretcher. "Bright Moon got taken early on. Bow and I made it back here, and Micah had already called for an evacuation. Prime was targeting Bright Moon in particular."

For some reason, Adora did not want to tell Catra that Micah ordered her to oversee the fighters assigned to protect the healers as they evacuated the wounded. Maybe it was because it had been Shadow Weaver's idea. The woman had pointed out that since Adora had put She Ra beyond reach, it was the best use of her abilities. It had been sensible and practical, and someone needed to do it. Even so, it felt like a demotion.

"During the evacuation, the Princesses and sorcerers were the only ones to engage directly with Prime's forces. Everyone else was ordered to cover the retreating civilians," said Adora truthfully. "It was kind of bad." That battle had been the first one that Adora had ever been in that she felt truly afraid.

Their skiff drew curious looks as they drove through the city, but no hostility. A few other Horde-made vehicles were around, and the palace guard just gave them a cheerful wave as they passed through the gate into the courtyard.

Catra's hand was cold in hers as they made their way through the palace and her ears twitched back. Suddenly feeling awkward, Adora furtively watched for Catra's reaction, but her expression showed no emotion. Her ears and tail gave nothing away. Melog slunk along, their head low, their tail stuck out behind them, and their mane, although it stayed smooth, darkened to purple.

"Is there somewhere we should check in or something?" Catra finally asked as they wound their way through the hallways.

"Not really. Are you hungry? We can order dinner sent up, or we can go to the dining hall. They'll still be serving."

"Is it okay if it's just us tonight? I am so tired."

Nodding understandingly, the blonde replied, "Glimmer said she gave orders to the staff to make my room ready for us, and I already told her we were probably going to go straight to our room. There's not anything officially planned until tomorrow."

"Wait. Official?" Catra gave Adora a side-eye. "What official thing is planned for tomorrow?"

"There's going to be a reception."

"A reception? What's that?"

"Oh, it's like a party." Adora bit her lip and hesitated. "And there's going to be a ceremony," she admitted.

“A ceremony?” Catra crossed her arms over her chest, one eyebrow going up.

“Yeah, just a little one, y’know… Glimmer wants to do a formal court thing to announce that She Ra is back.”

Catra shook her head. “And here I thought we were done with all that nonsense after the signing.” She brightened. “But, hey, I’m just an ambassador. I could skip out of it, right?”

Adora suddenly seemed terribly interested in the murals on the walls. “Ah… no. Glimmer says you have to come.” Those gray-blue eyes flicked towards Catra for a second, then stared resolutely ahead. “The other thing is that she wants you presented formally at her court because she wants to make sure folks understand that the war really is over.”

“And that they probably shouldn’t nail my hide to the wall?” Catra growled softly.

“Yeah. Pretty much.”

“Okay, fine.” She sighed. “I guess I understand.”.

They were both quiet, and the silence between them started to feel awkward as they walked through the bustling public parts of the castle. A few of the castle denizens they passed gave them friendly nods, but no one stopped to talk.

They passed by the dining hall where, by the noise, a party was already in full swing, but they didn’t go in.

“So, are you happy to be back here?” Catra asked when they finally came to the empty corridor that led to the castle’s private residences.

“Yes! Of course!” Adora replied a little too quickly and a little too loudly.

“What?.

Adora felt her shoulders hunch. “I… I guess I’m just worried. That’s all. Everything’s so different.” She blew her breath out, then said more softly, “What if nobody needs She Ra anymore?”

“Trust you to be worried that you won't have enough work to do.” Catra snarked, although her tone was almost gentle. "Hey,” the shorter woman put her arm around Adora’s waist. “It'll be okay.”

“This is it.” Adora stopped in front of the familiar door. “Glimmer used to be next door, but she took over Angella’s room after her coronation….” She broke off.

“Angella? That was her mom’s name?” Catra said softly. “I never knew.”

Cursing herself, Adora wished she had kept her stupid mouth shut. She wanted tonight to go well, and that sort of conversation would not lead them anywhere good.

“I beg your pardon, Adora?” a hesitant voice called from down the hall.

“Yes?” Grateful for the interruption, Adora turned to see one of the castle staff hurrying towards them. A stout gray-haired woman, she had been taking care of the rooms on this corridor for as long as Adora had lived at Bright Moon.

“I aired out your room and put clean sheets on the beds. Do you want me to have someone bring up your supper?”

“Please. That would be great. For three.” Adora indicated herself, Catra, and Melog. The woman nodded briskly.

“We tidied up the mess in there, and I don’t think too much was broken. We left it all on the desk so you could decide where to put it.”

“Thank you.”

The woman hurried away.

“Who was that?” Catra asked.

“She… that was… “ To Adora’s horror, she realized that the woman had been cleaning up after her for the better part of three years and she had no clue what the woman’s name was. “She’s one of the castle staff.” To save herself more embarrassment, she put her hand on the doorknob and opened the door. Two steps into the room, Adora realized Catra had stopped moving.

“Wow,” Catra said quietly. “This is… a lot.” Slowly, her movements careful, as if she feared breaking something, she turned and closed the door with a soft click.

The room didn’t quite look the same as when Adora had fled. Most of the textiles must have been beyond repair because the drapes and cushions were almost all new, although they were pretty similar to what was there. Instead of pinned up on her canopy or stacked on the shelves, her papers were in neat piles on her desk.

Two beds were positioned beneath two fluttering canopies. One was the firm cot Angella had ordered for Adora when she first arrived. The other was the traditional Bright Moon feather mattress. Each was piled high with new pillows (although Adora only ever used one) and soft blankets. The windows and doors to the balcony were all open to let in the breeze. The crystal ornaments caught the last rays of the evening, and little rainbows flashed around the room. The waterfall chuckled, and *oh* , it was so good to be here.

“Welcome home?” Adora had practiced this moment in her head hundreds of times, and she winced when the words came out questioning rather than confident. Anxiously, she waited for Catra’s reaction, twisting her fingers around each other.

Melog’s mane was a smooth, cool blue, and they began to slink around, exploring, so Catra probably wasn’t upset, but she seemed almost in shock as she gazed at the high ceiling and soft furnishings.

“It’s, um, sort of just a basic Bright Moon bedroom,” Adora said quickly. “It’s, uh, got a vanity and a bathroom.” She pointed. “Crystals, bell pull, tea nook, more crystals, bed. Well, beds. My desk, and of course, the waterfall.”

“Waterfall?” Catra stared at it blankly, then turned back to Adora. “So, what’s that for? Showering?”

A nervous giggle emerged from Adora’s throat. She couldn’t help it. She had the sudden memory of asking Glimmer the very same thing. “What?” Catra asked, confused.

The giggle erupted into full-on laughter, and Adora could not explain. She couldn’t even speak around the laughter.

“Welp. It looks like Adora’s finally lost it, Catra remarked dryly to Melog, who had ceased their prowling to look quizzically at her. “We’re going to have to tell Sparkles we broke her.”

When she first came to Bright Moon, Adora spent probably six months wondering what Catra would think of the place. Every time Glimmer or Bow showed her something that Catra would like (or even better, mock wholeheartedly), she felt a sharp pang in her heart. She had wanted to go back for Catra. A dozen times, she’d packed a bag, hoping that if they could have a proper conversation, If she could just explain, Catra would run away with her.

Every single time, something happened to stop her. A mission, or a crisis, or… Or she simply *didn’t* . As if she couldn’t make herself think through all the steps somehow. It had never occurred to Adora before this. The very next time she and Catra were able to talk was when they met at the temple. When Light Hope was fucking with them, trying to make her ‘let go." The best Adora could come up with in that conversation was, “I know you’re not a bad person.” Damning with faint praise. After that, there just seemed no point.

Even after she had lived there for three years, apart from hanging her maps and battle plans, she never changed anything, always feeling like she was just a visitor, wondering why she could never quite feel like this was her home. Now, the answer stood beside her, and Adora wanted to cry. No, she *was* crying, tears sliding down her cheeks.

"You okay?" Catra came closer, seeing the tears and hearing the laughter turn into little hiccuping sobs.

"I'm okay," Adora gasped, clutching at her girlfriend. "I'm just… I just need a minute." It was so good to be back.

"Hey, hey." Catra wrapped her arms around Adora's waist. "What's going on?"

"I missed you." Adora tucked her face into Catra's shoulder. Now she was crying in earnest. They weren't bad tears, but she did not know how to convey that to her girlfriend. "I missed you *so much."*

"I'm right here, dummy." Catra petted down Adora's back. "I'm not going anywhere." She paused and added, "not unless you tell me to."

"Promise?"

"I promise."

End.

This story continues in "Casting Out Shadows."

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